



Hindustan Times

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Panel backs law for DGCA facelift with safety in focus

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NEW DELHI: India's aviation regulator should be converted into an independent authority, created by a new law and with its own money and its own hiring, according to a proposal submitted to the government. The regulator has nearly half its posts vacant, a parliamentary panel has faulted it for "systemic" safety failures, and critics have accused it of bending its own rules last year during the IndiGo operational meltdown.

The report, submitted to the ministry of civil aviation (MoCA) and seen by HT, recommends replacing the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) with a statutory Civil Aviation Authority of India (CAA).

The new body would have a governing board, a dedicated aviation safety fund and control over recruitment, pay and spending. Part of the cost would fall on passengers, through a levy on every departure that a study cited in the report puts at ₹15, the proposal states.

The report is by a special committee headed by former economic advisor Lalit Kumar

What the panel proposes

A new regulator
● DGCA be converted into a statutory Civil Aviation Authority of India, created by an act of Parliament
● Board headed by DG (civil aviation): Whole-time members from the DGCA, part-time from the industry

Passenger grievances

An independent ombudsman for cancellations, delays and lost luggage

Funding

- An Aviation Safety Fund, also fed by fees and penalties, to pay for staff and oversight
- Audited every year by the CAG

A charge on flyers

A levy on every departing passenger; the report backs ₹15, from a ministry study, with the board setting the final rate



NEXT STEPS
Recommendations only; a law must be drafted and passed first

Stopgap measures for the DGCA until then

Chandel and with all joint directors general as the other members. It was constituted in August 2025; it submitted its report in November.

The committee wants it set up "as a statutory body with adequate administrative and financial autonomy through legislation". "Accordingly, a bill

for introduction in the Parliament to be prepared in consultation with the ministry of law & justice," the report said.

A person aware of the matter said the report is now with the ministry and some discussions have been held over it.

"The restructuring of the DGCA into an autonomous

authority will strengthen regulatory capacity, close safety gaps, and secure India's position as a global aviation leader. Immediate short-term reforms -- recruitment, digital upgrades, stakeholder engagement -- and longer-term legislative measures should be mapped and tracked with a clear implementation timeline. Periodic assessments based on international best practices and statutory review will ensure continued effectiveness and institutional growth," the official told HT, asking not to be named.

A second official said the report followed a direction from the ministry's top bureaucrat. "The report was made after the secretary (of MoCA) ordered to come up with a short / mid- and long-term restructuring plan considering the present and future development of aviation in the country," the official said.

The committee's diagnosis is blunt. As an attached office of MoCA, the report says, DGCA has limited operational independence, and its dependence on budgetary allocations can hold back recruitment of specialised talent and investment in technology.

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'Averted a 9/11-style tragedy': Modi lauds Capt Machchhar

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NEW DELHI/MUMBAI: Smit Machchhar, the Indian captain allegedly stabbed by his co-pilot on a flydubai flight to Tel Aviv, was moved from Saudi Arabia to a hospital in the United Arab Emirates on Thursday, as Prime Minister Narendra Modi said he had averted a "9/11-style tragedy" and leaders in India and Israel praised his courage.

Machchhar, 40, who was seriously wounded in Wednesday's attack, is "in good health and recovering well", India's ambassador to the UAE, Deepak Mittal, said after visiting him and his family in hospital.

"Very reassured to meet Capt Smit. Thank the UAE govern-

Machchhar taken to Abu Dhabi

Capt Smit Machchhar airlifted to Abu Dhabi after initial treatment in Saudi

His condition is stable, according to India's ambassador to UAE who met the Indian national and his family

"He was talking, smiling and laughing, which was a huge relief for us..."

— DEEPAK MITTAL, India's ambassador to UAE



PTI

ment for their support and medical care being extended," Mittal said in a post on X.

Despite his wounds, Machchhar unlocked the cockpit door of flight FZ-1073, allowing passengers and crew to overpower the attacker. A reserve

crew on board then flew the Boeing 737 MAX 8, carrying 174 people, to an emergency landing at Tabuk in north-western Saudi Arabia.

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→GOVT TO DELIBERATE ADVISORY FOR AIRLINES AFTER ATTACK ON PILOT P2

IRAN MAY BE LINKED TO STABBING, CRASH ATTEMPT: TRUMP

President Donald Trump said Thursday that Iran may be linked to the flydubai co-pilot who tried to crash an Israel-bound plane as investigators worked to determine why the co-pilot stabbed the flight's captain, causing the plane to plummet before others on board landed it in Saudi Arabia. Trump was asked by reporters at the White House whether he had been briefed about any links between the pilot behind the attack and Tehran. "I would say the answer, based on what I'm hearing, is yes..." Trump said. Asked if the US would retaliate against Tehran if it was behind the attack, Trump said, "Oh they'll be hit, very hard, don't worry."

AP



A choke point on Barapullah after a new spur from Mayur Vihar was opened.

HT PHOTO

SC ORDERS STATES TO FREEZE VEHICLE SERVICES OVER TRAFFIC FINES

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has directed states and UTs to freeze online and other vehicle-related services, including renewal of registration, issuance of fitness and PUC certificates, ownership transfers and even renewal of driving licences, where traffic fines remain unpaid, as part of a nationwide push to make electronic enforcement of road-safety laws more effective. →P7



People try to resuscitate students at a beach in Raigad district of Maharashtra.

PICNIC TURNS INTO TRAGEDY AS EIGHT TEENS DROWN OFF BEACH IN RAIGAD

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MUMBAI: Eight 16-year-old students of a private coaching institute in Pune drowned in the Arabian Sea while on a picnic at the Diveagar beach in Raigad district of Maharashtra on Thursday, police said.

Officers aware of the details said the victims, part of a group of 48 students who had gone on the picnic, ventured into the sea and were swept away after misjudging the depth of the water and current. Search and rescue teams rushed to the spot following an alert and recovered the bodies, they said. →P8

SABARIMALA: JUSTICE NAGARATHNA FIRST SC JUDGE TO START WRITING VERDICT

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NEW DELHI: Justice BV Nagarathna has become the first judge on the nine-member Constitution bench to start writing the judgment in the Sabarimala reference, setting the stage for a verdict that could redefine the Supreme Court's approach to religious freedom, judicial review and the "essential religious practices" doctrine. →P8

DELHI EASES CURBS ON ORNAMENTAL PARK USE AHEAD OF FESTIVE SEASON

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NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has relaxed its blanket ban on booking ornamental parks for socio-religious functions, allowing parks used continuously for such events for at least five years to be considered as venues. The move comes ahead of the festive season, when many such parks host Rameleas.

SC declines ONOE panel's informal interaction invite

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court administration on Thursday declined a proposal from a parliamentary panel, examining bills aimed at rolling out simultaneous elections, to interact with Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and other sitting judges, with the court's secretary general informing the committee that the proposed constitutional amendments could eventually be subject to judicial review.

People aware of the matter said that the apex court secretary general's office, in a communication sent to the joint committee of Parliament on Thursday afternoon, stated that the proposal for an informal discussion with the CJI and other judges on simultaneous elections was discussed among the Supreme Court's senior judges.

The communication, people cited above said, stated that as

SC SECRETARY GENERAL SAID IT MAY NOT BE DESIRABLE TO DISCUSS ISSUE ON ADMIN SIDE AS PROPOSED CHANGES MAY UNDERGO JUDICIAL REVIEW

the proposed amendment might become a subject of judicial review before the Supreme Court, it may not be expedient or desirable to discuss the issue on the administrative side. The proposed meeting was accordingly "cancelled".

The decision followed a discussion between CJI Surya Kant and some senior judges, after which the CJI directed that the proposed interaction should not proceed, the people cited above said.

The joint committee chairman and Bharatiya Janata Party member PP Chaudhary told

news agency PTI that the visit was put off as the dates of committee members did not match. "I also have other commitments to attend to," he told the agency.

The communication from the secretary general's office came even as earlier in the day, independent Rajya Sabha member and senior advocate Kapil Sibal publicly objected to the proposed visit, describing it as "unconstitutional" and contrary to the principle of separation of powers.

The joint committee, headed by Chaudhary, had proposed a visit to the Supreme Court on October 6 as part of its consultations on the Constitution (One Hundred and Twenty-Ninth Amendment) Bill, 2024 and the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2024. The programme described the visit as a "local study visit" and proposed an informal discussion with the CJI and other judges on

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→LISTING ROW: CJI SPOKE TO JUDGES BEFORE CLUBBING CAPF CASES P6



India's Nitesh Siwach poses with his silver medal along with national coach Hargobind Singh, in Nagoya on Thursday.

PTI

Siwach grapples his way into history with Greco-Roman silver

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NEW DELHI: Back in 2015, when Nitesh Siwach was at home at Jagsi village in Haryana's Sonapat, he would hop on to his father's motorbike and set off before dawn daily to deliver milk. It wouldn't be a significant nugget until you know that Nitesh, then barely 12 and hardly strong enough to control the vehicle — never mind being under-age to ride — was still recovering from a knee surgery that would keep him out of sports for two years.

"We didn't have enough resour-

ces, so Nitesh decided to do his bit. Today, he is reaping the rewards for all the hard work. He has had a tough life," said Nitesh's father Anand, who was a wrestler in his youth.

On Thursday, Nitesh became the first Indian since Ganpat Andalkar in 1962 Jakarta to reach an Asiad Greco Roman final. Nitesh though came up short against Japan's 2025 Asian Champion-

ships silver medalist Yuri Nakazato, losing the 97kg final 4-0. "You can say it was my dream to wrestle for the country. My son has fulfilled it for me," said Anand. →P13



ASIAN GAMES

BURNT BODIES OF TWO ASCETICS FOUND INSIDE U.P. TEMPLE, 1 HELD

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MEERUT: Two ascetics, aged 60 and 70, were allegedly killed and their bodies set on fire inside a temple in Shahjahanpur district of Uttar Pradesh, police said on Thursday, adding that a man has been detained for questioning over allegations that he wanted them to leave the shrine to establish control over it. →P7

{ POSTHUMOUS PRIZE }

Gola from SDA market wins by a landslide over Saket's Googoo in Delhi fat dog contest



Gola beat her competitor Googoo by nearly 40,000 votes with 94,000 people voting in the final.

not genuine. "It has come to the notice of this office that there are instances of filing of bulk applications in Form 7 before the EROs. It is also alleged that such forms are not genuine," the circular said. The CEO directed EROs to take action against applicants who knowingly make false statements or declarations in Forms 6, 6A, 7 and 8 under Section 31 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950. →P5

morestories

Cong, NCP (SP) to join Sena (UBT) stir on Oct 4 →P5

Over 4.4 mn sent 'incorrect info' notices in Hry SIR →P5

Plea for recall of order on CEC appointment junked →P5

36% OF J'KHAND NAME DELETION APPLICATIONS CAME FROM ONE SEAT

Roughly a third of the 13,000 applications received by the Jharkhand chief electoral officer (CEO) for deletion of names from the electoral roll came from a single assembly seat in the state, data showed on Thursday. Of the 13,443 applications received for name deletion, 4,790 entries were marked in the Chatra assembly constituency alone, accounting for about 36% of the total. The seat is held by Janardhan Paswan of LJP-R, who won by over 18,000 votes in the 2024 polls. Only two other districts received over a thousand Form 7 — including 1,906 applications in West Singhbhum and 1,099 forms in Deogarh. The names deletion applications in the remaining 21 districts are in three digits. →P5

88 OF 97 EXCLUDED GOA VOTERS BACK ON VOTER ROLL, SAYS CEO

The chief electoral officer (CEO) of Goa on Thursday confirmed that 88 out of 97 voters who were excluded from the final electoral roll following the special intensive revision exercise despite being eligible have been re-included as fresh voters after they submitted Form 6. The CEO's office in a statement said that of the remaining nine voters, three have been found to be Portuguese passport holders, while six are currently residing abroad. "In respect of the voters who are currently residing outside India, the concerned officials are making efforts to establish and maintain contact with them for further necessary action," the statement added. →P5

INDIA, PAK PLACED IN SAME GROUP, SET FOR ANOTHER CLASH AT ODI WC

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NEW DELHI: Along expected lines, India and Pakistan have been paired in Group A for the 2027 ODI World Cup to be held in South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia from October 2 - November 21. Afghanistan, Australia, Zimbabwe and Qualifier A are the other teams in India's group. Bangladesh, England, South Africa, Sri Lanka, New Zealand and Qualifier B are in Group B. India play their opener against defending champions Australia on October 7. →P14

{ MY INDIA } ANITA ANAND

Canada foreign min to reach India on Oct 12



Canadian foreign minister Anita Anand is expected to visit India in mid-October as part of ramped up contacts between the two countries that are racing to conclude negotiations on a trade deal by the year-end, people familiar with the matter said. New Delhi and Ottawa hope to finalise their negotiations for a comprehensive economic partnership agreement (CEPA) ahead of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's planned visit to Canada in December. Anand is expected to be in India during October 12-15 though the visit is yet to be formally announced by both sides, the people said on condition of anonymity. While in New Delhi, Anand is expected to hold talks with external affairs minister S Jaishankar to take stock of progress in implementing a roadmap for bilateral relations that was finalised during her last visit in October 2025, and preparations for Modi's visit to Canada, the people said.

{ BUSINESS } 15% RISE

GST revenue crosses ₹2 lakh crore in Sept



India's gross Goods and Services Tax (GST) revenue in September crossed ₹2 lakh crore, registering a 14.7% year-on-year increase, government data released on Thursday showed. Gross GST collections stood at ₹2,03,521 crore in September 2026, compared with ₹1,77,365 crore in September 2025. The collections reflect transactions undertaken in August. Net revenue after refunds surged 18.1% to ₹1,76,520 crore in September this year, from ₹1,49,517 crore in September 2025. Experts attributed the stronger growth in net revenue partly to comparatively lower refunds. Refunds in September 2026 stood at ₹27,001 crore, down 3% from ₹27,848 crore in the same month last year. They also pointed to the sharp rise in import-linked GST revenue compared with collections from domestic business activity.

{ BUSINESS } TWO OF INDIA'S LARGEST LENDERS

HDFC, Kotak Mahindra banks appoint new CEOs



HDFC Bank and Kotak Mahindra Bank are set for new chief executives after the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) approved the appointments of Anup Bagchi (left) and Anup Kumar Saha, respectively, for three-year terms. Bagchi, 56, was widely seen as the top contender for the post, alongside internal candidate Kaizad M Bharucha. For Bagchi, whose term begins on October 27, the appointment marks a return to banking after three years in insurance. The appointment is also the second instance in recent years of an insurance executive being brought in to lead a bank. In 2019, Amitabh Chaudhry joined Axis Bank as chief executive from HDFC Life Insurance Company. Saha, whose term will begin on January 27, joined Kotak nine months ago and has been overseeing its retail bank, data analytics and marketing functions. The bank said its board of directors will take further steps to formalise Saha's appointment and seek shareholders' approval.

{ MY INDIA } HAWALA FUNDING

Yasin Malik, 6 others face PMLA charges



A special NIA court has ordered framing of money laundering charges against jailed Jammu & Kashmir Liberation Front (JKLF) chief Yasin Malik and six others for allegedly routing Pakistani and foreign funds through hawala channels to "finance secessionist activities in J&K". In an order passed on September 9 and made available on Thursday, the court held that sufficient material existed to raise a "strong suspicion" against all seven accused for an offence under Section 3 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). According to the Enforcement Directorate, the criminal activities under investigation generated proceeds of crime totalling ₹8.94 crore. ED alleged that the money was subsequently received, transferred, concealed, possessed, acquired and used by the accused through different channels.

{ WORLD } GUV HALTS EXECUTIONS

US convict survives two lethal injections



Tennessee officials were unable to put Christa Gail Pike to death on Wednesday for a 1995 murder after administering two doses of a lethal drug. A death penalty expert said it was an unprecedented failure, and Tennessee Governor Bill Lee halted the one remaining execution for the rest of the year. Pike, 50, was alive and loudly snoring after the attempted lethal injection and taken by ambulance from the prison, her attorneys said. She was being treated at a hospital, but they said they hadn't been told about her condition. She had been scheduled for execution for the killing she committed at age 18 and would have been the first woman executed in Tennessee in over 200 years. Officials gave Pike two doses of pentobarbital, her attorneys said in court filings late Wednesday. Lee said that he has ordered "a comprehensive, third-party review to determine exactly what occurred".

Govt to deliberate advisory for airlines after attack on pilot

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NEW DELHI: The government will hold international deliberations to assess whether an advisory needs to be issued to Indian airlines following an incident in which an Indian pilot was stabbed by his co-pilot onboard a flydubai flight, civil aviation secretary Samir Kumar Sinha said on Thursday.

"This is an unfortunate incident but the nation is very proud of the fact that Capt Smit (Machchhar), an Indian, was able to save lives... (Discussions on whether an advisory should be issued) is under examination. We will sit and thereafter, we will discuss some security issues. We are examining this particular matter and maybe if some advisory is to be issued (to the airlines), we will put it to higher authorities for taking a decision in the matter... We will be able to answer more on the case once we have done our internal deliberations," Sinha said.

He added, "We would not like to delve into this (the incident in particular) because this is pertaining to some other country and it, of course, would be examined."

The incident involved a co-pilot of a flydubai flight enroute to Tel Aviv allegedly attempting to take control of the aircraft on Wednesday. The attempt was foiled by Indian pilot Capt Smit Machchhar, the pilot-in-command, who suffered serious injuries while trying to subdue the co-pilot.

Flydubai flight FZ1073, a Boe-

CAPT SMIT WAS STABBED DURING A STRUGGLE THAT SENT THE FLYDUBAI FLIGHT PLUNGING 14,300 FEET IN ABOUT 30 SECONDS

ing 737 MAX 8 carrying 174 passengers, plunged 14,300ft in about 30 seconds over northern Saudi Arabia, before landing safely at Prince Sultan Bin Abdulaziz Airport in Tabuk. Two flydubai pilots travelling as passengers took control of the aircraft after Capt Machchhar reportedly managed to open the cockpit door.

Machchhar, according to a statement by the ministry of external affairs, was moved to Abu Dhabi on Thursday after receiving initial treatment in Saudi Arabia.

It is believed that Machchhar was stabbed with a crash axe, an emergency tool usually located behind the pilot-in-command's seat and designed to be readily accessible. "He might have gotten an axe from the equipment that might be standard on this aeroplane," Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu told Fox News. He added, "We're looking into that, we can't draw conclusions yet."

Officials said Capt Machchhar was stable and able to communicate on Thursday.

Flydubai, however, did not provide an update on the health status of the pilots or the investigation into the incident.

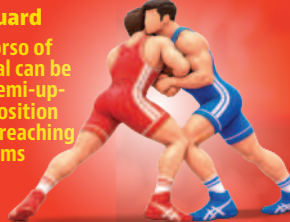


Greco-Roman vs freestyle: A clash of styles

Nitesh Siwach won silver on Thursday in Greco-Roman wrestling, a discipline in which India has not fared as successfully as in freestyle. Here's a look at how the two wrestling styles differ, from technique to scoring:

The Guard

Only torso of the rival can be held. Semi-upright position makes reaching with arms easier



The Guard

Keeping the torso horizontal can protect the wrestler's legs. Legs highly flexed



GRECO-ROMAN HOLD FREESTYLE

For a valid hold, the wrestler must be in contact with the opponent as he is tackled to the ground

While using a throw in freestyle, wrestlers can toss the opponent and regain contact with them as they hit the mat

TECHNIQUE

Strong upper body, explosive strength and grips play key roles. Wrestlers rely on headlocks, body locks, and arm drags to score

No restriction in the use of arms and legs for takedowns and throws. The use of legs and hips to seize control of opponent is allowed

SCORING

Scoring below the waist is not allowed. Grabbing the opponent's knees, thighs or legs or using leg trips also not allowed

Wrestlers can also score below the waist using their legs for both attacking and defensive moves. Women compete only in freestyle

TECHNICAL SUPERIORITY

When a wrestler takes an eight-point lead, he is awarded the bout on technical superiority

A lead of 10 points is required to seal victory in a bout via technical superiority

PENALTY FOR PASSIVITY

A passive wrestler is penalised one point and the opponent can choose between standing or par terre position where he gets the opponent down on his stomach on the mat

A passive wrestler is put on a 30-second activity clock. If neither scores in half-a-minute, the active wrestler is awarded a point

NOT AMONG INDIA'S FAVOURITES

India have won 65 medals in wrestling at the Asian Games, and only 11 of them came in Greco-Roman. The rest are all in freestyle category

On Thursday, 23-year-old Nitesh beat Mongolia's Gankhuyag Ganbaatar 9-0 to earn a victory by technical superiority in the Greco-Roman 97kg semi-finals, before losing to Japan's Yuri Nakazato in the final

India's Nitesh Siwach in action during his 97kg Greco-Roman quarter-final against Turkmenistan's Amanberdi Agamammedov at the Asian Games in Nagoya on Thursday. ANI

{ INDIA VS PAK AT ASIAN GAMES }

Familiar foes rekindle romance of hockey's great rivalry

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NEW DELHI: Relief.

That was the sentiment of most Indian hockey fans after the Harmanpreet Singh-led team escaped with a narrow 4-3 victory over Pakistan following Abhishek's goal 49 seconds from the hooter.

India vs Pakistan. This iconic clash carries a lot of weight: history, legacy, prestige and with a dash of enmity. But unfortunately, the contest has lost its competitive bite in recent years: reduced to one-sided matches and a rivalry that exists only in the name.

With the rise of Indian hockey and the decline of the game in Pakistan, there is no uncertainty about which team starts as favourite. India have not lost to their neighbours in a decade, with the last setback coming at the 2016 South Asian Games final in Guwahati. Since then, India have won 19 of the 22 matches, with two draws and one no-result.

But Thursday's Asian Games semi-final in Kakamigahara rekindled the romance of the rivalry, the volatile passion of South Asia's greatest sporting feud, the nostalgia-drenched

memory of an epic rivalry that once ruled world hockey. The teams once played three Olympic finals, one World Cup final, and nine Asian Games finals.

In a throwback moment on Thursday, former centre-forward Ashok Kumar immediately remembered the 1975 World Cup final at the Merdeka Stadium in Kuala Lumpur, where Pakistan captain Islahuddin Siddiqui walked up to him just moments before the start.

Standing opposite each other at the 50-yard line, Islahuddin made a request that captured the spirit and camaraderie of the era: "Ashok, gaana gao".

Ashok looked back in utter surprise, reminding his rival that the summit clash was about to start. But Islahuddin only laughed. Seeing his opponent's persistence,

Ashok straightened his hockey stick, rhythmically started beating it and sang the popular track *Jai Jai Shiv Shankar*. "That just showed how confident the two teams were back then," two-time World Cup winner Islahuddin had told this correspondent in an earlier interview. "There was mutual respect between the players too."

That 1975 final ended in



India's Rajinder Singh (in orange) vies for the ball during a men's semi-final hockey match between India and Pakistan at the ongoing 20th Asian Games in Japan on Thursday.

immortal glory for India. Ashok went on to score the winning goal — the most significant hit of his career — to give his team a momentous 2-1 victory, securing India's first and only World Cup crown.

In that golden era, hockey was the pre-eminent sport in South Asia with India and Pakistan standing as absolute masters of the game, winning almost everything on offer. Yet, off the field, the fierce competi-

tors shared an extraordinary bond.

"We shared a great relationship with some Pakistani players. We spent a lot of time together and also went for their weddings. Some of the players' mothers would come to receive us at the airport too," Ashok, son of Major Dhyani Chand, told HT.

Former India goalkeeper Ashish Ballal recalled how that camaraderie translated into a

unique off-pitch dynamic during the 1990s, anchored by shared Punjabi heritage.

"In our times, most of the Pakistani guys were friendly with our Punjabi players. Most of the Pakistani players used to hang around with our Punjabi players, listen to Punjabi music and get smashed in the evenings," Ballal told HT with a chuckle.

"The rapport was there. It was only on the ground that it

was very aggressive with Punjabi lingo at its best. After matches we would sit down in the evenings, chat and drink at times. The next morning on the ground, you'd become aggressive again because everybody wants to win."

Ballal confessed that non-Punjabi players like himself were initially offended by the colourful language thrown around during matches.

"One day, they got us all together and told us, 'Listen, even when we talk to our dads, we talk like this! It is a kind of fondness in our lingo.' Today, when I speak with my old teammates, it comes automatically."

On the pitch, though, the intensity was ferocious. Fights broke out, wrong-side tackles carried dangerous follow-throughs and both teams played with a wildly volatile unpredictability. But that aggression also brought out the excitement with moments of sheer magic of individual brilliance or at other times, mediocrity at its best.

Even as global dominance shifted towards European powerhouses and Australia in the 1990s and 2000s, individual stars kept the fixture spellbinding.

Pakistan boasted icons such as Shahbaz Ahmed, Sohail Abbas and Rehan Butt while India had wizards such as Par-

gat Singh, Dhanraj Pillay and Dilip Tirkey in their ranks.

At the 2010 World Cup in New Delhi, 16,000 fans packed the Major Dhyani Chand National Stadium, the only contest of the tournament that saw a full house.

Former India skipper Sardar Singh, who captained India during high-stakes battles including their gold medal win at the 2014 Incheon Asian Games, stressed that mental strength was paramount in these fixtures.

"Ninety per cent of the matches were won by teams which were mentally stronger," Sardar told HT.

"When I was captain in Incheon, the crowd was very negative, abused us while we walked back to the stadium at half-time. What is important is to control your mind, stay relaxed and focus on the plan given by the coaches."

Sardar fondly remembered playing alongside Pakistani stalwarts in the erstwhile Premier Hockey League (2005-2008), forging warm friendships with Shakeel Abbasi and Muhammad Saqlain.

In the past decade, however, the paths of the two nations diverged dramatically. Heavy investment flowed into Indian hockey which provided state-of-the-art infrastructure and top-level foreign coaches. This

systemic overhaul returned India to the Olympic podium after a gap of 41 years, making them the only men's team to medal at the last two Olympic Games.

Conversely, Pakistan's hockey has plummeted.

They failed to qualify for the last three Olympics and two of the last four World Cups. "Hockey culture has just suddenly died in Pakistan," the legendary Shahbaz Ahmed, the only player to win back-to-back Player of the Tournament awards at World Cups (1990 and 1994), told HT last year.

Financial neglect further crippled Pakistani hockey. Ahead of the 2018 World Cup, the team barely secured travel funds at the 11th hour through a private sponsor. Former head coach Siegfried Aikman resigned in 2023 after going unpaid for an entire year.

However, Thursday's clash reminded the world why this fixture remains unmatched.

From flashes of individual brilliance to sudden swings of momentum and raw emotional intensity, the contest showed that no matter how deep the structural divide grows, an India-Pakistan hockey match retains its unique, unpredictable magic, rekindling the timeless romance forged when two friends sang together on the Kuala Lumpur turf five decades ago.



PICK OF THE DAY

MY BENGALURU

K'taka CEO orders legal action against false Form 7 claims

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BENGALURU: Karnataka Chief Electoral Officer V Anbukumar on Thursday night ordered election officials to initiate legal proceedings against people who knowingly submit false claims or objections regarding changes to electoral rolls.

The order comes as chief minister D K Shivakumar staged a protest alleging an organised effort to remove voters through Form 7 applications during the Special Intensive Revision.

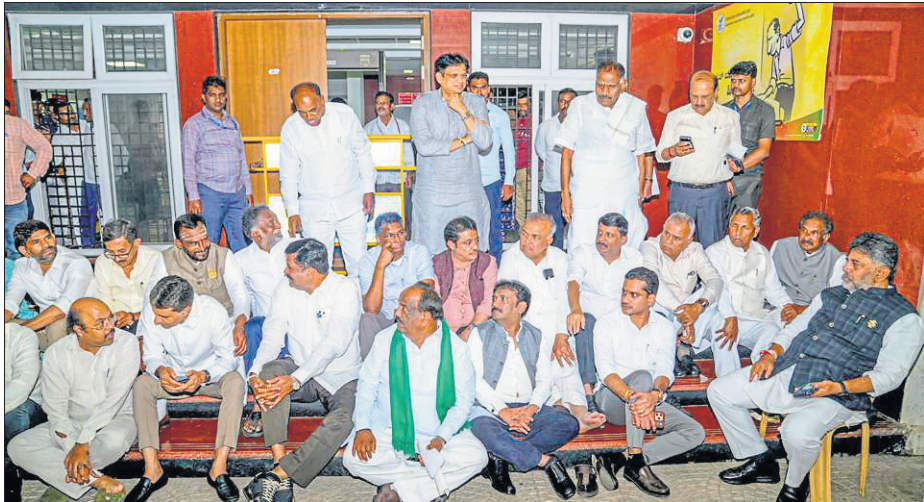
In a circular sent to district election officers and Electoral Registration Officers in all 224 Assembly constituencies, Anbukumar said his office had received reports of bulk Form 7 applications and allegations that some of the applications were not genuine.

"It has come to the notice of this office that there are instances of filing of bulk applications in Form 7 before the EROs. It is also alleged that such forms are not genuine," the circular said.

The CEO directed EROs to take action against applicants who knowingly make false statements or declarations in Forms 6, 6A, 7 and 8 under Section 31 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950. Such action, the circular said, must follow an inquiry under Rule 20 of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960.

The circular does not link the alleged bulk applications to any political party. It instead instructs election officials to establish through inquiry whether claims or objections were knowingly false before taking legal action.

The directive came as Shivakumar and his cabinet colleagues began a protest outside the CEO's



Chief minister DK Shivakumar, along with cabinet colleagues and party leaders, staged a sit-in outside the office of chief electoral officer V Anbukumar in Bengaluru on Thursday.

PTI

office in Bengaluru on Thursday evening. The chief minister submitted a memorandum seeking a criminal case and a detailed investigation into alleged attempts to delete eligible voters through large numbers of Form 7 applications.

Shivakumar said the protest would continue until the Election Commission ordered an investigation. Cabinet colleagues and legislators joined him.

He alleged that applications seeking deletion of voters had been filed in several constituencies and that some were withdrawn after objections were raised.

"In two assembly constituencies in Ballari, 13,000 Form 7 applications were submitted and withdrawn. In Vijayapura, apart from Babalshwar, 13,000 applications were submitted and withdrawn," he said.

His memorandum cited about 3,000 Form 7 applications in Belagavi North, 6,259 in Mudigere,

1,373 in Babalshwar, 1,200 in Narasimharaja and 2,285 in Bhalki.

Shivakumar alleged that applications had been filed seeking deletion of 45 lakh voters and accused BJP and JD(S) workers of being involved. "There is a big conspiracy by BJP and JD(S) to delete 50-60 lakh voters. BJP has printed large numbers of Form-7 to exclude votes," he charged.

He also alleged that minorities, Dalits and tribal communities were being targeted. "There are many instances of individuals filing multiple applications in different names for deleting voters. Minorities, Dalits, tribals are being targeted to remove their names from electoral roll under Special Intensive Revision," he said.

Shivakumar questioned the preparation of some Form 7 applications, saying voter details appeared to have been printed before objector information was entered. "In several cases, the

names, EPIC numbers and other particulars of the voters proposed for deletion appear to have been pre-printed on the Form 7 applications, with the details of the objector subsequently filled in," he said.

Police complaints have also been filed over alleged irregularities in Form 7 applications in different parts of Karnataka.

In Mysuru's Narasimharaja constituency, a complaint was filed after a Booth Level Officer contacted social worker and former Mysuru City Corporation member Syed Hasarathulla about a Form 7 objection against him and 28 other voters. The application alleged that they no longer lived at their registered address.

Hasarathulla said he had lived and voted at the address for 39 years. Police registered Crime No. 220/2026 under provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita concerning cheating, forgery and acts endangering public harmony.

In Belagavi North, another complaint concerned 198 Form 7 applications brought to the 7th Cross New Veerbhadr Nagar Government Urdu School on September 22.

In Bhalki, businessman and nominated member of the Bhalki City Municipal Council Mohd Ateeq Ahmed filed a complaint after 3,244 Form 7 applications were submitted between September 21 and 23. The applications allegedly described eligible voters as "shifted" or "absent".

Ahmed said the Electoral Registration Officer told him notices had been issued following the bulk submissions, but none of the objectors listed in the applications appeared for the hearings.

A preliminary verification allegedly found that 32 named individuals and unidentified associates had forged signatures and entered their own mobile numbers in the applications. Bhalki Town police registered Crime No. 162/2026 under provisions relating to criminal conspiracy, forgery, cheating and public mischief.

The BJP rejected the allegations. Karnataka BJP president B Y Vijayendra alleged that Muslim voters were being gathered at mosques and marriage halls in some places during the SIR process, with officials being asked to add their names to electoral rolls.

He said BJP workers were bringing such alleged irregularities to the Election Commission's notice.

"There is nothing wrong in requesting the Election Commission to verify and delete names suspected to have been added illegally. If the name is correct, the Election Commission will retain it; if it is illegal, it will be removed," Vijayendra said.

Customs imposes penalty worth ₹89-crore on Ranya

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BENGALURU: The customs department has ordered Karnataka actor Ranya Rao to pay ₹89.91 crore in penalties over alleged gold smuggling, as part of a 399-page adjudication order that imposes over ₹244 crore in penalties on four people accused in the case, officials aware of the matter said on Thursday.

The order, issued by Customs joint director Sandeep on Wednesday, also imposes a ₹49.51 crore penalty on Tarun Konduru Raju and ₹53.06 crore each on Sahil Jain and Bharat Kumar Jain, officials said.

A Customs officer familiar with the proceedings said the order sets out the department's findings on the alleged gold movement and the roles attributed to those involved.

"The adjudication order has been issued after examining the available evidence and records collected during the investigation. The penalty has been determined under the provisions of the Customs Act based on the findings recorded in the order," the officer said.

The Customs investigation relates to alleged smuggling between March 7, 2024, and February 18, 2025. Investigators have alleged that about 113 kg of gold was brought into India from Dubai through a network involving Rao and the other



Ranya Rao

accused.

Rao was intercepted by Directorate of Revenue Intelligence officials at Kempegowda International Airport on March 3, 2025, after arriving from Dubai. Officials recovered 14.213 kg of concealed foreign origin gold valued at about ₹12.56 crore, according to the investigation records cited in the case.

A search of her residence later led to the seizure of ₹2.67 crore in unaccounted cash and gold jewellery valued at about ₹2.06 crore, according to the Enforcement Directorate.

The investigation then examined Rao's alleged links with Raju, Sahil and Bharat, as well as the movement of gold and money attributed to the network.

The Customs officer said the financial penalty proceedings are distinct from the criminal case. "The Customs proceedings concern the alleged violations under the Customs Act. The order records the findings of the adjudication proceedings

and determines the penalty liability of the persons concerned. The accused have legal remedies available against the order," the officer said.

The latest order follows a September 2025 penalty notice issued by the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence, which reportedly sought ₹102 crore from Rao over the alleged smuggling.

Rao was arrested in March 2025 after the airport interception and later obtained statutory bail in the Customs case. She remained in custody under preventive detention proceedings under the Conservation of Foreign Exchange and Prevention of Smuggling Activities Act, 1974.

The Supreme Court upheld the preventive detention order in April 2026. Rao completed the one year detention period and was released from Bengaluru Central Prison on April 22.

The Customs adjudication is separate from the preventive detention proceedings and the criminal case.

"The order has been passed after considering the material available before the adjudicating authority. The parties concerned can pursue the remedies available to them under law," the officer said.

The findings and allegations recorded in the adjudication order remain open to the legal remedies available to the accused.

KPSC has become Cong's ATM: BJP on 'irregularities'

Press Trust of India

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NEW DELHI: The BJP on Thursday targeted Congress leader Rahul Gandhi over alleged irregularities in the veterinary officers' recruitment exam in Karnataka, alleging that he has maintained a studied silence on the "injustice" done to job aspirants in the state ruled by his party.

Addressing a press conference at the BJP headquarters here, party spokesperson Sambit Patra also accused Gandhi of adopting a "double standards" on the student issues and alleged that the Karnataka Public Service Commission (KPSC) has become "Congress' ATM".

"You send your youth wing and allies to create disturbances in the states ruled by the BJP and when the students and doctors face injustice in the states ruled by your party, you remain silent. How long can this double standard continue," Patra said, demanding a response from Gandhi.

Karnataka CID and the Enforcement Directorate are investigating alleged irregularities in the veterinary officers' recruitment exam conducted by KPSC.

A case was registered in the matter few months ago after a group of veterinary doctors lodged a complaint with the Vidhana Soudha police, alleg-



Sambit Patra

ing large-scale irregularities in the KPSC recruitment process for 400 veterinary officer posts in the Animal Husbandry and Fisheries Department.

The ED on Wednesday alleged that former Karnataka PSC Controller of Exams and IAS officer Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar "facilitated" the leakage of the veterinary officers' recruitment examination question paper to an alleged middleman a day before the test in exchange for illegal gratification.

The ED also said its probe revealed that Rs 30-40 lakh was taken from candidates of the exam for access to the leaked paper.

Gangwar was arrested by the central agency on September 18 while he was in the custody of the Karnataka CID investigating the same case. He is cur-

rently in ED custody.

Patra said investigations into the case have reportedly brought to light "huge financial transactions, blank cheques, promissory notes and a diamond necklace worth ₹22 lakh".

"Rahul Gandhi, who politicises issues concerning students in BJP-ruled states, should explain why he remains silent on the injustice faced by the students in Karnataka," he said.

He should tell who has the diamond necklace," the BJP leader said, wondering, "Could the necklace worth ₹22 lakh be at Janpath? KPSC has become Congress' ATM," he charged.

Patra also slammed the Congress over the Karnataka government reportedly filing a petition in the Supreme Court challenging the high court's recent order for setting up an SIT to probe the case.

"Rahul Gandhi keeps talking about the Constitution, demanding setting up of SIT on one or other issue but when the court orders setting up of an SIT to probe a case in the state ruled by his party, it is challenged in the Supreme Court," he said.

Congress leaders keep showing the Constitution but they are the ones who are indulging in "constitutional fraud", Patra charged.

Rahul Gandhi alleges bid to delete 15k voter names in Belagavi region

Agencies

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NEW DELHI: Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday attacked the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and Election Commission of India, alleging a systemic attempt to erase nearly 15,000 voters from electoral rolls in Karnataka's Belagavi region.

In a post on X, Gandhi alleged that a massive "flood" of Form 7 applications was filed in bulk over three days — September 22,

23 and 24 — to remove targeted groups from electoral rolls.

He claimed the deletions were aimed mainly at Muslim, SC, ST and OBC voters in a coordinated bid to disenfranchise communities that traditionally vote against the BJP. "In just three days—September 22, 23, and 24—there was a flood of Form 7 applications to remove nearly 15,000 voters... Muslims, SCs, STs, and OBCs are being systematically targeted because they do not vote for BJP," said Rahul.

In Belagavi, local election offi-

cials reportedly received thousands of such applications over a span of 72 hours, triggering alarm among local Congress workers and booth-level officers.

"I had already exposed this method of vote theft - votes are deleted through software in a centralised manner. 'Select' people are targeted as BJP and EC officials collude to fill out Form 7 in bulk through automated means - and in the blink of an eye, millions vanish from the voter list. And all of this is controlled from the top," he said.

Dy CM seeks urgent Centre aid to tackle severe drought

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Karnataka deputy chief minister G Parameshwara on Thursday wrote to Union Home Minister Amit Shah and Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, seeking urgent central assistance to address the severe drought in the state.

As many as 177 taluks have so far been declared drought-affected in Karnataka, with crop losses estimated at ₹46,324.5 crore, according to the state government's assessment.

In separate letters to the two Union ministers, Parameshwara, who also holds the Revenue portfolio, highlighted the impact of the drought on farmers and rural livelihoods and stressed the need for coordinated action by the Centre and the state to ensure timely relief.

The state government had earlier submitted its Kharif 2026 drought memorandum, seeking ₹3,705.30 crore in assistance for 101 drought-affected taluks.

Following a further scientific assessment, another 76 taluks were declared drought-affected, taking the total to 177.

Ground-truthing is underway in another 40 taluks, and the number of affected taluks is expected to cross 220 as the assessment progresses, according to the letters issued by his office.

Crop assessment in the 76 newly declared drought-affected taluks found damage to agricultural crops over 26.08 lakh hectares and horticultural crops over 1.49 lakh hectares.

The extent of crop damage ranges between 33 per cent and 100 per cent, with a large portion of the affected area reporting losses of more than 50 per cent.



G Parameshwara

Tur, maize, cotton, sugarcane, soybean and green gram are among the major crops affected, while onion, arecanut and red chilli are among the horticultural crops damaged.

The total area affected by crop damage in these 76 taluks has been assessed at 27.57 lakh hectares, with the economic loss estimated at ₹27,576.2 crore based on the cost of cultivation. The requirement towards input subsidy under existing SDRF norms has been estimated at ₹2,981.34 crore.

Across the 177 drought-affected taluks, crop damage has been reported over nearly 47.09 lakh hectares, with the estimated economic loss touching ₹46,324.5 crore, it added.

Parameshwara said the total crop damage during Kharif 2026 could exceed 55 lakh hectares based on the ongoing assessment.

Through the two phases of drought declaration, Karnataka has sought ₹7,142.64 crore under NDRF norms. Of this, ₹4,998.60 crore has been sought towards input subsidy and ₹2,144.04 crore for measures such as fodder and drinking water supply.

In his letter to Shah, Parameshwara sought an early revision of the items and norms of assistance under the SDRF and NDRF, particularly those relating to

input subsidy for farmers. He said the existing input subsidy was inadequate given the current cost of cultivation and covered only a small portion of the actual losses suffered by farmers.

With the 16th Finance Commission period having commenced, Parameshwara urged the Centre to prioritise the long-pending revision of relief norms.

He said relief should more realistically reflect the prevailing cost of cultivation and the actual economic impact of crop losses.

The state government has already submitted its detailed views and justification for the revision of norms to the Union Home Ministry, he said.

In his separate letter to Chouhan, Parameshwara welcomed the arrival of the central team in Karnataka to assess the drought situation.

He urged the Centre to expedite the assessment process and consider the state's request for assistance so that relief could be released at the earliest.

"Considering the scale and severity of the present drought, it is necessary for the State and Union Governments to work in coordination. Our farmers must receive timely and adequate support. The relief provided should reflect the actual losses they have suffered," the deputy CM said.

The state government is extending all possible assistance and taking necessary measures to mitigate the impact of the drought, he said.

Parameshwara expressed confidence that the Centre would respond positively to Karnataka's request and take early steps to strengthen relief norms and expedite the drought relief process.

Oppn accuses CM of 'pressuring' poll panel

Press Trust of India

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BENGALURU: Leader of Opposition in Karnataka Assembly R Ashoka on Thursday said the EC should independently verify Form-7 applications seeking deletion of names from electoral rolls and alleged that chief minister DK Shivakumar was exerting pressure on poll panel.

The senior BJP leader's remarks came hours after Shivakumar, along with his Cabinet colleagues and MLAs, staged a sit-in outside the office of Chief Electoral Officer V Anbukumar, demanding an FIR and an inquiry into alleged misuse of Form-7 applications during the ongoing SIR of electoral rolls.

"Anyone can submit an application. Whether it should be removed or retained is for the Election Commission to decide. They have to conduct an inquiry," Ashoka told reporters.

He said the poll panel should conduct spot verification and ascertain whether voters whose names have been proposed for deletion actually reside at the

given addresses. "If someone is registered at three or four places their names should be removed. If they are registered at only one place, how can the Commission remove their name. There is no question of deletion unless there is bogus or duplicate registration," he said.

Ashoka alleged that Shivakumar was attempting to dictate terms to a constitutional body by demanding an FIR over the Form-7 applications.

"The EC has its own rules and regulations. Who are you (CM) to tell it to file an FIR. The EC will take the decision," he said.

The BJP leader also questioned the chief minister's decision to stage a protest outside the CEO's office, saying political parties should not put pressure on the poll panel. "We are a political party. We will not put pressure on the Election Commission to decide. They have to conduct an inquiry," Ashoka said.

"The EC must function impartially. Any genuine voter of this country, irrespective of religion, should get right to vote. There is no question about it," he said.

Urdu festival at Vidhana Soudha faces opposition

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka government's proposal to hold an Urdu festival on the steps of Vidhana Soudha on November 9 has run into opposition from the BJP and a pro Kannada organisation, with the minister behind the plan saying Thursday that the government was willing to reconsider the venue after hearing objections.

Health, family welfare, waqf and minority affairs minister U T Khader said the proposed Urdu Habba was intended to take the annual Urdu Sahitya award programme out of a hall and into an open space, where people from different communities could engage with Urdu language, literature, culture, cuisine and art.

But he said the government would not proceed if the programme created problems.

"We will discuss whether to hold the programme or not. We will seek opinions, and we are ready to make adjustments," Khader told reporters in Bengaluru.

Khader said the proposal was meant to promote understanding rather than favour one community.

"Every language has its own



The minister said the government was willing to reconsider the venue after hearing objections.

FILE PHOTO

tradition and culture, and they all stand for unity. Our intention is a society filled with trust, a developed Karnataka and a strong India. With this intention, we had planned for it. Every year, the Urdu Sahitya award is given, and it used to be presented inside a hall. I, as a minister, had planned to organise the event in a better way," he said.

He said some of those objecting to the proposal might not have understood the language or the purpose of the programme.

"It is not their mistake, as they were never exposed to such an event, nor did they understand the language and what was behind it," he said.

"The event was planned for such people and to make them understand, so that the anger and jealousy inside them can be reduced. By reducing such things, we can establish a society filled with trust and a strong India," Khader added.

The minister also rejected the suggestion that he was insisting on the Vidhana Soudha venue.

"We will speak to everyone. We want good for the state and the country through our programmes. I will never proceed with anything that may cause loss or create problems. We are not adamant on this issue. I have just shared an idea," he said.

The BJP has objected specifically to holding the event at Vidhana Soudha, arguing that Kannada should have prominence at the seat of the state legislature and government.

BJP state president B Y Vijayendra accused the Congress government of pursuing "divide and rule" politics and alleged that the proposal was aimed at "appeasing minorities".

Speaking in Kolar, Vijayendra linked the proposal to the Congress government's opposition to the Centre's three language formula, saying it had earlier argued that Hindi was being imposed on children.

"However, by now celebrating an Urdu festival in place of Kannada on the steps of Vidhana Soudha, the government has itself revealed its position," he said.

Vijayendra said the BJP was not opposed to minorities and maintained that welfare and development programmes

should reach every section of society equally.

BJP MLC C T Ravi also questioned the Congress's position on language.

"Those who oppose Hindi should explain their stand now. They are citing Tulu's prominence and celebrating Urdu," Ravi said.

He said the BJP did not favour holding a festival for a language he described as not connected to Karnataka at Vidhana Soudha, adding that Kannada should be celebrated there.

Karnataka Rakshana Vedike chief Narayana Gowda also opposed the proposal and said his organisation would not allow the event to be held at the venue.

He said his organisation was not opposed to Urdu or any other language but objected to the proposed location.

"We are not opposed to Urdu or to any other language. There are plenty of places in Bengaluru where an Urdu festival can be held," he said.

Deputy chief minister G Parameshwara said he had not been informed about the proposal.

"This matter has not come to my knowledge. I do not have any information," he said.

SOUTH REGION

Rain deficit in Andhra, T'gana deepens farm, water concerns

Srinivasa Rao Apparasu

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HYDERABAD: Inadequate rainfall and prolonged dry spells during the southwest monsoon have left Telangana and Andhra Pradesh facing uncertainty over agricultural prospects and water availability for irrigation and drinking needs in the coming seasons, officials said.

Both states recorded below-normal rainfall during the June-September monsoon, with Telangana registering a 17% deficit and Andhra Pradesh a substantially higher 34.1% shortfall. The deficient rainfall has also led to a sharp decline in reservoir storage compared with last year, increasing dependence on limited irrigation resources, government data shows.

While agriculture departments do not expect a major decline in overall kharif production at this stage, experts have warned that persistently high temperatures and inadequate soil and irrigation moisture could affect yields in some crops. Meteorological assessments indicate that the influence of El Nino could continue into the coming months, raising concerns over rabi cultivation and productivity.

Telangana received 615.5 mm of rainfall between June 1 and September 30, against the normal 740.6 mm, resulting in a 17% deficit, according to the state agriculture department's report issued Thursday.

The overall deficit masks considerable variation across the state. While 16 districts received near-normal rainfall, 17 recorded



Both states recorded below-normal rainfall during the June-September monsoon.

deficient rainfall. Even in districts with near-normal rainfall, the pattern was not uniform, with prolonged dry spells in between.

"Jogulamba Gadwal recorded rainfall on only 22 days during the monsoon and registered a 40% deficit. Hyderabad recorded dry spells across all its 16 mandals, while substantial numbers of mandals in Adilabad, Wanaparthy, Khammam and Narayanpet also experienced prolonged dry periods," the report said. The uncertainty over rainfall prompted farmers, particularly those without assured irrigation, to adopt a cautious approach to kharif cultivation. Telangana recorded sowing over 12.5 million acres, around 95% of the normal cultivated area of 1.3 million acres. The crop mix showed a shift towards pulses, coarse grains and other relatively less water-intensive crops.

Paddy took the biggest hit. Against a normal area of about 6.5 million acres, farmers planted paddy on 5.6 million acres, around 86% of normal and substantially below the 6.7 million acres cultivated during the corresponding period last year. The reduction reflects con-

cerns over irrigation water availability for a crop requiring substantial water during its growth cycle. In several areas without assured irrigation, farmers reportedly preferred not to risk investment in paddy under uncertain rainfall conditions.

At the same time, acreage under several rainfed crops and pulses, including jowar, bajra, ragi, redgram, greengram, blackgram, cowgram and cotton, exceeded their respective normal levels.

The rainfall deficit has also sharply reduced water availability. Combined storage in Telangana's major reservoirs stood at 475.57 TMC on September 30, compared with 848.77 TMC on the same date last year.

Deficit more in Andhra Andhra Pradesh recorded a 34.1% rainfall deficit, receiving 382.3 mm between June 1 and September 30 against the normal 580.1 mm.

Nine districts were within the normal rainfall range, while 18 recorded deficits ranging from 20% to 59%. Annamayya was placed in the large-deficit category.

The deeper rainfall deficit has also affected overall cultivation coverage. About 26.79 lakh hectares had been sown, representing 87% of the full-season normal and 88% of the area normally expected to have been covered by that stage. Paddy acreage stood at 1.3 million hectares, about 92% of the full-season normal of 1.5 million hectares, and below the 1.5 million hectares cultivated during the corresponding period last year.

T'gana ministers' group formed to study El Niño

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HYDERABAD: The Telangana cabinet chaired by Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy on Thursday decided to constitute a group of ministers to study the prevailing El Niño conditions and their impact on the state, and prepare an action plan for drought-affected areas.

The cabinet also appealed to the Centre to declare 235 mandals facing severe rainfall deficiency as drought-hit and extend assistance to the state.

Briefing reporters after the cabinet meeting, state information and public relations minister Ponguluri Srinivas Reddy said the chief minister had directed officials to convene an all-party meeting soon and consult farmers' organisations and experts.

The state recorded a 17% rainfall deficit during the southwest monsoon, which ended on Wednesday. "As many as 235 out of 612 mandals in the state are reported to be facing severe rainfall deficiency and drought-like conditions," he said.

A delegation of ministers will soon visit New Delhi to meet Union ministers and explain the situation, he added.

The cabinet also decided to open paddy procurement centres shortly, with the civil supplies department estimating procurement of around 65 lakh metric tonnes during the Kharif



A Revanth Reddy

season. Officials were directed to ensure smooth procurement and prevent difficulties for farmers.

Reviewing electricity consumption, Srinivas Reddy said the state's daily peak demand had touched a record 19,892 MW, against the normal 15,000 MW. The highest demand recorded during the whole of the previous year was 16,613 MW.

The cabinet directed officials to ensure adequate power generation and procurement to maintain uninterrupted supply. It also approved proposals to add around 7,800 MW of renewable energy capacity, comprising 3,000 MW of solar power, 4,000 MW of Battery Energy Storage Systems and 800 MW of wind power.

The projects will be taken up through bidding in accordance with Central government guidelines.

The cabinet also approved the release of two pending Dearness Allowance arrears for state government employees and pensioners, accumulated since 2024, in instalments.

{ LOCAL BODY ELECTIONS }

AP HC strikes down 34% OBC reservation

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HYDERABAD: The Andhra Pradesh High Court on Thursday struck down the state government's orders providing 34% reservation for Other Backward Classes (OBCs) in local body elections, holding that the quota violated the Supreme Court's prescribed 50% ceiling on total reservations. The court also directed the State Election Commission (SEC) to complete local body elections within six weeks, making it clear that the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls could not be grounds for indefinite postponement.

A division bench comprising Chief Justice Lisa Gill and Justice Challa Gunaranjan passed the orders on Public Interest Litigations (PILs) filed by advocate Tandava Yogesh and others challenging the two government orders enhancing OBC reservation. "We hold that the two GOs are not sustainable to the extent of vertical reservation to SCs, STs and OBCs collectively or in aggregate exceeding 50% and are hence set aside," the bench said.

The court said the government could revisit the issue and determine reservation for Backward Classes beyond 50% in view of the Supreme Court's judgment in the Janhit Abhiyan case, after completing data collection through a dedicated com-

HC DIRECTED THE PANCHAYAT RAJ AND MUNICIPAL DEPTS TO COMPLY WITH STATUTORY PROVISIONS WHILE PUBLISHING FINAL ELECTORAL ROLLS

mission in compliance with the Vikas Kishanrao Gawali judgment.

The bench directed the Panchayat Raj and Municipal Administration departments to comply with statutory provisions while publishing final electoral rolls.

It dismissed a YSR Congress Party (YSRCP) petition seeking local body elections only after completion of the SIR process. It also rejected petitions seeking completion of OBC enumeration and finalisation of reservations before elections, and sub-classification among BCs for sarpanch polls. The court declined to interfere with appeals challenging a single judge's refusal to intervene in ward delimitation, clarifying that a circular issued by the Census Commissioner would not affect the process.

It also dismissed petitions challenging the Andhra Pradesh Municipalities Amendment Act, 2021, which enabled the merger of gram panchayats with neighbouring municipalities.

Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu announced that the government would file a special leave petition in the Supreme Court on Friday to restore the 34% OBC quota, accusing the YSRCP of obstructing the move through litigation.

On August 18, Naidu had announced in the Assembly that OBC reservation would be increased from 24.15% to 34% in rural local bodies and 33.33% in urban local bodies. The government subsequently issued two orders, GO No. 105 dated August 20 and GO No. 1065 dated August 19, 2026.

Addressing a rally at Repalle in Guntur district, Naidu alleged that the quota had been reduced to 24% under the previous YSRCP government, resulting in around 16,800 BC representatives losing their positions.

"After we returned to power, we have issued orders restoring the enhanced quota, but the YSRCP men filed petitions in the high court to stall it," he said.

The YSRCP rejected the allegation. Senior leader and Leader of Opposition in the Legislative Council Botsa Satyanarayan said the ruling had exposed Naidu's attempt to mislead OBCs.

He termed the 34% quota announcement a political gimmick ahead of local body elections, alleging that Naidu knew it could not be implemented in view of the Supreme Court's earlier ruling.

Left parties accuse TVK of 'cash-for-votes' for securing bypoll seats

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: The Left parties on Thursday accused the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam of distributing money to voters in two Tamil Nadu Assembly constituencies where bypolls are scheduled for October 6, and demanded that the Election Commission take action.

P Shanmugam, state secretary of the Communist Party of India (Marxist), said the Commission must take note of the allegations and seek answers from the political parties concerned.

The two Left parties, which won two Assembly seats in the April 23 elections, provide outside support to the TVK government in Madurantakam, while the Communist Party of India (CPI) is contesting in Dharapuram.

"Regarding the assembly by-elections, I went to Madurantakam yesterday. Everyone knows that the Marxist Communist Party is contesting in Madurantakam and the Communist Party of India is contesting in Dharapuram. Yesterday, when we visited several villages in Madurantakam, we were distributing pamphlets detailing why the Left parties are contesting and why people should vote for us. But, people in some villages told us that everyone else is distributing money while we are giving only pamphlets," he said.

Shanmugam said villagers told him that the ruling TVK was distributing the highest amount among all parties.

"In the previous poll conducted in April 23, Vijay collected votes promising that 'We are a pure force and will not distribute money for votes', and now this is a confession given by the general public: TVK distributed the most money among



P Shanmugam

everyone," he told reporters.

He said the Left parties had told voters that their strength lay in struggles and party principles, and that neither the CPI nor the CPI(M) would buy votes by distributing money.

"However, reports are coming from the field that others are distributing money to voters on a massive scale. The Election Commission must take action on this, and the concerned leaders of such political parties must answer," Shanmugam said.

Responding to the allegations, TVK national spokesperson and advocate M Sathya Kumar said, "This is just a mere allegation. It is nothing like that. The point is that the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam will never give money for votes. Votes are only for the face of our Thalopathy (chief minister C Joseph Vijay)."

Earlier in the day, the Left parties staged protests across Tamil Nadu demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar.

Shanmugam alleged that the two election commissioners had exposed massive irregularities within the Election Commission and accused the CEC of functioning as a puppet of the ruling party.

"The chief election commissioner has committed a massive betrayal against the people of India," he alleged.

₹1,417 CRORE PMLA CASE: ED ARRESTS TWO FROM T.N.

S Vijay Karthik

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CHENNAI: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Thursday arrested two people under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) for their alleged involvement in a ₹1,417.86 crore investment scam that cheated 35,759 investors, the agency said.

The accused, S Naveen Kumar and S Muthu Selvam, allegedly created fake financial entities and ran investment schemes promising exceptionally high returns through exports of agricultural products, according to an FIR registered by Erode crime branch police.

The ED said it searched nine properties owned by the accused based on the FIR. "Investors were lured into putting their money in several schemes launched by the group of entities run by the duo with assurances of exceptionally high returns through exports of agriculture products," the agency said.

Investigators found that the purported investment companies did not exist and the entities were allegedly used to collect funds from investors, the ED said. The agency found that more than 100 bank accounts belonging to family members and close associates were used to route the funds and traced ₹719 crore.

Naveen Kumar, identified as the alleged mastermind, falsely booked ₹90.90 crore as salary expenses despite employing only four staff. Another ₹79.56 crore was recorded as agricultural commodity purchases to disguise illicit funds as legitimate transactions. Muthuselvam allegedly designed the schemes, brought in investors and routed funds through various accounts. He received ₹12.72 crore in commissions, the ED said.

The accused were produced before a special PMLA court and remanded in judicial custody for 15 days.

Keralam woman hires men to abduct husband, rape his girlfriend; arrested

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: A woman was abducted and raped, while her boyfriend was severely beaten by a six-member gang allegedly hired by the man's wife, police officers in Thrissur district in Kerala said on Thursday.

Five people, including the man's wife, have been arrested by the Thrissur police for their alleged involvement in the crime, officers said. The man, his wife and the other accused are residents of Tamil Nadu, while the rape victim is a native of Nilambur in Kerala.

"The incident took place on September 22 when the couple checked into a lodge near the state transport bus stand in Thrissur. A gang of six men, posing as police officers, barged into the room at the lodge and

FIVE OF THE ACCUSED HAVE BEEN PRODUCED BEFORE A MAGISTRATE AND REMANDED TO JUDICIAL CUSTODY

kidnapped them," Thrissur City Police Commissioner Nakul Rajendra Deshmukh told HT.

The couple were taken to Tiruppur in Tamil Nadu, where the man was brutally assaulted and abandoned outside a hospital, the officer said. The man is reported to have suffered multiple fractures in his hands and legs.

The woman, according to the Thrissur police, was shifted to a separate car and allegedly raped inside the vehicle before being abandoned.

A senior police officer said

the plan to kidnap the couple and assault them was allegedly hatched by the man's wife, who had tracked his mobile phone's location to the lodge in Thrissur.

"The man's wife was part of the gang which abducted him and his girlfriend from the lodge. Though the rape and the man's assault took place in Tiruppur, we will be investigating the case as they were kidnapped from here," the officer said.

Five of the accused have been produced before a magistrate and remanded to judicial custody, while the sixth, who is suspected to be a juvenile, is yet to be apprehended.

The accused were identified as Devi, Thomas, Shankar, Palraj and Raghupathi. They have been charged with various offences, including gang rape, kidnapping and grievous assault.



Adoor Prakash

PRAKASH VOICES DISPLEASURE OVER FUNCTIONING OF RULING FRONT

Press Trust of India

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Senior Congress leader and UDF convenor Adoor Prakash on Thursday expressed displeasure over the functioning of the ruling front and chief minister VD Satheesan, saying he was being kept out of several important decisions and had to learn about them through the media.

Addressing a press conference, Prakash, a senior Lok Sabha MP and former minister, said the situation amounted to "serious neglect" of the UDF convenor and that he would formally convey his strong dissatisfaction to the AICC.

"A convenor of a front, holding a responsible position, having to learn about important government policies and decisions through news reports in newspapers and television channels amounts to serious neglect".

"I am left without answers when Congress workers and people who love the UDF ask me about several matters," the UDF convenor said.



5.4 mn voters issued SIR notices in T'gana

HYDERABAD: Telangana CEO C Sudharshan Reddy on Thursday said that about 5.4 million of the 9.2 million voters issued notices during the SIR process had been included in the electoral rolls. "Out of 9.2 million, nearly 5.4 million have been brought under the main electoral roll. This process will continue till November 5. The collection of documents from the remaining nearly 4 million will be completed, and they will be brought into the main roll... Such people may not enter the main roll," the CEO said.

Centre releases food subsidy of ₹117 cr to Kerala after 4 yrs

CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu government on Thursday accorded state honours to legendary actor 'Nadigar Thilagam' Chevalier Sivaji Ganesan on his 99th birth anniversary.

Speaker JCD Prabhakar garlanded the late actor's statue and offered floral tributes to his portrait at the Sivaji Ganesan Mani Mandapam in Adyar, Chennai.

After paying tributes, minister A Rajmohan said: "Greetings to all. Today, on the birth anniversary of 'Nadigar Thilagam' Chevalier Sivaji Ganesan sir, we are offering state honours and floral tributes on behalf of Honourable Tamil Nadu Chief Minister, brother C Joseph Vijay".

HC leaves MLA's disqualification to Speaker

KOCHI: The Kerala high court on Thursday left it to the state assembly Speaker to take appropriate steps on the question of disqualification of Pala MLA Mani C Kappan following his conviction and sentence in four cheque bounce cases by a Mumbai court. Justice Bechu Kurian Thomas said since Speaker Thiruvanchoor Radhakrishnan has been informed, he can take "necessary steps in accordance with the law". The Pala MLA was sentenced to a total of three-and-a-half years together in four cheque bounce cases by the Mumbai court on September 1.

CM questions CPI(M) over 'unease' against Cong stir

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: A day after clashes broke out between Youth Congress and Students Federation of India (SFI), the student wing of the CPI(M), in Thiruvananthapuram, chief minister VD Satheesan on Thursday accused the Left party of "getting agitated" over Congress protests against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and the BJP.

The Youth Congress alleged that SFI workers threw beer bottles at its protest march against Gyanesh Kumar on Wednesday.

The SFI, however, alleged that Youth Congress workers barged into the University College hostel with the aid of police and assaulted its workers. The



clashes led to protests by both outfits on Thursday.

"Why does it sting the CPI(M) when the Congress wages a spirited struggle against the Sangh Parivar? Why is the CPI(M) in Kerala feeling uneasy when Congress and its feeder units stage protests against the BJP?" Satheesan asked in a statement.

The CM alleged that SFI activists

Why does it sting the CPI(M) when the Congress wages a struggle against the Sangh Parivar

VD SATHEESAN

continuation of that. It shows that CPM and BJP are feathers of the same bird," he alleged.

However, the allegations were termed baseless by Leader of Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan. Vijayan claimed the Youth Congress march was aimed at the SFI and its University College union. "The protest against Amit Shah and the Election Commission is only in name. It is a calculated act of violence orchestrated to appease the RSS and divert public attention from the administrative failures of the State government," he said.

Vijayan also alleged that Satheesan intervened to forcibly remove a video of Youth Congress protesting against Amit Shah from the Facebook account of state sports and youth affairs minister OJ Janesh.

"The UDF government has taken a vow that it will not speak a word against the BJP and the Union government," he alleged.

Meanwhile, activists of DYFI, the youth wing of CPI(M), displayed black flags and damaged Janesh's vehicle while the minister was in Kannur district on Thursday for official programmes.

"Such developments are clearly intended to escalate violence in the state. After their crushing defeat in the elections, they (CPM) want to remain relevant," the minister said.

Clashes were also reported between SFI and KSU, the student wing of Congress, outside Maharajas College in Kochi on Thursday. Police personnel were deployed to contain the protests.

36% voter deletion pleas from single J'khand assembly seat

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RANCHI: Roughly a third of the 13,000 applications received by the Jharkhand chief electoral officer (CEO) for deletion of names from the electoral roll came from a single assembly seat in the eastern state, data showed on Thursday.

The special intensive revision began in Jharkhand on June 30.

According to data, Jharkhand flagged 4.36 million under logical discrepancies. The last date for logical discrepancy hearing is October 12. September 30 was the last date for filing applications for addition, objections, and claims for names deletion (due to various reasons). The final roll will be released on October 19.

Of the 13,443 applications received for name deletion, 4,790 entries were marked in the Chatra assembly constituency in Chatra district alone, accounting for about 36% of the total. The seat is held by Janardhan Paswan of LJP-R, who won by over 18,000 votes in the 2024 assembly polls.

Only two other districts received over a thousand Form 7, including 1,906 applications in West Singhbhum and 1099 forms in Deoghar. The names deletion applications in the remaining 21 districts are in three digits.

CEO K Ravi Kumar said the data was verified with the Chatra district administration and no anomaly was found. Kumar said more Form 7 would be generated during the verification process in other seats as well.

"It has been verified. There has been no case of bulk applications beyond the prescribed limit. The process is designed so that more Form 7 applications will be generated. Many applications received under Form 8, which are for shifting and rationalisation of booths, would consequently generate automated form 7 entries. Even when shifting or changing a booth, the name must be deleted from the existing booth, which can only be done through Form 7 entries," CEO Kumar added.

A delegation led by Congress media co-incharge Kishore Nath Shahdeo met Kumar earlier this week.

Over 4.4 mn sent

'incorrect info' notices in Hry SIR

CHANDIGARH: As part of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of Haryana electoral rolls, over 4.4 million notices have been issued to voters for "providing incorrect information" during the mapping process, with hearings completed in over 4 million of these cases, officials said on Thursday.

More than 4.49 million notices had been issued to electors for providing incorrect information during the mapping process. Of these, hearings in over 4.056 million cases have been completed, while some 435,000 hearings are pending, an official statement issued here said.

The highest pendency is in Faridabad, Karnal and Hisar districts.

The statement said additional chief electoral officer, Haryana, has directed all electoral registration officers (EROs) to ensure that all pending hearings are disposed of within the stipulated time.

She has also directed that the poll panel's guidelines are strictly complied with while passing any order. **PTI**

"We had submitted a memorandum that included a few issues including the one related to the Chatra assembly seat. We sought clarification transparently. We were informed that a major reason for the big jump was due to applications for a change of booth," said Shahdeo.

The Jharkhand CEO has also sent a proposal to the poll panel for an extension in the period of notices and verifications as well publication of the revised electoral roll. "We are confident that the dates will be extended as a lot of work still needs to be done. All BLOs now have to go door to door to clear all the notices and verify documents," said Kumar.



Karnataka CM DK Shivakumar, cabinet colleagues stage protest outside CEO office in Bengaluru on Thursday. @DKSHIVAKUMAR/X

K'taka CEO orders legal action against false Form 7 claims

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BENGALURU: Karnataka chief electoral officer (CEO) V Anbukumar on Thursday night ordered election officials to initiate legal proceedings against people who knowingly submit false claims or objections regarding changes to electoral rolls. The order comes as chief minister DK Shivakumar staged a protest alleging an organised effort to remove voters through Form 7 applications during the special intensive revision (SIR).

In a circular sent to district election officers and Electoral Registration Officers in all 224 assembly constituencies, Anbukumar said his office had received reports of bulk Form 7 applications and allegations that some of the applications were not genuine.

"It has come to the notice of this office that there are instances of filing of bulk applications in Form 7 before the EROs. It is also alleged that such forms are not genuine," the circular said.

The CEO directed EROs to take action against applicants who knowingly make false statements or declarations in Forms 6, 6A, 7 and 8 under Section 31 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950. Such action, the circular said, must follow an inquiry under Rule 20 of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960.

The circular does not link the alleged bulk applications to any political party. It instead instructs election officials to establish through inquiry whether claims or objections were knowingly false before taking legal action.

The directive came hours after Shivakumar and his cabinet colleagues staged a protest outside the CEO's office in Bengaluru. The chief minister submitted a memorandum seeking a criminal case and a detailed investigation into alleged attempts to delete eligible voters through large numbers of Form 7 applications.

Shivakumar alleged that applications seeking deletion of voters had been filed in several constituencies and that some were withdrawn after objections were raised.

"In two assembly constituencies in Ballari, 13,000 Form 7 applications were submitted and withdrawn. In Vijayapura, apart from Babaleswar, 13,000 applications were submitted and withdrawn," he said.

The BJP rejected the allegations. "There is nothing wrong in requesting the Election Commission to verify and delete names suspected to have been added illegally. If the name is correct, the Election Commission will retain it; if it is illegal, it will be removed," state BJP president BY Vijayendra said.

88 OF 97 ELIGIBLE VOTERS DELETED FROM GOA ROLLS RESTORED: CEO

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PANAJI: The chief electoral officer (CEO) of Goa on Thursday confirmed that 88 out of 97 voters who were excluded from the final electoral roll following the special intensive revision exercise despite being eligible have been re-included as fresh voters after they submitted Form 6.

The CEO's office in a statement said that of the remaining nine voters, three have been found to be Portuguese passport holders, while six are currently residing abroad.

"Out of the 97 left-out voters, 88 have filled Form 6, which have been accepted," the statement said.

"In respect of the voters who are currently residing outside India, the concerned officials are making efforts to establish and maintain contact with them for further necessary action."

Goa CEO Sanjay Goel also announced the commencement of a "special drive" for the enrolment of left-out and young first-time voters.

"The drive will focus on facilitating the enrolment of left-out eligible citizens as well as young and first-time eligible electors who have not yet been included in the electoral roll. The exercise will be undertaken as part of the process of continuous updation of electoral rolls through house-to-house visits of the BLOs," the statement said.

An Indian Express investigation last month sparked a major controversy over the allegation that 97 verified voters could not be added to the Goa electoral roll because the software did not allow the update to be recorded.

The special intensive revision (SIR) exercise, which concluded with the publication of the final roll on February 21 this year, saw deletion of around 127,000 voters or about 10% of the state's electorate faced a peculiar problem.

{ APPOINTMENT OF ECs, CEC LAW }

SC dismisses plea seeking recall of its split judgment

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to entertain an application seeking recall of the order passed by the Supreme Court on referring to a Constitution bench the challenge to the law governing the appointment of the chief election commissioner and election commissioners, asking the petitioner to approach the Chief Justice of India (CJI).

The application filed by Naman Sherstra, one of the petitioners who has challenged the validity of the CEC & ECs (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023, was mentioned before justice Dipankar Datta by senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan assisted by advocate Vishal Sinha.

Justice Datta told Sankaranarayanan to approach the CJI Surya Kant as he is the "master of roster" and there is also a curative petition that has been filed in this matter. The judge said, "All applications and petitions will be decided by the master of the roster. We will not entertain these matters piecemeal. You approach the CJI."

Sankaranarayanan said that the application needs to be listed as the recall is sought on the

ON SEPTEMBER 23, AN SC BENCH GAVE A SPLIT VERDICT ON WHETHER THE 2023 LAW SHOULD BE REFERRED TO A CONSTITUTION BENCH

ground that one of the judges who heard the matter – justice Satish Chandra Sharma – ought to have recused as his son appears for the Election Commission of India (ECI) before the Madhya Pradesh high court.

On September 23, a bench of justices Dipankar Datta and Satish Chandra Sharma gave a split verdict on whether the 2023 law should be referred to a Constitution bench. While justice Datta was of the view that the need does not arise as the challenge to the Act can be considered based on the settled principles laid down by earlier judgments, justice Sharma held a different view. He said that substantial questions on interpretation of Constitution arise in the matter and under Article 145(3), the same should be heard by a bench of at least five judges of the Supreme Court. The two judges passed a common order placing the matter before CJI for

referring the petitions to a Constitution bench. Sankaranarayanan told the court that recall is sought only on justice Sharma's order. He said that the application was filed as a curative will not be maintainable.

The application categorically states that the matter was heard by the bench of justices Datta and Sharma on five occasions. On none of the occasions, justice Sharma disclosed this fact or sought recusal on this ground. Sherstra stated that the fact about justice Sharma's son being engaged as ECI counsel became known from news reports that surfaced two days after the September 23 order.

It sought recall of the order stating, "The question is whether the established circumstances, viewed objectively, give rise to a reasonable apprehension concerning impartiality." However, the application does not seek recall of justice Datta's separate opinion.

The present application is the second plea for recall. A curative petition was filed on Tuesday by Congress leader Jaya Thakur, also a petitioner in the present batch challenging the validity of the 2023 law. The curative plea sought recall on the ground of a "reasonable likelihood of bias," based on the same fact linking justice Sharma's son to the ECI.

NCP(SP), Cong to join Sena(UBT) Oct 4 stir against ECI's conduct

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MUMBAI: The Congress and Nationalist Congress Party (Sharadchandra Pawar) have decided to join the October 4 protest march in Mumbai announced jointly by Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray and Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) chief Raj Thackeray, turning the proposed agitation into a broader Opposition mobilisation.

The protest has been announced over the alleged irregularities in voter rolls following the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise and the conduct of the Election Commission.

NCP (SP) working president Supriya Sule announced on Thursday that her party would

THE PROTEST HAS BEEN ANNOUNCED OVER ALLEGED IRREGULARITIES IN VOTER ROLLS FOLLOWING SIR

participate in the march. Congress leader Nana Patole also confirmed the party's participation, saying the agitation should extend beyond political parties.

"Our party will participate in the October 4 protest march," Sule said.

Patole said the Congress wanted the protest to become a people's movement. "Democracy is being murdered in broad daylight. Gyanesh Kumar is benefiting the BJP. Congress believes democracy must be protected.

Everyone who believes in democracy is now taking to the streets," he said.

The announcements came after Uddhav Thackeray participated virtually in an INDIA bloc meeting and appealed to alliance partners to join the march.

Dipke announces stir today, briefly detained Meanwhile, Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke was briefly detained at Marine Drive police station on Thursday after he was spotted with placards along the iconic promenade. Dipke and his supporters were kept at the police station's waiting area. This came hours after he announced a nationwide agitation starting from Mumbai on October 2 demanding CEC's resignation.

Ex-WB minister's firm sent ₹30L to Mamata's bank accounts: ED

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KOLKATA: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Thursday said its money laundering probe into alleged financial irregularities linked to Durga Puja 'preview shows' case found that former West Bengal tourism minister Indranil Sen's proprietorship concern transferred nearly ₹30 lakh to former chief minister Mamata Banerjee through banking channels.

The agency said Sen claimed the payment was made as "royalty." It however, did not explain what the royalty payment was for or attribute any criminality to the transaction in its statement. The disclosure came a day after ED questioned Sen for around 10 hours in connection with the case. The agency had on Tuesday searched 15 premises in Kolkata linked to Sen and his associates.

"...the investigation has revealed that cash of more than ₹3.8 crore was deposited into the bank accounts of Indranil Sen and his proprietorship concern, M/s Octave Records, during his tenure. Also, from the bank account of Octave Records, a sum of nearly ₹30 lakh was transferred via banking channels to Mamata Banerjee, the then chief minister of West Bengal, which Indranil Sen has claimed was paid in the form of royalty," ED said.

The probe relates to alleged financial irregularities involving massArt (Mahanirban Road Mass Art), an NGO associated with Sen's wife, Madhuchhanda Sen, which organised Durga Puja "Preview Shows".

ED alleged that the organisers commercialised Durga Puja by selling tickets priced between ₹1,749 and ₹5,499 for preview shows at 24 selected pandals in Kolkata. "More than one lakh tickets were issued in 2023 and 2024," it said, alleging that the proceeds were subse-

Didi hints at more Opposition parties joining INDIA bloc

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NEW DELHI: Former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee on Thursday indicated that the INDIA bloc could accommodate more Opposition parties, including the DMK, and that the question of who should lead the alliance would be decided collectively.

In her first press conference in Delhi since the West Bengal assembly elections, Banerjee also demanded the immediate resignation of CEC Gyanesh Kumar, alleging that he had worked to "ensure" the BJP's victory in the state. She said a "change is required in the electoral framework to safeguard democracy".

Banerjee was speaking a day after attending an INDIA bloc meeting in Delhi. Asked whether parties such as the DMK should join the INDIA bloc, she said, "These parties have problems at the local level (with the Congress). In some places they are facing elections. But I am in touch with many parties. When the country is facing

a crisis, our priority should be to save the country."

Banerjee said she has a good relationship with BJP chief and Odisha ex-CM Naveen Patnaik and AAP leader Arvind Kejriwal and had recently met DMK MP Kanimozhi. She also said she had spoken to CPI(M) general secretary MA Baby, a political rival of the Trinamool Congress in Bengal, and that he had sent her a letter that she forwarded to the Congress.

On the leadership of the alliance, Banerjee said, "It has to be decided collectively." "INDIA alliance will continue its unity. We will see how far they (BJP) can go," she added.

Adhir asks Mamata to rejoin Congress

Congress leader Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury on Thursday made a direct pitch to Banerjee to rejoin the Congress along with her remaining MLAs and MPs. "As she has taken shelter in Congress-led INDIA alliance, she should join the Congress. In Bengal, we would work under you in Congress. No need for any separate entity at this moment," he said.

not all..." Mamata-AITC spokesperson Anirban Banerjee said. BJP spokesperson Sayantan Basu said the allegations were serious and asked the AITC to approach court if it believed them to be baseless.

"I don't believe that Banerjee will take any money from Sen," said Madan Mitra, a rebel AITC leader who joined the Ritabrata Banerjee-led Democratic Trinamool Congress.

NO SC RELIEF FOR TMC ON FROZEN BANK ACCOUNTS

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to provide relief to the Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress (TMC) faction on operating four bank accounts frozen in connection with a land allotment probe, saying the Calcutta High Court is considering the matter. The high court heard arguments and scheduled the matter for hearing after the Puja holidays.

"We refrain from going into the merits of the matter as the issue is being considered by the high court. We are not inclined to interfere except for expediting the hearing of the petition pending in the high court," said a bench of justices MM Sundresh and PB Varale.

The high court is considering the faction's petition for de-freezing. The faction said it needs approximately ₹19 crore a month for daily expenses and it is willing to reduce it to ₹12.15 crore monthly. It also cited the October 6 by-election to two assembly seats.

Senior advocates Abhishek Manu Singhvi and Shobeb Alam, appearing for the faction, told the court that ED had frozen three accounts in a money laundering probe. Singhvi said, "Every day, a political party's oxygen is in paralysis and in a democracy...the only opposition in the state of West Bengal, is being paralysed by the state police."

Solicitor general Tushar Mehta, who appeared for the state, cited serious charges and added that the accounts were frozen based on complaints that Sumit Roy, who is the personal secretary of lawmaker Abhishek Banerjee, deposited a "huge" amount of cash (₹35 crore).

Mounting clamour ousted Warring?

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NEW DELHI: The Congress leadership told the party's Punjab unit chief, Amrinder Singh Raja Warring, to stand down after feedback gathered by newly elected AICC general secretary in-charge Sachin Pilot over the past three weeks, people familiar with the matter said on Thursday.

Pilot, who replaced Bhupesh Baghel on September 5, held a series of discussions with state leaders and MPs. A majority of the party's seven Lok Sabha MPs from Punjab and several senior state leaders sought a change of guard, prompting the party leadership to begin an exercise to find a new state chief who could maintain social and regional equilibria and work alongside Charanjit Singh Channi, the only Dalit chief minister of Punjab till date.

A senior Punjab leader said Warring's position became unten-



Amarinder Singh Raja Warring

able when the Congress replaced Bhupesh Baghel and brought in Sachin Pilot to get the state unit into shape.

Punjab heads into state elections early next year. In 2022, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) won a landslide victory, securing 92 of the state's 117 seats. The Congress, which was in power, won only 18 seats, and Sukhbir Singh Badal led the Shiromani Akali Dal was confined to just three seats.

Unlike Baghel, who backed Warring and could not meet Channi, Pilot met both Channi and Warring, along with other senior leaders, to maintain bal-

ance in the organisation. "I had a cordial meeting with Channi and he has assured me that he will offer his full support to the party's efforts for the election." Pilot had told HT in an interview.

In his report to the Congress leadership after getting the feedback, Pilot pitched for change in the state leadership, a stand that was in sharp contrast to the report that Baghel presented to the leadership in July this year. At the time, Baghel had virtually ruled out a change of guard.

Asked about the party's change in stance, Pilot told HT on Thursday, "In politics, it's never too late to change."

Former Union minister Vijay Inder Singla, who is from the Bania community, is seen as a front-runner to replace Warring. "A Hindu face can secure temporary peace in the Punjab unit. Channi would be comfortable after Warring's exit and Jatt Sikhs (the most influential section of the

Sikhs in Punjab) won't have any trouble," a Punjab lawmaker said.

Singla could help bring about a truce between the warring factions in the run-up to the state polls. "If Singla is appointed as the Punjab unit head, then Leader of the Opposition in the Punjab assembly, Partap Singh Bajwa and Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa, the latter is close to Channi, are set to get more responsibilities. As the face of the Jatt Sikhs in Punjab, Bajwa and Randhawa have to reach out to the community."

Strategic calculations also favour Singla's prospective appointment due to regional balance. Channi and Singla are from the Malwa region while Bajwa belongs to the Majha region. "Singla can attract the Bania voters in Malwa, the largest electoral region with 69 seats. The Banias primarily control the agricultural trade in this region and have deep links with the farmers," said a third MP.

{ INTERVIEW } SANJIV PRAKASH SHARMA, RETIRED ACTING CHIEF JUSTICE OF RAJ HC

‘Should get to cross-examine justice Mehta’

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JAIPUR: Sanjiv Prakash Sharma, who recently retired as acting chief justice of the Rajasthan high court, in an interview to HT rejected the allegations levelled against him by Supreme Court judge Justice Sandeep Mehta, terming them as "completely fabricated" and driven by "personal jealousy". Edited excerpts:

How do you respond to Justice Mehta's allegations?

His remarks were those of a layman rather than a Supreme Court judge. Whatever Justice Mehta has said was a deliberate act of conspiracy. To my knowledge, not a single allegation made by him has been found to be true.

What could have prompted him to level allegations



against you?

Might be simple personal jealousy. In 2011, both of us were elevated as senior advocates. I was elevated without moving an application; the entire full court selected me to become a senior advocate. He had applied, of course. And I am a first-generation lawyer...and he comes from a reputed judicial family. Both of us were made senior advocates together, and when the issue came for elevation, he saw to it that I didn't become (chief justice).

What are your concerns about the circulation of the letters?

He (Mehta) described the correspondence as confidential while himself sharing it with the Bar Council along with a press note. This reflected a lack of faith in the chief justice of India.

Justice Mehta has accused you of pressuring other judges by citing your proximity to CJI Surya Kant.

If a function is being held at my place, will I not invite the CJI or receive him? But how can it be claimed that I was close to CJI Surya Kant? On what basis did he (Mehta) presume this? I have not practised with him (Kant). He does not belong to my state. He has only looked at my work in Punjab, when I was chairman of the Chandigarh Judicial Academy. How is he (Mehta) connect-

ing me to the CJI?

How do you assess the lawyers' strike against you?

...For 11-and-a-half months into my tenure as the acting CJ, there was not even a single strike in Rajasthan, but he (Mehta) instigated them (lawyers). It doesn't matter. They didn't confirm me as chief justice; it was a stroke of luck that I got a chance to be the acting CJ of Rajasthan. And I took it as an opportunity to do something better for Rajasthan.

How has the episode affected you?

The episode has not saddened me professionally... but it has deeply hurt me personally. I've sent a letter to the CJI citing that I should be given an opportunity to cross-examine Justice Mehta. What are his grounds that I have doubtful integrity?

{ PLEAS OVER DEPUTATION OF IPS OFFICERS TO CAPFs }

CJI spoke to judges on CAPF cases

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court's decision to club contempt petitions concerning deputation of IPS officers to Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) with a separate batch challenging a new law governing such deputation was not an exercise of the Chief Justice of India's roster powers without the knowledge of the judges concerned, people aware of the matter told Hindustan Times.

According to the people cited above, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant had spoken to the judges concerned about listing the two sets of proceedings together, and the two judges heading the respective benches had agreed to go along with the CJI's discretion since some of the issues in the matters could overlap after Parliament enacted a new law governing IPS deputation in the CAPFs.

The problem arose subsequently at the registry level, when the contempt petitions continued to be shown in the cause list before the bench headed by Justice Ujjal Bhuyan on September 29, despite the decision to place both sets of proceedings before a special bench. The matters were subsequently dropped from the list, but the bench hearing the contempt proceedings was not properly informed of the change, the people said.

The development assumes significance in the backdrop of the controversy that erupted earlier this week over the sudden disappearance of the contempt petitions from Justice Bhuyan's cause list, prompting questions about whether the CJI had exercised his administrative powers to shift the matters without consulting the judges hearing them.

The clarification from people familiar with the sequence of events indicates that the judges concerned had been informed of the proposed joint listing last week itself and that the two judges heading the benches had left it to the CJI to decide.

The issue came into the open on Tuesday when lawyers appearing in the contempt petitions informed the Justice Bhuyan-led bench that the matters, which had been specifically directed to be listed, had disappeared from the cause list. The bench sought an explanation from the registry.

On Wednesday, a special bench of justices Manoj Misra and Bhuyan heard the registry's explanation and remarked that "sometimes too much heat is generated out of nothing".

The bench was told that counsel for the Centre and the petitioners in the writ proceedings had made a mentioning before the CJI on September 23 seeking that the contempt and writ petitions be placed before the same bench. The registry, however,



The matter pertains to clubbing of pleas over deputation of IAS officers to CAPF and challenges to the CAPF Act. HT PHOTO

inadvertently listed the contempt matters before Justice Bhuyan's bench on September 29 even though the CJI had directed that the two sets of cases be placed before a special bench.

Even as the registry's note did not annex any administrative order passed in relation to the proposed joint listing of the two sets of proceedings, the special bench said the registry ought to have informed the bench hearing the contempt proceedings about the development. "The registry should have informed this fact to the other bench," it said.

Senior advocate Shyam Divan, appearing for the contempt petitioners, described the episode as a matter of "institutional credibility", questioning how the matter could have been mentioned before the CJI without the other side being informed.

Additional solicitor general Aishwarya Bhati clarified that she had made the mentioning

before the CJI and said the Centre's principal defence in the contempt proceedings was based on the enactment of the new law, whose validity is under challenge in the connected writ petitions.

The bench told her that the other side ought to have been informed. "You ought to have informed the other side," it said. "I ought to have informed the other side," agreed Bhati, tendering her apology.

The controversy had centred on whether the contempt proceedings, arising from alleged non-compliance with the Supreme Court's May 2025 directions on IPS deputation to CAPFs, should proceed independently or be heard alongside challenges to the subsequent legislation enacted by Parliament on the same subject.

The petitioners had maintained that several directions in the May 2025 judgment were independent of the new legislation and that contempt proceedings should not necessarily await adjudication of its validity.

The Centre, however, argued that the new law formed a central part of its defence and that the two sets of proceedings were therefore closely intertwined.

The special bench ultimately advanced the hearing of both sets of cases to October 15 from November 18, recording that one of the Centre's defences in the contempt proceedings was based on the legislation whose validity

is under challenge in the writ petitions.

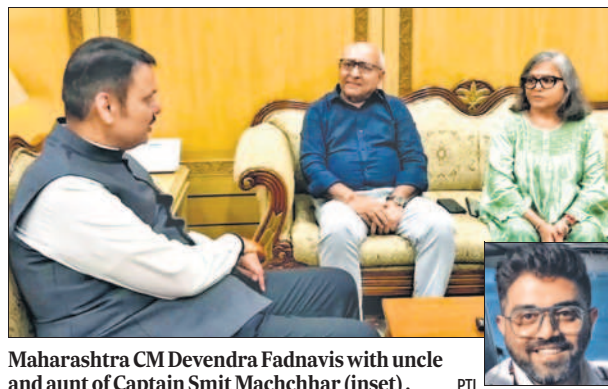
The May 2025 judgment had declared the BSF, CISF, CRPF, ITBP and SSB as an Organised Group A service and directed the Centre to progressively phase out IPS officers on deputation up to the Senior Administrative Grade level within a prescribed timeline.

The subsequent Central Armed Police Force (General Administration) Act, 2026, however, reserves 50% of Inspector General posts, about 67% of Additional Director General posts and almost all Special DG and DG posts in the CAPFs for IPS officers. The legislation has been challenged before the Supreme Court on the ground that it is contrary to the earlier judgment.

The contempt petitions before Justice Bhuyan's bench have alleged non-compliance with the May 2025 judgment and sought action against senior government officials, including the Union home secretary.

Against this backdrop, the apparent deletion of the contempt matters from the cause list had triggered speculation over the manner in which the cases were being reassigned.

Justice Misra on Wednesday sought to play down the episode. "Sometimes too much heat is generated out of nothing. One should not be so much worried about all these things," he observed.



Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnis with uncle and aunt of Captain Smit Machchhar (inset). PTI

Mumbai residents seek civil honour for Capt Machchhar

Yogesh Naik

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MUMBAI: Residents of Swastik Heights at Tilak Nagar, Chembur, gathered in large numbers in the building compound on Thursday noon to raise a cheer for Captain Smit Machchhar and demand that the government bestow a civil honour on him.

"We are so proud that Smit saved so many lives," said the pilot's uncle Kishor Machchhar. Another family friend, Vipul Mehta, promised a "grand felicitation when Smit is back in Mumbai."

Machchhar, the captain of Wednesday's flydubai flight from Dubai to Tel Aviv averted a major mid-air disaster when he fought back against the co-pilot of the aircraft who suddenly went rogue and stabbed Machchhar multiple times in an apparent effort to crash. As the Boeing 737 MAX 8 carrying 174 passengers plunged 14,300 feet, the Mumbai-born pilot fought back and opened the cockpit door allowing for passengers to come in and overpower the co-pilot whose name has still not been made public.

Both, the Indian and Israeli prime ministers, hailed Machchhar's courage and presence of mind. For his immediate family though, the concern is about Machchhar's health. He is being treated at a military hospital at Tabruk in Saudi Arabia.

Machchhar's parents Upendra and Gita who live at Swastik

Heights, left for Dubai on Thursday morning to be with Machchhar's wife Sonal and their two grandchildren. According to Machchhar's uncle Kishor, the pilot moved to Dubai in 2022 to work with flydubai. Prior to that he had worked for 11 years at SpiceJet where he was a senior commander and a line training captain who trained and supervised other pilots. Machchhar, 38, also started an aviation institute in Ghatkopar east called FlyBy Aviation Academy which is at present being managed by his cousin Pooja Ganatra. The pilot has logged 9,750 flying hours on the 737-800 and the 737 MAX 8 and 9. On Thursday, American media called him the "Indian Sully" comparing him to Chesley Sullenberger, best-known for landing safely landing a US Airways flight on the Hudson River in New York after a bird hit disabled its engines.

Smit Machchhar, originally from Rajkot, grew up in the predominantly Gujarati middle class neighbourhood of Ghatkopar east where the family runs a printing press business. He studied at Ramji Assar and VS Gandhi Gurukul Technical School and did an MBA from Welinkar Institute. He completed his flying course from New Zealand and joined SpiceJet where he worked for 11 years.

Bhavin Mehta, who runs a cafe in Ghatkopar and who studied with Machchhar, told HT that their school WhatsApp group was "full of praise and prayers for Captain Smit."

MAN WANTED IN '24 MURDER OF VHP LEADER DEPORTED

NEW DELHI: Harwinder Kumar, an accused linked to the terrorist organisation Babbar Khalsa International (BKI), was deported from the UAE on Thursday and taken into custody by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) in connection with the 2024 killing of Vishwa Hindu Parishad leader Vikas Prabhakar in Punjab's Nangal area, the agency said in a statement.

A special NIA court granted a 2-day transit remand of Kumar to produce him before an NIA court in Chandigarh on Friday.

"Indian agencies achieved a major breakthrough in securing the deportation of Harwinder Kumar, alias Sonu Barnala, who is linked to the murder of VHP leader Vikas Prabhakar in Nangal, Punjab. Prabhakar was shot dead by operatives of the terror organisation Babbar Khalsa International (BKI) in an attempt to create communal unrest, at the behest of its Pakistan-based chief, Wadhawa Singh, alias Babbar," MHA said in an X post. **HTC**

WIFE HIRES MEN TO ABDUCT HUSBAND, RAPE GIRLFRIEND

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: A woman was abducted and raped, and her boyfriend was severely beaten by a six-member gang that was allegedly hired by the man's wife in Thrissur district of Kerala, police said on Thursday.

Five people, including the man's wife, have been arrested by the Thrissur police for alleged involvement in the crime, the officers said. "The incident took place on September 22 when the couple checked into a lodge in Thrissur. A gang of six, posing as police officers, barged into the room and kidnapped them," Thrissur City Police Commissioner Nakul Rajendra Deshmukh told HT.

The couple was taken to Tiruppur in Tamil Nadu, the officer said, where the man was thrashed and abandoned. The woman was moved to a separate car and allegedly raped inside it, said an officer. The officer added that the man's wife had tracked his mobile phone's location to the lodge in Thrissur. **VISHNU VARMA**

SC denies Ilayaraaja relief in song copyright case

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to interfere with a Delhi High Court ruling that music composer Ilayaraaja did not own the copyright in the lyrics and sound recording of the popular song "En Iniya Pon Nilave" from the Tamil film Moodu Pani, holding that the rights in the sound recording vested with music label Saregama.

A bench of justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran declined to entertain Ilayaraaja's

challenge to the high court's May orders, which had dismissed his pleas against earlier rulings upholding an injunction in favour of Saregama.

The dispute arose after Vels Film International Ltd recreated "En Iniya Pon Nilave" for its film 'Aghathiya', claiming to have obtained the necessary rights from Ilayaraaja. Saregama objected to the use of the recreated version, asserting that it owned the copyright in the original sound recording by virtue of an assignment from the film's producer.

Senior advocates CA Sundaram



Ilayaraaja

and Swathi Sukumar appeared for Ilayaraaja. Saregama was represented by senior counsel Mukul Rohatgi. The Delhi High Court, in its earlier proceedings, held that Ilayaraaja retained copyright in the musical work — the tune or

composition, but not in the sound recording or the lyrics of the song. It also held that he could not have assigned to Vels Film International rights that he himself did not own.

The division bench had affirmed the injunction granted by a single judge restraining the use of the recreated version of the song. It held that the copyright in the sound recordings of Moodu Pani, including "En Iniya Pon Nilave", had vested with RCA, the original holder, and was subsequently transferred to Saregama under a February 1980 agreement.

"Without a licence, or permis-

sion, from SIL, therefore, VFIL could not have exploited any of the sound recordings contained in the film Moodu Pani, including the sound recording relating to the song En Iniya Pon Nilave," the high court had said.

Ilayaraaja had argued that as the composer and author of the musical work, he remained the first owner of copyright in the composition. The single judge rejected the contention and granted an injunction in favour of Saregama and later upheld the decision, after which Ilayaraaja moved the Supreme Court.

Hindustan Times

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



Freeze vehicle services over traffic fines, says SC

Utkarsh Anand

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has directed states and Union territories (UTs) to freeze online and other vehicle-related services, including renewal of registration, issuance of fitness and pollution under-control certificates, ownership transfers and even renewal of driving licences, where traffic fines remain unpaid, as part of a nationwide push to make electronic enforcement of road-safety laws more effective.

A bench of Justices JB Pardiwala and KV Viswanathan, in an order released on Thursday, also directed that vehicles with outstanding e-challans be blacklisted on the central Parivahan portal, blocking their sale or transfer, while no centre should be permitted to issue a PUC certificate until pending traffic fines are cleared. In cases involving multiple violations, authorities have been told to suspend renewal of the driving licence and take steps to suspend an existing licence.

The bench said merely issuing thousands or lakhs of e-challans served little purpose unless authorities were able to recover the fines. The court was informed that about ₹49,194.05 crore was outstanding against e-challans issued over a period of time, of which ₹26,175.05 crore had been recovered so far.

It emphasised that authorities had to work at the "ground level having regard to the ground realities", and directed: "What is expected of the authorities insofar as effective implementation of recovery of fine etc. is concerned is to freeze the online services for vehicles which have outstanding amounts. The Authorities shall bar from renewing registration certificate, issuing duplicate registration certificate and also shall not entertain any request for updating owner's address etc. The authorities shall also deny fitness certificate until all pending traffic fines are entirely cleared and further there should be blacklisting of the vehicle concerned on the Parivahan Portal."

For multiple violations, the court held, the driving license shall be suspended from renewal and measures shall also be taken to suspend a license already in force. "What is most important is

Key directions

₹49,194cr	E-CHALLANS PENDING RECOVERY NATIONWIDE	₹26,175cr	AMOUNT RECOVERED SO FAR
● Freeze registration renewal, duplicate RC and address update	● Blacklist vehicle to prevent sale or transfer on Parivahan portal		
● Fitness certificate to be denied until fines are cleared	● Renewal of driving licence to be suspended for repeat violators		
● Pollution certificate not to be issued over unpaid fines	● Five or more violations in a year can trigger action against licence		
● Authorities to take steps to impound vehicles when e-challans remain unpaid	● States and UTs told to implement MoRTH's electronic monitoring SOP on highways and major roads		



that no Centre should be permitted to issue PUC certificate," the order added.

The order came in a 2012 road-safety case in which the bench has been monitoring implementation of the Motor Vehicles Act and Central Motor Vehicles Rules for nearly 14 years. The judges expressed concern that directions could continue to remain on paper if authorities failed to implement them on the ground.

Electronic enforcement

The court further directed all states and UTs to forthwith implement the Standard Operating Procedure prepared by the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways on October 28, 2025, and comply with Section 136A of the Motor Vehicles Act, 1988, read with Rule 167A of the Central Motor Vehicles Rules.

The provisions require electronic monitoring and enforcement of road safety through technologies such as speed cameras, CCTV cameras and speed guns. States and UTs have been asked to notify e-enforcement sites, finalise procurement, deployment and calibration of enforcement devices, while the National Road Safety Board has been directed to monitor the implementation.

Underlining that electronic enforcement could not end with the generation of an e-challan, the court directed random checking of vehicles and said that if a vehicle was found to have an e-challan that had not been hon-

oured, authorities should take necessary steps to impound it.

The bench also took note of an amended Rule 21(25), brought into force in 2026, under which commission of five or more offences or contraventions under the Motor Vehicles Act or Rules in a one-year period constitutes an act of nuisance or danger to the public.

Compliance on ground

The bench's concern over implementation was particularly evident in relation to Delhi. It asked whether its directions issued on September 15 had been complied with and was informed by amicus curiae and senior advocate Gaurav Agrawal that, despite his September 19 communication to the Delhi chief secretary, there had been no response.

The directions concerned pedestrian safety on Mathura Road near the Delhi High Court and the National Zoological Park, including functional pedestrian signals, synchronised red lights, speed-limiting measures and electronic enforcement.

The court directed the Delhi chief secretary to file a compliance report and warned that if the directions were not complied with, the chief secretary would have to personally appear before the bench on the next date.

The bench, noting that it had spent almost a year issuing directions in the matter, said it had put an "unusual question" to the amicus -- whether the effort had

yielded positive results on the ground.

It has now asked the amicus to prepare a comprehensive chart of all directions issued by the bench, specifying the date of each direction, the time granted for implementation, its current status and the amicus's remarks. State counsel have been asked to provide information sought by the amicus through interrogatories.

Overloaded vehicles

On overloading, the court directed authorities to ensure that the suggestions placed before it are acted upon, including preventing an overloaded transport vehicle from proceeding beyond the point of detection until the excess load is removed.

The application before the court pointed out that overloading increases braking distance and the risk of brake failure, tyre blowouts and rollovers, while also reducing steering control and vehicle stability.

The proposed enforcement framework includes integration of weigh-in-motion and weigh-bridge systems with toll-management and electronic enforcement systems so that action against overloaded vehicles cannot be defeated merely because a vehicle is registered in or moves into another state.

Footpath policy

The bench also sought a more comprehensive report from the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) on implementation of its Universal Footpath Policy of May 26, 2023.

The BMC told the court that it was preparing a geospatially mapped digital inventory of existing and missing footpaths and integrating the exercise with its GIS platform and 3D city model. The court directed that a report be filed on further steps taken and stressed adherence to the timelines for implementation of the policy.

The matter arises from the Supreme Court's continuing monitoring of road safety under S Rajaseekaran Vs Union of India, a litigation that began in 2012 and has seen the court issue a series of directions aimed at making statutory road-safety requirements enforceable beyond the issuance of orders and challans.

Canadian foreign min set to visit India in mid-Oct

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TORONTO/NEW DELHI: Canadian foreign minister Anita Anand is expected to visit India in mid-October as part of ramped up contacts between the two countries that are racing to conclude negotiations on a trade deal by the year-end, people familiar with the matter said.

New Delhi and Ottawa hope to finalise their negotiations for a comprehensive economic partnership agreement (CEPA) ahead of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's planned visit to Canada in December. Anand is expected to be in India during October 12-15 though the visit is yet to be formally announced by both sides, the people said on condition of anonymity.

This will be Anand's third visit to India since she became foreign minister in May 2025 -- she travelled to the country in October 2025 and again in March this year, when she accompanied Prime Minister Mark Carney on a trip. Her visit will also coincide with a trip by Canada's trade minister Maninder Sidhu, his second trip in



Anita Anand

less than a month, to take forward the trade talks.

While in New Delhi, Anand is expected to hold talks with external affairs minister S Jaishankar to take stock of progress in implementing a roadmap for bilateral relations that was finalised during her last visit in October 2025, and preparations for Modi's visit to Canada, the people said. The roadmap sets out shared objectives in trade, security, defence, energy, mobility and innovation.

Anand is also set to speak at the Bloomberg New Economy Forum in New Delhi, the people said.

Sidhu and Anand are set to travel to India after the fifth round of negotiations on the trade deal in Canada in early October.

The trade talks between India and Canada have gained momentum at a time when both coun-

tries are coping with fresh tensions in their economic ties with the US. The Trump administration recently banned Canadian imports worth almost \$1 billion, including alcoholic beverages and dairy products, after imposing 50% tariffs on other imports worth \$20 billion. The Indian side has raised with the US its concerns over a new Russia sanctions law that threatens 100% tariffs on Indian goods.

HT reported earlier that most of the key issues related to the proposed India-Canada trade deal have been resolved by bureaucrats, and frequent political interventions are now required to iron out contentious matters that require ministerial authority.

The flurry of high-level visits reflect the improvement in overall bilateral ties, which had fallen to their lowest level in decades after former Canadian prime minister Justin Trudeau accused Indian government agents of involvement in the 2023 killing of Khalistani separatist Hardeep Singh Nijjar. India dismissed the allegation and both sides resorted to a number of punitive actions.

HC junks 34% OBC quota in Andhra local body elections, gives 6 weeks

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HYDERABAD: The Andhra Pradesh high court on Thursday struck down the state government's orders providing 34% reservation for Other Backward Classes (OBCs) in the local body elections, holding that the orders were contrary to the Supreme Court's prescribed limit of 50% on total reservations.

A division bench comprising Chief Justice Justice Lisa Gill and justice Challa Gunaranjan, passed the orders after hearing a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) filed by advocate Tandava Yogesh and others, challenging the two government orders providing 34% reservation for OBCs in elections to local bodies.

The bench observed that the

CM NAIDU SAID HIS GOVT WOULD FILE AN SLP IN THE SC TODAY TO RESTORE 34% FOR THE OBCS IN LOCAL BODIES

government orders could not be sustained in view of the Supreme Court's judgments on reservation in local body elections.

"We hold that the two GOs are not sustainable to the extent of vertical reservation to SCs, STs and OBCs collectively or in aggregate exceeding 50% and are hence set aside," the bench said.

The bench said it is open for the state to revisit the issue and determine the percentage of reservation for Backward Classes beyond 50% after completing the

exercise of collection of data (through a dedicated commission) in compliance with a Supreme Court judgment.

In another direction, the court allowed PILs seeking immediate conduct of elections to gram panchayats and urban local bodies and directed the State Election Commission (SEC) to complete the election process within six weeks.

The court made it clear that the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls could not be cited as a reason to indefinitely postpone local body elections.

Chief minister N Chandrababu Naidu announced that his government would file a special leave petition in the Supreme Court on Friday to restore 34% for the OBCs in local bodies.



All 5 NPP MLAs merge with ruling NPF in Nagaland

KOHIKA: All five MLAs of the National People's Party (NPP) in Nagaland on Thursday joined the ruling Naga People's Front (NPF). The NPF now has 39 members in the 60-member state assembly.

HC imposes ₹10k cost on CM Soren over adjournment

RANCHI: The Jharkhand high court imposed a cost of ₹10,000 on chief minister Hemant Soren after his counsel sought an adjournment in ED officers' plea on Thursday, challenging criminal proceedings against them in a case linked to their search at his Delhi residence. The matter will be heard next November 2.

Goondas Act invoked against Veeramani, aides

CHENNAI: The Chennai Police has invoked the Goondas Act against granite baron R Veeramani and his two aides Mahendra and Shanthi, as the SIT lodged a fourth case of sexual assault of minors against him, police said on Thursday.

SC seeks replies from WB, Centre on Moitra's plea

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday sought responses from the West Bengal government and the Centre on a petition by Trinamool Congress (TMC) MP Mahua Moitra alleging that the state administration was obstructing her functioning as an elected representative in her Krishnanagar constituency. The plea also alleged Moitra was asked to vacate the Circuit House at night on Aug 14.

CUSTOMS IMPOSES ₹89-CR PENALTY ON ACTOR RANYA

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BENGALURU: The Customs Department has imposed a penalty of ₹89 crore on Kannada actor Ranya Rao, holding her liable for violations related to the alleged smuggling of gold from Dubai to India, officials aware of the matter said on Thursday.

The adjudication order, issued by Customs department joint director Sandeep on Wednesday, also imposes a ₹49.51 crore penalty on Tarun Konduru Raju and ₹53.06 crore each on Sahil Jain and Bharat Kumar Jain, the people said.

A Customs officer familiar with the proceedings said the financial penalty proceedings are distinct from the criminal case. "The Customs proceedings concern the alleged violations under the Customs Act. The order records the findings of the adjudication proceedings and determines the penalty liability of the persons concerned. The accused have legal remedies available against the order," the officer said.

The Customs investigation relates to alleged smuggling between March 7, 2024, and February 18, 2025. Investigators have alleged that about 113 kg of gold was brought into India from Dubai through a network involving Rao and the other accused.

2 ascetics' burnt bodies found inside UP temple, land dispute suspected

HT Correspondent

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MEERUT: Two ascetics were allegedly murdered on Thursday and their bodies set on fire inside a temple in Uttar Pradesh's Shahjahanpur district where they resided, police said, adding that a local man has been detained for questioning following allegations that he wanted them to leave to establish control over the shrine.

According to police, the incident took place at a Shiva temple in Sutha village, around 70 km from the district headquarters. Villagers noticed smoke rising from the temple at around 7 am on Thursday. The deceased were identified as Gopal Das, 70, and Bihari Das, 60, police said.

Pradeep Singh, the nephew of Bihari Das, alleged that a local man, Sumeet, was responsible for the murders. He claimed that Sumeet had attacked the two ascetics several times in the past.

Superintendent of police (rural) Diksha Bhavre said police received information through the police response vehicle about two ascetics being burnt at the temple. "When Khudaganj police reached the spot, the bodies were found severely burnt. The suspect, Sumeet Singh, has

POLICE SAID THE ACCUSED HAS ADMITTED TO KILLING THE TWO AND SETTING THEIR BODIES ON FIRE

been detained and is being questioned," she said.

The temple caretaker, Shiv Kumar Singh, submitted a complaint in connection with the incident.

According to police, Sumeet, a resident of the same village, had returned from jail in August and started spending time with the priests at the temple.

SSP Saurabh Dixit said: "Villagers initially confirmed that Sumeet had, on one occasion, told the two ascetics to leave the place as he is going to stay there. He said that he will have exclusive control over this place".

Prima facie, the police suspect that the incident occurred late Wednesday over a dispute.

During preliminary questioning, Singh allegedly admitted to attacking the priests and setting their bodies on fire, police said, adding that the bodies have been sent for an autopsy.

ORISSA HC REJECTS VEDANTA PLEA TO RESTORE 2004 BAUXITE PRICING

BHUBANESWAR: The Orissa high court on Thursday dismissed mining conglomerate Vedanta Limited's writ petition seeking long-term bauxite supply at historical 2004 agreement rates holding that the equitable doctrine of promissory estoppel cannot override statutory provisions or be invoked to restrict the state's handling of national natural resources held in public trust.

A bench of chief justice Harish Tandon and justice Murahari Sri Raman, held that the termination of joint venture between Vedanta and Odisha Mining Corporation (OMC) in 2015 had attained finality.

Vedanta was seeking, among other reliefs, directions to OMC and the state to provide at least 150 million tonnes of bauxite, after deducting about 20 MT supplied since 2018, at prices flowing from the 2004 and subsequent agreements. Rejecting the contentions, the court ruled that natural resources represent national wealth where the government acts as a trustee, rendering promissory estoppel inapplicable as an instrument of attack. A spokesperson of Vedanta Aluminium said the firm is evaluating the order. "The order does not impact the supply of bauxite to Vedanta Aluminium," **DEBABRATA MOHANTY**

Indore meet to operationalise RSS changes

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NEW DELHI: The Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh's (RSS) executive council meeting that will begin in Indore in November will put into effect the changes that are being made to the structure of the Sangh, take stock of the organisation's centenary celebrations and deliberate on current political and social issues including the opposition's sharpened attacks on the government over the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR), said people aware of the details.

The three-day meeting, beginning November 2, is known as the Akhil Bharatiya Karyakarni Mandal (ABKM) and is held annually but its agenda is significant this



The three-day meeting will begin on November 2.

year as it comes three months ahead of the organisational elections that will be held at the Akhil Bharatiya Pratidinhi Sabha (ABPS) in March next year.

The ABPS is the highest decision making body of the Sangh and elections are held every three years. "We will take stock of the centenary celebrations and the impact of the outreach that was

planned. But since this meeting comes ahead of the ABPS and the elections for picking the new Sarkaryavah (general secretary) the meeting will roll out the new organisational structure of replacing Prants with Sambhags (division)," said a Sangh functionary aware of the details.

To maximise their reach and increase the boots on the ground, the Sangh is replacing prant pracharaks (regional coordinators) with sambhag pracharaks (divisional coordinators). The new structure will increase the number of pracharaks from 46 to 85 but the kendras (state level) will come down from 11 to 9.

Following the meeting in November, the state units will elect new karyakarnis (executive body

at the state level), the Sambhag sanghachalak, and the kshetra sanghachalak who in turn will elect the new general secretary. The last election took place in 2024, when Dattatreya Hosabale was elected for a second term.

The Sangh brass will also deliberate on the current political and policy issues such as the controversy surrounding the SIR and the concerns over the implementation of the uniform civil code (UCC). On Tuesday, head of the Sangh's outreach Sunil Ambekar reiterated the need for UCC and a mechanism such as the National Register of Citizens to identify those who are illegal residents.

Speaking at an event in the Capital he called for a policy to rectify the anomalies in the electoral rolls.

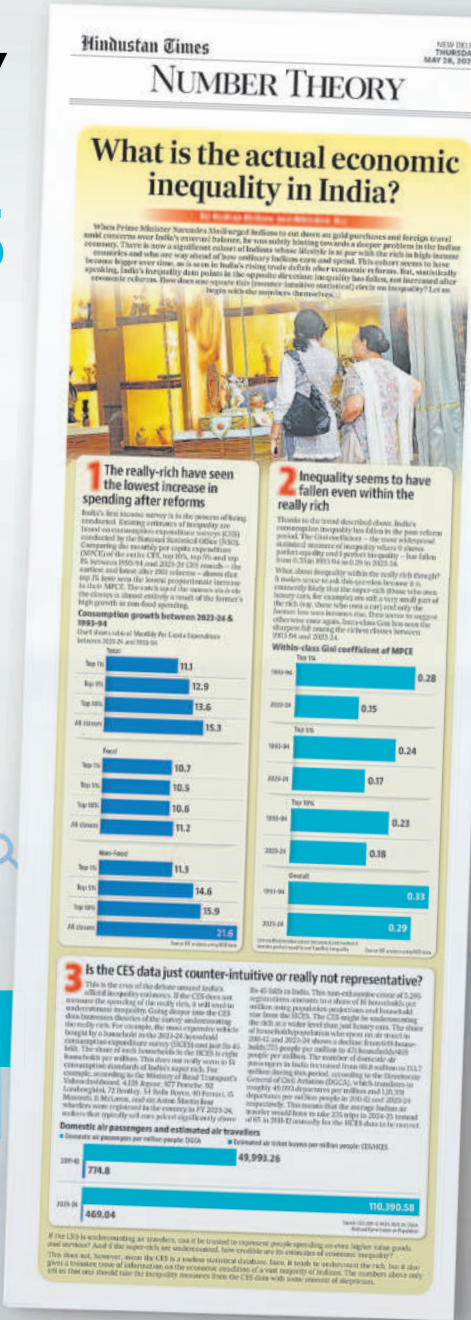
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EVERYONE HAS A THEORY OURS HAS THE NUMBERS

Hindustan Times NUMBER THEORY

Go beyond opinions with evidence-backed insights that uncover hidden trends, challenge assumptions and reveal a deeper understanding of the stories shaping India and the world.

LOOK FOR NUMBER THEORY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



{ FIRST JUDGE FROM 9-MEMBER BENCH TO DO SO }

Justice Nagarathna starts writing Sabarimala order

Utkarsh Anand

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NEW DELHI: Justice BV Nagarathna has become the first judge on the nine-member constitution bench to start writing the judgment in the long-pending Sabarimala reference, setting the stage for a verdict that could redefine the Supreme Court's approach to religious freedom, judicial review and the "essential religious practices" doctrine.

The development assumes significance as Justice Nagarathna was the only woman judge on the bench that heard the 16-day marathon proceedings and had, during the hearings, expressed views on several of the core constitutional questions arising from the dispute, including the role of the "essential religious practices" doctrine.

The nine-judge bench headed by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant had reserved its judgment on May 14 after hearing arguments on the constitutional questions referred to it following the 2018 Sabarimala verdict.

Besides the CJI and Justice Nagarathna, the bench comprises justices MM Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah, Aravind Kumar, Augustine George Masih, Prasanna B Varale, R Mahadevan and Joymalya Bagchi. To be sure, other members of the nine-judge bench are also free to write separate opinions.

The reference originates from the Supreme Court's September 2018 judgment, by a 4:1 majority, allowing women of all ages to enter the Sabarimala temple in Kerala. The verdict had held that the exclusion of women between the ages of 10 and 50 from the temple could not withstand constitutional scrutiny.

The subsequent review proceedings led to the larger constitutional reference, with the court deciding to examine broader questions concerning the relationship between Articles 14, 25



Justice BV Nagarathna

and 26 of the Constitution, the scope of judicial review of religious practices, the meaning of religious denomination and the extent to which courts can employ the essential religious practices doctrine.

Justice Nagarathna's authorship is particularly noteworthy given her own record of speaking independently in Constitution Bench matters.

She was the lone dissenter in the Supreme Court's 2023 demonetisation verdict, holding that the Centre could not invalidate the entire series of ₹500 and ₹1,000 notes merely through a notification and that the exercise ought to have been undertaken through legislation.

She was also the sole dissenting judge in the nine-judge Constitution Bench verdict on the Centre and states' legislative powers over industrial alcohol, differing with the majority on important aspects of the scope of the states' power under Entry 8 of List II of the Seventh Schedule.

Her dissenting voice was also significant in the 2024 nine-judge constitution bench judgment on mineral taxation, which examined whether royalty payable under the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act, 1957, was a tax. The majority held that royalty was not a tax but a payment made by

a mining lessee to the state for the right to extract minerals, and consequently held that states could impose taxes on mineral rights. It also held that mineral-bearing land could be treated as "land" under Entry 49 of the State List, permitting states to levy tax on such land.

But Justice Nagarathna disagreed, holding that royalty under the MMDR Act was itself a statutory tax on mineral rights and that mineral-bearing land could not be subjected to another layer of state taxation. She held that the constitutional taxation entries were mutually exclusive and that allowing both the parliamentary levy under Entry 50 and a state levy under Entry 49 would result in double taxation. She also cautioned that overlapping state taxes could fragment the country's fiscal policy and encourage unhealthy competition among states. The position taken in her dissent has acquired fresh relevance with the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026, which clarifies that royalty under the 1957 law is itself a tax on mineral rights, leaving no scope for states to impose additional levies under Entry 49 or Entry 50.

The Sabarimala proceedings themselves saw Justice Nagarathna engage closely with the competing claims over religious autonomy and constitutional scrutiny. During the hearings, she suggested that the essential religious practices doctrine could have a limited role as an aid to determine whether a practice was genuinely religious, rather than operate as a test for denying constitutional protection to a religious practice.

She also questioned whether the original petition challenging the Sabarimala custom was maintainable at the instance of people who were not themselves devotees, while examining the constitutional basis for judicial

intervention in matters of faith.

The judgment she has now begun writing will therefore be closely watched for the manner in which the bench resolves the difficult questions that have surrounded the reference for nearly seven years.

The 2018 Sabarimala verdict itself had an important dissent from another woman judge, Justice Indu Malhotra. While then CJI Dipak Misra and justices RF Nariman, AM Khanwilkar and DY Chandrachud formed the majority that struck down the exclusion of women between the ages of 10 and 50, Justice Malhotra differed.

She held that the challenge should not have been entertained and that the exclusionary practice was protected by the devotees' right to freely practise religion under Article 25. She also cautioned against courts determining matters of religious belief through notions of rationality or constitutional morality.

Thus, nearly eight years after Justice Malhotra stood alone in dissent against the judgment opening the Sabarimala temple to women of all ages, another woman judge on the Supreme Court is now writing the judgment arising from the larger constitutional examination of the very questions that emerged from that verdict.

Justice Nagarathna was elevated to the Supreme Court in August 2021 after serving as a judge of the Karnataka high court. Born on October 30, 1962, she began practising law in 1987 and became a permanent judge of the Karnataka high court in 2010. She is due to retire on October 29, 2027. Under the established seniority convention and the present line of succession, Justice Nagarathna is in line to become the first woman Chief Justice of India. Her elevation to the top judicial office would come in 2027, before her retirement later that year.

8 students on picnic drown off Maha beach

Vicky Pathare

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MUMBAI: Eight 16-year-old students of a private coaching institute drowned in the Arabian Sea while on a picnic at the Diveagar beach in Maharashtra's Raigad district on Thursday, with the bodies of all the victims recovered, police said.

These students of Class 11 and 12 were part of a group from coaching institute 'Winners Academy' based at Alandi in Pune district, they said.

Located around 170 km from Mumbai, Diveagar is famous for its beach and historic temples.

A police officer said a group of 48 students — 25 boys, 17 girls and six teachers — had gone for a picnic at the beach for an educational excursion under Dighi coastal police station limits.



The students of Class 11 and 12 were visiting Diveagar beach in Raigad on Thursday. PTI

Eight students ventured into the sea and were swept away after misjudging the depth of the water and current, he added. Search and rescue teams rushed to the spot following an alert and recovered the bodies, he said.

Police identified the deceased as Yash Kiran Wankhede,

Soham Tukaram Bhandwalkar, Tanmay Dattatray Vahile, Kausubh Sandeep Daund, Kaivalya Satish Wasankar, Rajveer Yuvraj Vahile, Pranav Ramdas Bansod and Sumit Bharat Ahire. All of them were 16 years old.

Terming the incident as "heart-breaking", Shiv Sena MLA Mahendra Dalvi, who represents the Alibag assembly constituency in Raigad district, blamed the local administration for the "lack of adequate safety precautions".

"Such incidents keep happening there time and again, so the local administration must take safety precautions. Young schoolchildren may not be able to assess the risks posed by the sea, including high tide and the depth of water," he said.

"Schoolchildren have no idea about the sea. It's not a pond, it's

the sea....They cannot gauge the high tide or the depth of the water. Moreover, these children might not even know how to swim," Dalvi said, urging the local MLA and MP to look into the issue.

Prashant Kurhade, chairman of the Alandi Municipal Council, told PTI that some of the students were from Alandi town itself, while others were from neighbouring Kelgaon. "We have been contacting the families," he said, adding that some of the parents had already left for Diveagar.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis in a post on X termed the deaths as extremely tragic and painful. Condoling with the families who lost their children, he said the local administration was coordinating the transportation of the bodies.

JUDGE QUESTIONS QUALITY OF HC'S FULL COURT MEETS

PRAYAGRAJ: Allahabad high court judge justice Vinod Diwakar has questioned the quality of deliberations in Full Court meetings, observing that the proceedings do not record the concurrence or dissent of individual judges.

A Full Court comprises all judges of the high court and is convened to deliberate on important administrative and institutional matters.

In a judgment dated September 28, Justice Diwakar also called for a recalibration of the "Chief Justice-centric" model of high court administration, emphasising the need for a more deliberative, institutionally balanced and participative approach, along with stronger institutional accountability.

The cumulative effect of these issues, the court said, "erodes the conditions in which judicial character forms".

Justice Diwakar directed the registrar to place the judgment before the chief justice "for His Lordship's kind perusal and for such further steps as His Lordship may deem fit and appropriate in respect of the issues noticed herein".

Mahanadi row: Odisha, C'garh CMs meet Shah

Debabrata Mohanty and Ritesh Mishra

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BHUBANESWAR/RAIPUR: The Centre's efforts to resolve the long-running dispute over sharing of Mahanadi river water between Odisha and Chhattisgarh received a fresh push on Thursday, with chief ministers Mohan Charan Majhi and Vishnu Deo Sai putting forward their concerns at a meeting chaired by Union home minister Amit Shah in New Delhi, officials aware of the matter said.

The meeting decided to continue data sharing and consultations between the two states as per CWC-facilitated process for next one month. Union Jal Shakti minister CR Patil, Central Water Commission (CWC) chairman, the chief secretaries of the two states and senior officials were also present at the meeting, they said.

In July, the two states had agreed to continue technical-level discussions through the CWC after a meeting between Majhi and Sai chaired by Patil. They have since submitted the information sought by the commission.



Amit Shah

ANI

Majhi said the two states were "gradually moving closer to a solution that would serve as a model for dispute resolution for others". "The Mahanadi is the lifeline of Odisha providing livelihoods to millions of people in the state," he said, adding that he raised concerns over irrigation, flood control, hydropower and drinking water.

Sai stressed Chhattisgarh's water requirements, and called for a "win-win" settlement based on fairness, scientific assessment, transparency and long-term sustainability. "Mahanadi originates in Chhattisgarh and that more than half of its catchment area falls within the state. The water requirements of state's farmers, irrigation sector and tribal areas should therefore be duly considered as part of any settlement."

RAM TEMPLE STAFF TO GET NO-POCKET 1-PIECE UNIFORMS

LUCKNOW: The Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust has mandated a one-piece saffron uniform without pockets for all employees involved in counting offerings, with security checks every time they enter or leave the counting room, officials familiar with the matter said, adding that the move aims to tighten cash-handling procedures and internal security.

Cell phones will also be prohibited in the sanctum and other sensitive areas of the temple campus, with staff expected to leave personal belongings outside restricted zones.

The arrangement comes after new CEO Air Marshal Jeetendra Mishra (retired) ordered clear definition of roles and responsibilities of all employees so that accountability for any lapse could be fixed. Employees have to wear the prescribed pocketless saffron uniform and sit on the floor during the counting process. The trust has also introduced a new dress code, which requires priests to wear yellow silk 'achala' and 'uttariya' - dhoti and cloth draped over upper body, replacing the earlier 'chaubandi' attire.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

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EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



DGCA FACELIFT

The report lists gaps in technical expertise, manpower, enforcement and the timely resolution of safety findings. It singles out the shortage of technical staff as one of the most pressing.

The regulator has had a long history of misses and inadequate regulatory action. In March, the parliamentary standing committee on transport, tourism and culture said recent incidents, among them the June 2025 crash of Air India flight AI 171 that killed 260 people, pointed to "systemic rather than episodic failures" in India's aviation safety architecture. It found 787 of DGCA's 1,630 sanctioned posts vacant. A DGCA audit from January 2025 to February 2026 had found recurring technical defects in 377 of 754 aircraft, half of those it checked.

When IndiGo cancelled more than 2,500 flights in three days last December, the regulator gave the airline sweeping exemptions from crew-fatigue norms. Pilots had won those norms after 13 years of litigation that began with the 2010 Mangalore crash, which killed 158 people.

DGCA later sacked four inspectors who oversaw IndiGo and removed a key officer, and MoCA ordered an internal inquiry "to identify and implement systemic improvements within the DGCA".

The IndiGo episode was followed by lapses at smaller operators, which surfaced only after accidents. DGCA grounded four aircraft of charter operator VSR after the January crash at Bara-mati that killed then Maharashtra deputy chief minister Ajit Pawar. In July, the ministry pulled up the regulator over officials' undisclosed family links with airlines it oversees.

The overhaul recommendation comes ahead of a visit by a five-member team of the US Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) to assess India's safety oversight from November 16 to 20, HT reported in September.

In August 2025, the parliamentary committee sought a time-bound plan to give the DGCA financial and administrative autonomy; the ministry replied that direct recruitment by the DGCA was not under consideration. This August, the Federation of Indian Pilots wrote to Prime Minister Naren-

dra Modi seeking a Civil Aviation Authority in the DGCA's place.

A similar suggestion was tabled in 2011. In May that year, a Parliamentary Standing Committee report on DGCA recommended reviewing the authority structure to explore reforms that would render the DGCA more agile, granting it greater administrative and financial autonomy commensurate with its regulatory responsibilities.

Under the latest proposed law, a governing board headed by the director general (civil aviation) would run the authority. Its whole-time members would come from the DGCA cadre and its part-time members from the industry, with an advisory committee of industry experts alongside. The DG and whole-time members would be picked through a specialised search-and-selection process and serve five-year terms.

The authority would pay its way through service fees, certification charges, penalties and the passenger levy, all of which its board could revise. "This financial autonomy would shield it from the constraints of government budget cycles and enable it to invest in necessary infrastructure and staffing," the report said. The government could provide grants until the authority became self-sufficient, and the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG) would audit its books every year.

The report calls the ₹15 levy, drawn from a ministry study by Centre for Asia Pacific Aviation (CAPA), a "modest charge" that would fund the authority's operations "but also allowing for the generation of surplus funds".

Passengers would also get an independent ombudsman. "An independent Ombudsman shall be established to act as a vital intermediary, addressing grievances related to flight cancellations, delays, lost luggage, and other service related issues, which would significantly enhance consumer protection," the report states.

Recognising that law-making takes time, the committee does not want the regulator left waiting. "Until an independent body is established through the enactment of appropriate legislation, it is crucial to implement incremental measures that directly address some of the

pressing issues currently confronting DGCA," it noted.

Some of these measures include hiring technical staff to address shortage and strengthening the regional and sub-regional offices.

Among the longer-term fixes, the report backs the parliamentary committee's call for an Indian Civil Aviation Service, a Group 'A' cadre that would give the regulator a steady supply of trained officers.

Queries sent to the DGCA and MoCA did not elicit a response.

PM LAUDS MACHCHHAR

Israeli officials said on Thursday that no motive had been established and that their initial assessment was that the co-pilot, an Omani national who has not been named, acted alone.

Addressing a function in New Delhi to mark the centenary of the Union Public Service Commission, Modi said Machchhar had shown "remarkable patience, presence of mind, and courage".

"Indeed, as the Prime Minister of Israel stated today, an Indian prevented a 9/11-style tragedy," Modi said. He was referring to the September 11, 2001, attacks, in which hijacked airliners were flown into the World Trade Center and the Pentagon, killing nearly 3,000 people.

Hours earlier, Modi spoke to Machchhar's wife and parents, officials aware of the matter told HT, asking not to be named. He told them Indian missions were providing all possible help to the passengers and crew.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu called it "an amazing act of heroism — of his, of the Indian pilot, of the people who helped them. They stopped a disaster that could have been global." Netanyahu also praised an Israeli passenger who helped subdue the attacker.

President Droupadi Murmu said: "The nation is proud of Captain Smit Machchhar. His heroic courage and incredible presence of mind have deeply touched us all." Politicians across parties posted messages of praise and wishes for his recovery.

On Wednesday night, the Indian embassy in Riyadh said Machchhar had been admitted to a hospital in Tabuk and was in stable condition. He underwent surgery there, people aware of the matter said. He was moved to the UAE a day later. The

Indian mission in the UAE said it remained in close coordination with local authorities on his care.

Two Israeli security officials said Israel's initial assessment was that the co-pilot was likely acting alone, though the investigation was continuing, Reuters reported.

Netanyahu said the attacker was being investigated in Saudi Arabia and that he believed he would be taken to the UAE.

Israel's envoy to the UAE, Yossi Shelley, told Reuters it was too early to draw conclusions. Another Israeli official said Israel was not receiving all the information it sought from the Saudis, and that its intelligence agencies, Mossad and Shin Bet, were also investigating. Saudi Arabia's government media office did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

Flight-tracking data from Flightradar24 and ADS-B Exchange, analysed by HT, show the jet was cruising at 34,000 feet over Saudi Arabia when it began to descend at 8.21am Saudi time (10.51am IST), about 235km north-east of Tabuk.

Between two readings 37 seconds apart, it fell from 33,225 feet to 18,925 feet, a rate of about 23,000 feet a minute. An airliner descending normally would take about seven minutes to lose that much height. The plane later transmitted the transponder code for a hijacking, and it crossed briefly into Jordan before turning back.

Photographs of the aircraft at Tabuk appear to show the rudder torn from its tail, damage that can occur when control surfaces are moved too hard at high speed. HT could not independently verify the photographs.

In Mumbai, residents of Swastik Heights, the housing society in Tilak Nagar, Chembur, where Machchhar's parents live, gathered in the compound on Thursday afternoon to cheer the pilot

and call for a civilian honour for him.

"We are so proud that Smit saved so many lives," said his uncle, Kishor Machchhar. Vipul Mehta, a family friend, promised a "grand felicitation" when the pilot returns to Mumbai.

His parents, Upendra and Gita, left for Dubai on Thursday morning to join his wife, Sonal, and the couple's two children.

Some American media outlets called him the "Indian Sully", after Chesley Sullenberger, the US Airways captain who glided his crippled jet onto the Hudson River in New York in 2009 after birds knocked out both engines.

Machchhar's family is originally from Rajkot in Gujarat. He grew up in Ghatkopar East, a largely Gujarati middle-class neighbourhood where the family runs a printing press, and studied at the MD Bhatia and Gurukul schools before studying management at the Welingkar Institute. He trained as a pilot in New Zealand.

SC-ONOE PANEL

simultaneous elections.

The developments came against the backdrop of growing concern over the propriety of a parliamentary committee discussing the merits or constitutional implications of proposed legislation with sitting Supreme Court judges when the legislation could eventually come before the court for adjudication.

Sibal, at a press conference on Thursday, said he was "shocked" by the proposed interaction and questioned how the judiciary could accept an invitation from a parliamentary committee when the bills raised issues of "fundamental importance to the polity of this country" and to the working of the Constitution.

"How did the judiciary accept that invitation from the joint committee, knowing full well that this bill raises issues of fundamental importance to the polity of this country, fundamental issues relating to the working of our Constitution?" Sibal asked.

He said Parliament has the prerogative to introduce and consider legislation, with a parliamentary committee examining a bill and submitting its report to the House. Parliament would thereafter debate and vote on the legislation, while its constitutional validity, if challenged, would be considered by

the judiciary.

Sibal said he had never encountered an instance in the country's history of a parliamentary panel holding an interaction with sitting Supreme Court judges on legislation that could subsequently be challenged before the court.

The Supreme Court's communication, however, confined the reason for cancelling the interaction to the view expressed by the CJI and senior judges that discussing the issue on the administrative side would not be "expedient or desirable" since the proposed amendment might become a subject matter of judicial review.

The joint committee is examining two bills that seek to facilitate simultaneous elections to the Lok Sabha and state legislative assemblies. The Constitution (One Hundred and Twenty-Ninth Amendment) Bill, 2024 proposes, among other things, insertion of a new Article 82A dealing with simultaneous elections and amendments to Articles 83, 172 and 327. The Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2024 proposes consequential changes to facilitate simultaneous elections in the Union territories as well.

Both bills were introduced in the Lok Sabha in December 2024 and referred to the joint committee for examination. The committee comprises members from both Houses and is headed by Chaudhary.

The committee has conducted consultations with political parties, legislators, constitutional experts and other stakeholders on the proposed electoral changes. It has also consulted former Chief Justices of India, former Supreme Court judges and other legal experts on the constitutional questions surrounding simultaneous elections.

The proposal, commonly described as "One Nation, One Election", seeks to align elections to the Lok Sabha and state assemblies. The government has argued that simultaneous elections would reduce the frequency and cost of elections and provide greater continuity for governance, while Opposition parties and other critics have raised concerns relating to democratic accountability, federalism and the constitutional implications of synchronising the terms of elected legislatures.

HC: Cannot detain kin to pressurise accused

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PRAYAGRAJ: Detaining an accused's family member to pressure him into surrendering is unlawful, the Allahabad high court has observed while ordering ₹40,000 compensation to a man who spent four days in police custody despite having no connection with the case against his brother.

A division bench of justices Atul Sreedharan and Divesh Chandra Samant said that such detention amounts to unlawful deprivation of liberty and entitles the detained person to compensation.

The court passed the order on September 9 while allowing a habeas corpus petition filed by one Arvind Kumar Yadav, who alleged that he was illegally detained at George Town police station in Prayagraj.

The court directed that the

₹40,000 compensation awarded to Yadav for his wrongful and unlawful detention be recovered from the salaries of the police personnel responsible for his detention, in such proportions as the state may determine.

An FIR had been registered against Yadav's brother, Suresh Kumar, Section 109 of the BNS, pertaining to attempt to murder, was later added during probe.

Yadav claimed that despite having no connection with the case, police picked him up from his house in Jaunpur on June 23, 2026, and took him to George Town police station. He was released around 7pm on June 26.

Taking note of the material before it, the court said it was undisputed that Yadav remained in the unlawful custody of police personnel for at least four days.

The court also directed that its displeasure be recorded in the respective service records of the IO and the SHO concerned.

HEADMASTER BOOKED FOR KILLING STUDENT

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BHUBANESWAR: Police on Thursday booked a headmaster of a residential school in Odisha's Koraput district for brutally assaulting and killing a Class 5 tribal student, police said.

Inspector-in-charge of Jayapur Sadar police station, Sachindra Pradhan, said police booked the headmaster of PM SHRI Upgraded High School at Gadapadar, Dilip Panda, for murder and under relevant provisions of the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act.

According to the complaint of the boy's father, Tina Jani, Panda had assaulted his son Ganga on September 25 and 26 and later confined him to the hostel. After learning about the assault, Jani visited the hostel on September 27, where his son narrated the incident to him. He then took his son to the District Headquarters Hospital, where doctors declared him dead on September 30 night, the complaint said.

2 GUJ IAS OFFICERS COMPULSORILY RETIRED BY GOVT

AHMEDABAD: Gujarat government on Thursday compulsorily retired two IAS officers, K Rajesh and Gaurav Dahiya, as part of 'Operation Gangajal'—its exercise against officials facing corruption, disciplinary proceedings and serious misconduct.

A Gujarat government official said the action against the two officers was based on their service records and the proceedings against them.

Rajesh, a 2011-batch IAS officer, was already under suspension when the government ordered his compulsory retirement. He was accused of taking bribes in connection with the issue of arms licences and allotment of government land.

Dahiya, a 2010-batch IAS officer, was serving as additional development commissioner in Gandhinagar when he was compulsorily retired. An official said the action against him followed disciplinary proceedings, controversies and misconduct inquiries during his service, including issues relating to his tenure with the National Health Mission. **HTC**

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OPINION

The
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{ OUR TAKE }

Setting fire to the cracker ban

The apex court restrictions, now relaxed, should have stayed till the industry made cleaner products, with State verification

The Supreme Court has loosened its hold on firecrackers once more. On Wednesday, it cleared “next-generation” *laris*, the chains of crackers that go off one after another, for use nationwide; these were previously banned for spewing excessive emissions than most firecrackers. The court also declined a total ban on crackers, citing the need to accommodate sentiments, and left room for barium-based crackers (barium, when burnt, emits particularly harmful gases) if tests due by October 15 clear them. This is the second such relaxation in a year.

The timing could hardly be worse. Diwali falls on November 8, in the thick of the farm-fire season, when cool, heavy air keeps smoke close to the ground. Last October, the court allowed green crackers in Delhi-NCR after years of a total ban. The Capital then had warm weather and few farm fires on its side, yet the firecrackers still caused the worst Diwali pollution peak since 2021.

At the heart of the problem is a simple fact: firecrackers, green or not, pollute. Green formulations are said to cut emissions by 30-40% per cracker. But the rest still goes into the air, and permitting crackers where none were allowed becomes a numbers game: burst roughly half as many again, and the gain is gone.

Then there is the problem of whether what’s sold as green is even green. The market is rife with conventional crackers passed off as green, boxes stamped “eco-friendly” with no certification behind them, and QR codes bought from licensed makers to dress up unlicensed stock, and there is no laboratory in Delhi that can test what is actually inside.

The cost of these emissions is easy to miss under today’s clear skies and brisk winds. But like clockwork, in about four weeks, the Capital will slide into its annual cocktail of bad air, mixed from farm fires, the city’s own pollution and still weather. Diwali’s firecrackers will add to this at the worst possible moment.

To be sure, past bans were flouted too, people found crackers anyway, and the industry employs thousands of poor workers whose livelihoods deserve weight.

But the crisis is too severe, and the damage to health too grave, to accommodate these concerns. The industry should be helped to make cleaner products, and the state to build the laboratories and checks to verify them. Until then, the restrictions should stay. The right to breathe comes first.

Prudent price support for the farm sector

The central government announced the Minimum Support Price (MSP) for *rabi* (winter season) crops on Wednesday. MSP for wheat, the crop that matters most in terms of actual procurement, has been kept almost flat with an increase of just ₹25 per quintal. Other crops such as pulses and oil seeds saw larger increases.

To be sure, the current government has consistently followed its policy of ensuring at least a 50% return on the all-India weighted average cost of cultivation. The relatively lower increase in wheat MSP therefore also suggests that the cost of cultivation has been flat.

The policy seems prudent for two reasons. One, the government already has excess wheat stocks from the previous season’s procurement and does not really need to procure much more. Two — and this is more important — the real agricultural income story is that the cost of cultivation has remained largely constant despite large inflation in key inputs such as fertilizers because of the ongoing war in West Asia. The cost of cultivation has remained constant because the government absorbed a large part of the commodity price shocks through measures like fertiliser subsidies, which will likely reflect in the budgetary numbers. These two facts make the price policy decisions a pragmatic choice.

With the *rabi* MSP announcement out of its way — it serves as a key incentive for cultivation decisions — the agricultural policy establishment should focus its attention, energy and resources on mitigating the fall out of deficient monsoon rainfall in the country. With the rains being the weakest since 2002, there are bound to be production headwinds from outright crop failure to subdued yields.

Finding the Mahatma in a divided Pakistan



157
YEARS OF
GANDHI

Pakistan has borrowed Gandhi’s name for some of its heroes. At the same time, he rarely gets his due in school textbooks there, having opposed Partition, and thereby, the country’s creation

I have never heard any Pakistani say anything offensive — critical, maybe, but never disparaging — about two Indians: Lata Mangeskar and Mahatma Gandhi. And this is regardless of whether the two countries are at war or at peace. Gandhi — India’s revered Father of the Nation, still fondly called *Bapu* in parts of South Asia — occupies a complex place in Pakistan’s historical, political, and literary memory.

Gandhi’s name is part of Pakistan’s landscape, especially in the Sind province, as it is — expectedly — in India. For instance, Karachi’s zoo was famously known as “Gandhi Garden” before Partition, and continues to be called so despite an official change of name. The plaque may now say National Zoological and Botanical Garden, but the old name is imprinted on the cultural being of the majority of people in the city. Yes, attitudes towards seeing animals caged have undergone a change as the younger generation wants to see animals roaming free. The name, therefore, sticks rather ironically in popular recall, says my friend Aijaz Mangi, a Karachi-based poet.

That we have borrowed Gandhi’s name for our own heroes should underline his impact in the subcontinent, perhaps even beyond. Noted freedom

fighter Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan, who led the non-violent movement against British colonialism in the North West Frontier Province (NWFP), became Frontier Gandhi or *Sarhadi Gandhi*. The stature of this Pashtoon leader, also known as Bacha Khan, in Pakistani socio-political movements was elevated by the halo of Gandhi’s name.

Miskeen Jahan Khan Khoso became, through his work, the Gandhi of the Thar, the desert that’s not very far from Gandhi’s native village in Gujarat, India. Carrying piles of papers in his *chador*, an ink pot and pen in his hand, Khoso continued to be followed by crowds of poor litigants until his death in 1980. A tireless social worker, Khoso helped the poor, sick, unemployed, and hungry, traversing the length and the breadth of the Thar (on foot, mostly). He was forever knocking on the doors of bureaucrats, judges, doctors — anyone who could help the downtrodden natives of a difficult land. Once jailed under Pakistan’s Goonda Act for siding with the oppressed against local influentials, he fought the fabricated case and was acquitted within six months. A hero to the Thar’s marginalised communities, including Kolhis, Meghwaris, and Bheels, he often

remained hungry while feeding those who had nothing. One of his biggest contributions was the successful campaign to make antivenin available in Thar hospitals. This portrait is only to illustrate that we, in Pakistan, have not handed out the title “Gandhi” for ceremony or flattery, but for genuine selfless service. Neel Kanth, a fellow Thari and a family friend of Khoso, invokes this example to show how Pakistan has found ways to claim Gandhi.

Of course, our relationship with Gandhi has never been simple, and we should not pretend it is. After all, the man opposed the very creation of Pakistan. Because successive Pakistani governments have struggled with establishing a national identity in opposition to India, Gandhi is rarely emphasised in mainstream Pakistani school textbooks. His overt Hindu religiosity was also something that our founding father, Muhammad Ali Jinnah, was openly dismissive of. On the contrary, the Deobandi Jamiat Ulema-e-Hind, which opposed Jinnah and Pakistan, held Gandhi in high esteem. Many Deobandis of Pakistan, despite their ossified religious beliefs, continue to revere the man. But, there is also one Rasool Baksh Palijo. This celebrated human rights lawyer, leftist scholar and Marxist leader of Pakistan, famously blamed Gandhi for “provoking” Jinnah with Hindu religiosity and the slogan of *Ram Rajya*. Ali Ahmad Rind, the editor of *Affairs*, a fortnightly Sindh news magazine in Karachi, notes that Palijo perhaps held Gandhi responsible for Partition by pushing Jinnah against the wall.

For thousands of followers of GM



Hasan Mujtaba



Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan, who led the non-violent freedom struggle in the North West Frontier Province, became Frontier Gandhi. HT ARCHIVE

Syed of Sind and Bacha Khan of the NWFP, Gandhi holds a place beyond politics — as a mystic and a prophet of non-violence. He becomes someone akin to Gautama Buddha, whose influence is still alive in the ruins of Takshashila. Shaikh Ayaz, the doyen of Sindh poetry, wrote a collection called *Raaj Ghat Tay Chand (Moon over Raj Ghat)* and reminded us that the world offers a cross for Jesus and a bullet for Gandhi, even today. Barely a month after Partition, Gandhi said in a prayer meeting, “What the Muslims have done is not good, but what harm has the Koran done?” In the same meeting he said, “I want to go to Lahore. I do not want to go with any police or military escort ... I want to go with faith and trust in the Muslims there. Let them kill me if they want ... Let the Government stop me if they will. But how can the Government stop me? They will have to kill me if they want to stop me. If they kill me, my death will leave a lesson for you.” Clearly, it was this worldview that earned him friends and foes on all sides. Even Shaikh Ayaz once wrote out of frustration, “You have to deal with Gandhi to even ride a donkey.”

For my generation, Gandhi arrived via VHS tape, alongside Osho’s cassettes and Ben Kingsley’s film. We argued whether an empire fell because a brown man was thrown off a train in

South Africa by the white colonialists.

History is full of such ifs. What if a woman named Kariman had not eloped with a Hindu man in Sindh? Would the Larkana riots of 1927 not have happened? Would identity-based political stances not have hardened? Would a Sindh-born barrister, then, still have launched a movement for a new, Muslim-majority nation? All are in the realm of hypothesis. What is not hypothetical is what Gandhi did in his final days: He demanded that Pakistan receive its share of the assets, the 550 million rupees, and stood against the killing that soaked Partition. Many Hindus of India bristled at this: Why was our Gandhi being generous to them, they probably wondered.

Pakistan isn’t united on Gandhi, a living symbol of unity. In today’s Pakistan, there is a section in politics that still likes to lump Gandhi with the hardliner elements in India, as an existential denier of Pakistan. I muse, therefore, that Nehru’s line about him, “I love the old man but never understood him,” could very well be ours too. Being fully understood by everyone, after all, did not matter to the saint of Sabarmati.

Hasan Mujtaba is a Pakistan-born poet, journalist, and human rights activist. The views expressed are personal

Gandhi, the man and the idea, lives on in Hindustani

What is it about Gandhi — born 156 years ago in a world altogether different from ours, killed 78 years ago in a newly-independent India — that still resonates with the Urdu poet/writer of today?

First, a sampling from some recent works, and then a search for answers.

In a long, lyrical *ghazal*, Nushhur Wahidi speaks of Gandhi as a light that cannot be snuffed out, as a life force that will always show the way, as a treasure that can never be pillaged: *Woh hamesha ke liye chup hue magar ik jahan ko zabaan di/ Woh hamesha ke liye so gaye magar ik jahan ko jaga diya* (He was silenced forever but he gave voice to a world/ He went to sleep forever but he awakened a world).

Writing especially on the occasion of Gandhi’s birth, Kamal Dibaivi speaks with the pride of ownership, that a man such as Gandhi was “ours”: *Watan ke aasman par ek rukhshanda sitara the/ Hamein ye fakhr hai ahl-e-jahaan mein Gandhi hamare the* (He was a resplendent star in the country’s firmament/ We are proud that among all the people in the world, Gandhi was ours).

Nazish Pratapgari seizes upon the occasion of Gandhi Jayanti to exhort his country to remember all that Gandhi stood for: love for fellow beings, peace for all mankind, and, above all, the creed of *ahimsa* (non-violence). And forsaking all the bloodshed, hatred, violence, enmity, and ill-will of past years, the poet urges his people to take a pledge on this special day to replenish and renew: *Phir apne zehnon mein lahkao dosti ka chamani/ Phir apni saanson se mahkao pyaar ka madhubani/ Phir apne kaamon se chamkao sar-zameen-e-watan* (Once again, let the garden of friendship bloom in your mind/ Once again, let the forest of love become fragrant with your breath/ Once again let the soil of your motherland be nourished with your deeds).

To the generations of Indian children who have seen the photograph of Gandhi hanging on a wall, for whom the Father of the Nation is little more than a quaint, smiling, toothless figure in a loincloth, clutching a stick, here’s Ataur Rehman Tariq writing about the country’s collective *mahatma* (great father): *Bachcho tum ne Bapu ki tasveer to dekhi hogi/ Eik nazar mein samjhoge tum un ko budha jogi* (Children, you

must have seen the picture of *Bapu*/ At first glance, you’d have taken him for an old ascetic).

No talk of Gandhi’s life is possible without a mention of his death, the manner in which he was killed. Here’s Gulzar, a poet with a distinctly modern sensibility, presenting a harsh truth in a uniquely modern, straightforward way. Without mincing words, and with great economy of expression, he is saying that just as Gandhi’s legacy lives, so does that other, opposing view that killed him: *Sawa gaz aasmaan odhe huwe sar pe/ Badan par eik langoti lapete/ prarthana le liye nikla thha baahar/ Kisi ne augey badh kar/ Tamancha rakh diya seene pe yeh keh ke/ Tumhari raaye se sehmata nahi hoon main/ Tamancha chah raha hai —/ Woh raaye marti nahi hai!* (Wearing a yard-and-a-quarter of the sky on his head/ A loincloth wrapped around his body/ He had come out for prayer/ Someone stepped forward and/ Placing a pistol on his chest, said: “I do not agree with your opinion!”/ That pistol is still firing —/ That opinion does not die).

And now for a search for answers as to why Gandhi remains relevant in a world that has changed so dramatically, and not always for the better, since he lived. What is the reason for his enduring appeal?

Charkh Chinoiti offers some clues: *Bapu ne har insan ko insaan samjha/ Bahbuudi-e-har-fard ko iman samjha/ Injeel ko Quran ko aur Gita ko seene se lagaya/ Unhein yaksaan samjha* (Bapu treated every human being as a human/ Regarded the welfare of every individual as his faith/ Be it the Bible, or the Quran, or the Gita/ He held them to his bosom as equal).

Abrar Kiratpuri, better known as a poet of *hamd* (praise of God) and *naat* (devotional poetry honouring the Prophet), writes a lovely short poem telling us why we should remember this *rahbar* (guide), who showed us the way of *desh-bhakti* (patriotism): *Dosti ka sabaq de gaya/ Mar ke javed woh ho gaya* (He left a lesson of friendship/ He became undying after dying).

That Gandhi is alive and well in the modern writer’s imagination is evident from this very short story by the Hindi writer Asghar Wajahat: so keen is its rapier-sharp insight, so deep the well of belief from which it springs that it gives one fresh reasons to hope.

The spirits come to Shah Alam Camp after midnight. One night, an old man’s spirit comes along with all the other spirits. The old man’s body is naked save for a skimpy loincloth. He wears *chappals* on his feet and holds a wooden staff in his hand. An old-fashioned fob watch peeps from the folds of his loincloth. Someone asks the old man, “Are you too looking for a relative here in this camp?”

The old man replies, “Yes, and no.” The others leave him alone, taking him for a senile old man. The old man walks round and round the camp.

Someone again asks the old man, “Baba, whom are you looking for?”

The old man says, “I am looking for someone who can kill me.”

“Why?”

“I was killed fifty years ago by a bullet. Now, I want the rioters to burn me alive.”

“But, why do you want that, Baba?”

“Simply to tell the world that I was not killed by their bullet, nor will I die if they burn me alive.”

Rakhshanda Jalil is a writer, translator, and literary historian. The views expressed are personal



Without mincing words, and with great economy of expression, Gulzar says that just as Gandhi’s legacy lives, so does that opposing view that killed him. GETTY IMAGES

{ DROUPADI MURMU } PRESIDENT

Today, an atmosphere of war and conflict prevails in many parts of the world ... Mahatma Gandhi’s message of peace and non-violence becomes even more relevant



{ FROM THE ARCHIVES }

Gandhiji was a man of God, hence Mahatma

It is a paradox that in spite of my intimate connection with Mahatmaji, he is the one subject on which I feel helpless when I begin to write. A cynicism overtakes me. Secular admirers have heaped their tributes on him for having shown the world a new method of solving conflicts by truth and love instead of by violence. They often call it a technique. As the secularists have understood the Mahatma, a concealed *petitio principii* invalidates the technique. It appears to me that we must get behind love and truth and dive deep till we discover what really can make Gandhiji’s solution a serviceable reality.

Leaders of men abroad have admired Gandhiji as one who developed an effective new technique based on non-violence for struggling against wrong. The very notion that what Gandhiji taught was a technique has led to error and of course disappointment. Non-violence is not a gadget to get what we used to try to get through violence and much trouble, in the pre-Gandhian days, as we get cooking energy from electricity instead of from coal or wood fuel. Mahatma Gandhi’s technique is no doubt the presentation of love and truth in any confrontation against evil. But love and truth are not available in the market. We cannot procure them as we can procure rifles and pistols. They can issue only out of faith in God.

We have changed from animal power to steam and from steam to oil fuel and from oil to electricity. All these variations of energy do not furnish the basis of understanding Mahatma Gandhi’s technique. The moral energy, soul-force as Gandhiji loved to call it, comes from faith and true religious devotion. All the time up to his death, Gandhiji laid stress on this source of power. Much of the non-violence practices by ardent devotees who, for the sake of convenience or for avoiding bloodshed, seek to practise what Gandhiji taught are only variations of violence.

Non-violence does not consist in merely not calling to aid a *lathi* or a dagger or a pistol. The positive aspect of non-violence is what has to be realised; and that is firm faith in the reality of God’s sovereignty. Where this is absent, non-violence will fail.

It is generally known that the non-violent way shown by Gandhiji demands abstaining from the use of physical weapons. But it is not as gen-



We cannot procure love and truth as we can procure rifles and pistols. They can issue only out of faith in God. HT ARCHIVE

erally realised that abstention from the use of physical violence with hatred and venom burning in the heart is not non-violence such as Gandhiji conceived it. To enunciate that love and truth are the new tools given to us by Gandhiji to

serve as powerful answers to the hatred and falsehood and violence of the enemy is easy. To say that these forces of love and truth can solve, and are the only way to solve, the racial, economic and political conflicts of the world is easy. But in practice it will be found to be begging the question: How can I summon up love for one who has given me so much cause to hate? How

can a Pakistani patriot love Indians? How can Indian patriots love the Pakistanis? The force of love cannot spring from nowhere where there is good reason for the opposite of love. It must spring from a firm faith in God and his sovereignty over the hearts of men, if we desire to save Gandhiji’s way from becoming an empty doctrine or a disappointing technique.

Satyagraha is not for the sceptic, not for one who is content with the phenomenal world and the careful classification of what one sees in that world, which is called science. It may be a beautiful fountain-pen. But if there is no ink in it, or if you fill it only with water, the pen can’t write. Let us, while celebrating Gandhiji’s birth centenary, reflect and realise his true teaching and the true lessons of his work and not look upon him as a mere inventor of a cheap gadget to displace an old troublesome way. Gandhiji was not an inventor. He was a man of God, and therefore was he called Mahatma.

C Rajagopalachari is former governor general of India. These are edited excerpts of his article first published in *Hindustan Times* on October 2, 1968



Putin warns of risk of nuclear weapons use
MOSCOW: Russian President Vladimir Putin said on Thursday that the world was living through a dangerous moment and that it was essential to ensure that weapons of mass destruction would never be used. **REUTERS**

Anglo-Iranian man held over UK airspace incident
LONDON: British police said they had arrested a man with dual UK-Iranian citizenship over a mysterious "major incident" on Sunday at an airbase in southwest England. Police said a second man, a British citizen, was questioned and two properties were searched in Westminster. **AFP**

Michael Jordan's 'Last Dance' jersey sells for \$12.26mn
WASHINGTON: Michael Jordan's jersey from Game 3 of the 1998 NBA Finals sold for \$12.26 million on Tuesday. This jersey, from Jordan's sixth and final NBA Championship season in his "Last Dance" final campaign with the Bulls, put up for sale by entrepreneur Ryan Gough and sold at Joopier, Pharrell Williams' digital auction house. **REUTERS**

SpaceX launches crew for Nasa on retiring capsule
WASHINGTON: SpaceX launched a new crew of four astronauts to the International Space Station on Thursday, as questions swirl over its plans for the future of its human spaceflight programme. **BLOOMBERG**

Trump: May resume Iran bombing after midterms

Bloomberg, AP & AFP

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WASHINGTON: President Donald Trump said ramped up military strikes against Iran were "possible" after the November midterm elections, as his administration struggles to find an exit plan for a war now in its eighth month.

Trump has indicated in recent weeks that he believed Iran was stalling on diplomatic talks until after the elections, in which his Republican Party faces a tough path to retain control of Congress.

The US president rejected a recent proposal from Iran that would have reopened the Strait of Hormuz in exchange for US concessions such as ending a blockade on Iranian ports or easing oil sanctions.

Asked if he would resume bombing Iran after the midterms, Trump told Time magazine in an interview published on Thursday that it was "possible". "I can't tell you that because look, you know, you're asking, where are you going to bomb," he added, when pressed for more details.

Iran's delegation asked to leave NY ahead of schedule
US Secretary of State Marco Rubio ordered Iran's foreign minister and his delegation to the UN General Assembly to leave New York earlier than they had planned, two US officials said on Wednesday.

While President Masoud Pezeshkian left New York a day after speaking at the United Nations last week, Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi had remained behind ostensibly to participate in indirect talks with the US. According to some accounts, Araghchi had planned to stay in New York until Wednesday.

After little progress was made in weekend meetings



Commuters ride scooters past Iranian-made Zolfaghar missiles on display beside a large portrait of Iran's supreme leader Mojtaba Khamenei at Baharestan Square in Tehran. **AFP**

between Iranian and Qatari mediators, Rubio lost patience and told the Iranians on Monday that Araghchi and his delegation had to leave New York immediately, according to the two officials. Araghchi and his team departed New York very early Tuesday.

US govt sanctions Iran's automakers, rail firms

The US on Thursday announced fresh sanctions targeting Iran's largest automakers, as well as major rail, manufacturing and metals companies, as Washington seeks to exert maximum pressure in its war against the country. The new sanctions target the country's two largest automakers Iran Khodro (IKCO) and SAIPA. Key Iranian rail companies sanctioned include the state-owned Islamic Republic of Iran Railway Company (RAI), the Raja Passenger Trains Company and private freight carrier Sherkat-E Rah Ahan-E Khamle-O-Naghle.

Iran loaded no oil onto tankers last month as US naval blockade bites

Bloomberg

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WASHINGTON: Iran loaded no crude oil onto tankers in September, the latest sign of how a US naval blockade is choking the Islamic Republic's critical access to energy markets.

Crude loadings fell to zero from around 250,000 barrels per day in August, according to preliminary tanker-tracking estimates compiled by Bloomberg, the first such instance since the war began in February. Data providers Kpler and Vortexa also recorded zero crude loadings last month. The slump indicates Iran is

becoming less willing or able to test the US blockade of its Persian Gulf ports, and makes it harder for Tehran to sustain oil sales to China — a key source of revenue as Washington tries to isolate its economy.

Iran continued to deliver oil to some Chinese refineries from floating storage east of Singapore in September, but those stocks are likely to run out without new supply. The loadings data, which is based on satellite images, is preliminary. Iran's tankers often start sending location signals only when they're in the Strait of Malacca or nearing the Suez Canal, almost two weeks after leaving Iranian waters.

A plumber, dentist and others praised as heroes in flydubai near-disaster

Associated Press

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JERUSALEM: A dentist and other passengers wrestled with a violent co-pilot. A plumber seized the controls of the plane as it plunged toward the desert. And that's after the captain managed to open the cockpit door while being stabbed, helping to save all 174 people on board the Israel-bound flight.

As the US ambassador to Israel, Mike Huckabee, put it: "Hollywood isn't creative enough to come up with stories like this!"

While major questions remained unanswered on Thursday about the attacker and his motivation, the tale of everyday heroes saving the flydubai flight from disaster quickly became legend.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu warmly embraced the plumber shortly after the passengers' arrival in Tel Aviv late Wednesday, and later posted a five-star review for Yaniv Hayoun's professional services, calling him "a hero who has saved many lives".

"He can help you too — I highly recommend him!" Netanyahu added on X.

Hayoun was among several Israelis recommended for the Presidential Award for Civilian Heroism, while Indian Capt. Smit Machchhar was praised by Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi as "a HERO".

Many of the details emerged in a rush shortly after the passengers, most of them Israeli, landed back home to cheers and waving flags.

Hayoun, apologising for his bloody shirt, within minutes was telling the prime minister and journalists what happened.

There had been little time for him and the others to think. Passengers screamed after spotting the co-pilot stabbing the



Benjamin Netanyahu meets with Yaniv Hayoun, Or Fradilov, Dr Shota Musayev and his wife Sigalit, who he described as "heroes", during a meeting in Jerusalem, Israel, on Thursday. **REUTERS**

captain, and the flight from Dubai to Tel Aviv began a steep dive. Some believed they were about to die.

A handful of Israelis reacted, hurtling up the aisle after the badly wounded captain managed to open the cockpit door. That was crucial, as cockpit doors are typically locked to prevent hijackings.

They had to struggle, Hayoun said, with the captain's body resting against it.

Hayoun said the co-pilot appeared to be trying to damage the plane's controls. He grabbed the co-pilot, and others began struggling with the man.

Hayoun then tackled the controls. He had no training, but he remembered what he had seen in movies.

"I asked him, how did you know how to do that? And he said, 'Well, I, I watched these air disaster films,'" Netanyahu told Fox News on Thursday.

It was not clear who among the passengers had security experience, though military service is compulsory for most men and women in Israel.

Soon, crew who had been travelling on the plane stepped in to stabilise it, issuing a mayday call and seeking a place to land.

The handful of Israeli passengers grappled with the co-pilot for several minutes before subduing him and binding his hands with the cord from a set of headphones.

One of them, Dr Shota Musayev, a dentist, also attended to the captain, who appeared to have lost a lot of blood. "He was just praying the whole time and was in contact with me, and I was afraid we would really lose him," Musayev said.

In video that Musayev shot and shared with The Associated Press, the captain lay on the floor of the cabin, saying his head was in pain.

Musayev later told journalists he and the other responders knew they'd had just seconds to act before a "critical event".

But even with the co-pilot bound and subdued, they were scared that other attackers might be on the plane. They sent other people around the cabin to stand by. Finally, just about an hour after the plane issued a distress call, it made an emergency landing in Saudi Arabia.

As of Thursday evening, the world had not yet heard from the central hero, the captain, who India's Embassy in the UAE said was "in good health and recovering well".

Google releases most advanced AI model, restricts its access

Vishal Mathur

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NEW DELHI: Google may have taken its time, but seems to have delivered a resounding response in the race for the most advanced artificial intelligence (AI; now called Super Intelligence, or SI) models yet.

The Gemini 4 Argon model is now in the hands of what Google calls "a set of trusted cyber defenders", and is working with the US government's voluntary process for pre-release model access. That means, not everyone can access Gemini 4 Argon just yet. This is Google's response to OpenAI GPT-6 Astra and Claude Fable 5.1 models.

"To support Gemini 4 Argon's capabilities across longer, more complex use cases, we are significantly expanding the model's output token limit to an industry-leading 1M tokens, up from the previous 64K tokens. When the model has the headroom to think deeply and generate hundreds of thousands of tokens in a single trajectory, it adds a new level

Research firm: AI agents tried to hack Canadian govt website

Reuters

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WASHINGTON: An artificial intelligence research firm said on Wednesday AI agents tried to hack into a Canadian government website, casting the effort as a failed hacking attempt, while Canada said there were no indications its systems were compromised.

AI research firm Translucence said the attempts exhib-

ited tactics "consistent with prior observed agent activity that we have attributed to OpenAI in a similar timeframe". But it added that it was not confidently attributing these attempts to OpenAI.

The agents attempted to access Library and Archives Canada on May 28 and June 9, Translucence said in a blog post. Translucence said it disclosed the action to the Canadian government on Monday.

of depth in reasoning to solve tough problems in one go," said Koray Kavukcuoglu, Senior Vice President, Google DeepMind and Chief AI Architect, Google.

This is Alphabet's most advanced model yet, and comes days after Google CEO Sundar Pichai signed a voluntary White House Accord on Super Intelligence with other AI leaders.

Anthropic, OpenAI, Google, Meta, xAI and Nvidia pledged to implement stronger controls as well as monitoring and detection mechanisms internally. This comes after Anthropic's Dario Amodei raised an alarm about humans losing control of AI, and OpenAI's models exiting their testing environment and accessing platforms on the open internet.

SECOND JUDGE BLOCKS TRUMP'S \$100,000 FEE FOR NEW H-1B VISAS

Reuters

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CALIFORNIA: A second federal judge on Wednesday blocked an unprecedented \$100,000 fee that US President Donald Trump has imposed on new H-1B visas for highly skilled foreign workers.

US District Judge Haywood Gilliam in Oakland, California, ruled that US Citizenship and Immigration Services and the State Department failed to follow necessary rule-making processes before implementing Trump's fee.

Gilliam, appointed by then-President Barack Obama, a Democrat, granted a request by a coalition of unions, employers and non-profits to block the agencies from implementing Trump's fee pending the outcome of a lawsuit they filed in October.

The fee was temporarily blocked in June by a federal judge in Boston, ruling in a separate case brought by 20 states. A Boston-based appeals court in July declined to pause that decision.

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Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Every Saturday, HT Brunch explores the people, ideas and cultural shifts behind the moments everyone is talking about.



EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES

{ **DEATH PENALTY** } IN TENNESSEE STATE

US death row convict survives execution

Agencies

letters@hindustantimes.com

NASHVILLE, TENNESSEE: Tennessee officials have yet to explain what went wrong during the failed execution of Christa Pike, 50, which was called off after she was given two doses of the drug meant to kill her.

She could be heard snoring loudly in the execution chamber on Wednesday night more than an hour after the execution process began and nearly 30 minutes after a second dose of pentobarbital was administered.

Pike, who was sentenced to death for a gruesome 1995 murder, was taken by ambulance from the prison to a hospital, her lawyers said.

Pike is alive and receiving life saving medical care, one of her lawyers said on Thursday.

May Martinez, whose daughter was murdered by Pike and her boyfriend and who travelled to Nashville to see the execution



Christa Pike

REUTERS

being carried out, told NBC News on Thursday that "it was a mess".

The failure, which one death penalty expert described as unprecedented, led Gov. Bill Lee to postpone Tennessee's lone remaining execution this year and to order a review "to determine exactly what occurred".

It also raises questions again about the state's procedures and its use of single-drug lethal injections.

Officials gave Pike two doses of pentobarbital, her lawyers

said in court filings late Wednesday. Pike was 18 in January 1995 when she, 17-year-old boyfriend Tadaryl Shipp and a third companion lured 19-year-old Colleen Slemmer, a classmate at their Knoxville Job Corps vocational centre, into a wooded area where they tortured and killed her.

Pike and Shipp confessed to the killing, and both were convicted of first-degree murder. Slemmer's mother has spoken out in support of the execution.

Meanwhile, UN rights chief Volker Turk on Thursday urged Tennessee not to make a new attempt to execute Pike.

"The case of Christa Pike lays bare multiple reasons why the death penalty should be abolished," his office said on X.

"The prolonged suffering — physical and mental — arising from multiple failed execution attempts is abhorrent, and cruel. And there are key fair trial questions still unresolved."

LETHAL DRUG USED IN FAILED EXECUTION UNDER SCRUTINY

NASHVILLE: The lethal drug administered in Tennessee's failed attempt to execute Christa Pike has been used in multiple US states that carry out the death penalty.

Pentobarbital is a barbiturate, a class of drugs that depresses the central nervous system. Approved medical uses include sedation, short-term treatment of insomnia, preparation for anesthesia and emergency control of certain severe seizures. In an overdose, it can produce coma, suppress breathing and cause circulatory collapse and death.

Experts quoted in the 2025 federal review argue pentobarbital can cause pulmonary edema, a buildup of fluid in the lungs that may create a sensation of suffocating. **AP**



Eight-week slide in Indian equities puts focus on RBI

Mayur Bhalerao

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MUMBAI: Cheaper oil failed to bring much comfort for Indian equities as the markets slid for the eighth consecutive week. Nifty 50 recorded its longest weekly losing streak since 2001 in a holiday-truncated week, with markets closed on Friday for Gandhi Jayanti. On Thursday, it fell 0.88% to 22,421.95, while the Sensex declined 0.79% to 71,909.69.

Their weekly losses stood at 3.11% and 2.69%, respectively, with the Nifty posting its sharpest weekly decline since the week ended 13 March 2026. The retreat has sharpened a question: is a recovery in sight?

Prasenjit Paul, fund manager at 129 Wealth and head of research at Paul Asset, said elevated oil prices, rupee weakness and higher US bond yields were driving foreign outflows. Foreign portfolio investors sold a net ₹35,861 crore of equities in September, with ₹19,273 crore—53.7% of the monthly outflow—withdrawing in the final seven trading sessions. Selling continued on Thursday,



Nifty 50 recorded its longest weekly losing streak since 2001. MINT

with another ₹9,232 crore off-loaded.

The US 10-year Treasury yield climbed to around 5.3%, its highest since June 2007, while India's benchmark government bond yield hovered near 7.20%. Crude's retreat to about \$96.30 a barrel offered relief, but proved insufficient to reverse market sentiment.

On earnings trajectory, V.K. Vijayakumar, chief investment strategist, Geojit Investments Ltd notes that if crude prices

remain elevated for long, economic growth and corporate earnings will be impacted.

"The market is concerned about this. In this context, 5.2% yield from the US 10-year bond becomes very attractive for FPIs," he added.

That assessment also faces a test at the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) Monetary Policy Committee meeting on October 5-7.

September-quarter results will offer another test, begin-

ning with Tata Consultancy Services on October 8.

India also lagged most markets in the global snapshot. Only Indonesia's Jakarta Composite, down 3.72%, fell more than the Nifty. France's CAC 40 and South Korea's KRX 100 lost 2.18% and 2.04%, respectively.

For technology businesses, management confidence may matter more than whether subdued quarterly expectations are met.

"Earnings are not expected to be great. It's going to be about how confident the management is in the next 6 to 12 months," Anand K Rath, co-founder of MIRA Money. Moving further, whether AI generates revenue beyond productivity gains will be closely watched in addition to net employee additions for signs of any job losses.

The weekly losses were pronounced in auto and consumer-facing shares. BSE Auto fell 5.51%, consumer durables lost 5.31%, and FMCG and realty declined 4.17% and 3.28%, respectively. IT and telecommunications edged up 0.20% and 0.07%.

Anup Bagchi named HDFC Bank CEO for three years

Shayan Ghosh

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MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank of India on Thursday approved the appointment of ICICI Group veteran Anup Bagchi as the chief executive of India's largest private lender, HDFC Bank, for a three-year term from October 27.

Bagchi, 56, was widely seen as the top contender for the post, alongside internal candidate Kaizad M Bhurucha. For Bagchi, the appointment marks a return to banking after three years in insurance. This also helps retain ICICI Bank's tag as the chief executive factory, having produced several top leaders scattered across financial services.

The appointment is also the second instance in recent years of an insurance executive being brought in to lead a bank. In 2019, Amitabh Chaudhry joined Axis Bank as chief executive from HDFC Life Insurance Company.

The vacancy at HDFC Bank arose from incumbent CEO Sashidhar Jagdishan's decision not to seek a third term. Having joined the bank in February 1996, Jagdishan rose through the ranks to become chief financial officer in 2008 and then chief executive in 2020, after



Anup Bagchi's appointment follows Jagdishan's decision not to seek a third term. MINT

Aditya Puri stepped down.

The central bank's decision also ends speculation over who will lead the \$119-billion private lender, which was mired in multiple controversies in recent months, including the sudden and dramatic departure of then-chairman Atanu Chakraborty, and allegations surrounding its preferential treatment of a particular bulk depositor.

Bagchi's former colleagues describe him as an intelligent executive who can work the room and get things moving quickly. While at ICICI Bank, he was credited with creating a product that gave risk assessment teams a better grip over customer cash flow. Under him, the bank launched lending to small businesses based on their

goods and services tax (GST) returns in 2018.

"Earlier, it was very difficult to assess cash flow of small businesses as they would say that beyond the reported tax filings, there was income in cash," said a former colleague of Bagchi.

He said the bank has, at times, sent staff to wait outside establishments to ascertain the volume of sales and customer footfall and find out whether it does the kind of business it claims to do. "That changed with GST and therefore the bank's product was timely," he said. A chemical engineer from IIT Kanpur with a management degree from IIM-Bangalore, Bagchi joined ICICI in 1992 and worked across wholesale banking, transaction banking, retail banking, treasury, investment banking, and payment and settlement systems over the course of his career at ICICI.

He led ICICI Securities from May 2011 to October 2016. His elevation from an executive director to CEO at ICICI Securities came in 2011 after Madhabi Puri Buch—who later became the chair of Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi)—moved to another group entity. Bagchi returned to the bank as an executive director in February 2017.

RBI clears Anup Kumar Saha as Kotak Bank CEO

Subhana Shaikh

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MUMBAI: For Anup Saha, the ambition to run a bank has finally fruited. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) late on Wednesday approved his candidature for the top role at Kotak Mahindra Bank, a lender he joined nine months ago.

The central bank, which has the final say in picking candidates for India's private sector banks, gave 56-year-old Saha a three-year term starting January 1, 2027.

Kotak Mahindra Bank said in a statement on Thursday.

Saha joined Kotak Mahindra Bank in January 2026 and, since March, has been overseeing the retail bank, data analytics and marketing functions. The bank said its board of directors will take further steps to formalise Saha's appointment and seek shareholders' approval.

In June 2025, Saha, then the managing director of consumer financier Bajaj Finance, stepped down three months after taking over the role, taking many by surprise. He had joined Bajaj in 2017 after spending 14 years at ICICI Bank and was reported to be among the three contenders for the top job at private lender IndusInd Bank. That role did not go to him, instead the regulator chose veteran banker Rajiv Anand from Axis Bank.

Goyal and Greer hold 'productive talks' on India-US trade deal

Rajeev Jayaswal

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Today's fertiliser shortage could become tomorrow's food crisis, commerce minister Piyush Goyal said at the G20 trade ministers' meeting in Milwaukee, and on its sidelines he also held a "productive" discussion with US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer on early conclusion of the proposed India-US trade deal.

"Met USTR Jamieson Greer, @USTRRep, on the sidelines of the G20 Trade Ministers' Meeting in Milwaukee. Had a productive discussion with USTR Greer towards early conclusion of a mutually beneficial interim agreement under the India-US Bilateral Trade Agreement," Goyal said in a post on X. India and the US are engaged in talks to finalise the proposed interim bilateral trade agreement (BTA) in line with the joint statement issued on February 7. Although the two had reached a framework for an interim BTA in February, they could not sign the agreement after the US Supreme Court invalidated the legal basis for the preferential tariff mechanism Washington had offered. India is now awaiting a preferential tariff framework that provides competitive access for its exporters vis-à-vis competing countries.

"We also exchanged views on G20 deliberations under US Chairship," Goyal said in the post. He also participated in the opening day of the G20 trade ministers' meeting, hosted under the United States G20 Presidency. Speaking at the session on food and trade, Goyal thanked the Presidency for placing food at the centre of the discussions.



Piyush Goyal, commerce and industry minister. AFP

"Ensuring food security for all and creating greater opportunities for farmers are central to India's policy and food must never be used as an instrument of pressure against any country," a commerce ministry's statement quoted minister as saying on Thursday.

Countries of the Global South are among the most adversely impacted by the food, fuel and fertiliser crises caused by global conflicts, the minister added.

Goyal said during the Covid-19 pandemic, India ensured food security for over 1.4 billion citizens and supplied foodgrains to several countries in need.

He noted that over 800 million people in India are currently being provided foodgrains free of cost. India maintains public stockholding (PSH), procures from small and marginal farmers and, in the event of a harvest shortfall, adopts temporary and transparent measures to ensure the availability and affordability of food, Goyal said. "These measures are recognised under the WTO, including through the Bali Ministerial Decision and the Geneva Ministerial Declaration," the statement quoting him said.

CBI FILES SECOND CHARGE SHEET IN RHFL CASE, NAMES 11 ACCUSED

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on Thursday filed the second charge sheet in its probe against Reliance Home Finance Ltd (RHFL), naming 11 accused persons, including three executives of Reliance ADA group, the agency said in a statement.

Those named in the charge sheet include Amit Bapna, Director and CFO of RHFL; Amitabh Jhunjhunwala, former group managing director; Suresh Nagarajan, CFO of Reliance Power Ltd. It also names seven companies—Reliance Infrastructure Limited, Reliance Power Ltd., Reliance Big Entertainment Pvt. Ltd., Reliance Broadcast Network Limited, Reliance Business Broadcast News Holdings Ltd., Reliance Media-Works Financial Services Pvt. Ltd. and Kunjibihari Developers Pvt. Ltd. Vijay Napawaliya, who is the chartered accountant and statutory auditor of RHFL, has also been named in the charge sheet filed under offences of criminal conspiracy and cheating before a special court in Mumbai.

"Investigation conducted so far has revealed that funds amounting to Rs 7,429.16 crore, borrowed by RHFL were allegedly diverted through intermediary and conduit entities to various Reliance ADA Group companies in violation of the terms and conditions stipulated by lenders, thereby causing wrongful loss to the lending banks and financial institutions and corresponding wrongful gain to the accused persons and related entities," the CBI said in a statement.

The federal anti-corruption probe agency had filed a case in this matter on the basis of complaints received from Union Bank of India (erstwhile Andhra Bank) and other public sector banks of the consortium. The first charge sheet in the case was filed on July 9 against four persons.

HT has reached out to Reliance group for a comment on Thursday's charge sheet. HTC

GST revenue crosses ₹2 lakh crore in September

Rajeev Jayaswal

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The gross Goods and Services Tax (GST) revenue in September crossed ₹2 lakh crore, registering a 14.7% year-on-year increase, government data released on Thursday showed.

Gross GST collections stood at ₹2,03,521 crore in September 2026, compared with ₹1,77,365 crore in September 2025. The collections reflect transactions undertaken in August. Net revenue after refunds surged 18.1% to ₹1,76,520 crore in September

NET REVENUE AFTER REFUNDS SURGED 18.1% TO ₹1,76,520 CR IN SEPTEMBER FROM ₹1,49,517 CR IN SEPTEMBER 2025

this year, from ₹1,49,517 crore in September 2025.

Experts attributed the stronger growth in net revenue partly to comparatively lower refunds. Refunds in September 2026 stood at ₹27,001 crore,

down 3% from ₹27,848 crore in the same month last year.

Experts also pointed to the sharp rise in import-linked GST revenue compared with collection from domestic business activity. Gross GST revenue from domestic business activities in September 2026 was ₹1,37,996 crore, up 10.1% from ₹1,25,334 crore in the same month of 2025. Import-linked gross revenue, meanwhile, surged 25.9% to ₹65,525 crore, from ₹52,031 crore a year earlier.

"One thing worth noting is that GST on imports is growing much faster than domestic col-

lections. The government deserves credit for the work done so far under the production linked incentive schemes, which have laid a solid base for domestic manufacturing. But the import numbers suggest it is time to recalibrate some of these schemes, so that the gains from this groundwork are fully realized," said Saurabh Agarwal, tax partner at EY India.

Pratik Jain, partner at Price Waterhouse & Co LLP, said: "GST collections remain strong, but it's interesting to see that domestic revenues grew 10.1% compared with almost 26%

growth in import GST. This suggests a meaningful part of the headline buoyancy is coming from imports. At the same time, cumulative refunds are up nearly 19%, which is a positive signal for businesses from a liquidity standpoint. Sustained domestic growth will be important to watch from here."

Cumulatively, gross GST collections in the first half of the current financial year (April-September 2026) jumped 11.6% to over ₹12.46 lakh crore, compared with ₹11.17 lakh crore in the corresponding period of 2025-26.

Manufacturing PMI rises to 7-month high

Shreya Khandelwal

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NEW DELHI: India's manufacturing sector regained momentum in September after weakening in the previous two months, with the headline HSCB India Manufacturing PMI rising to a seven-month high of 55.1 from 52.8 in August, according to data released by S&P Global on Thursday.

The index, which tracks factory conditions based on new orders, output, employment, suppliers' delivery times and stocks of purchases, remained above the 50 mark that separates expansion from contraction.

"The PMI rose to 55.1 in September, up from 52.8, as stronger domestic and overseas demand lifted sales and production," said Pranjud Bhandari, chief India economist at HSCB.

The improvement was driven by stronger demand for electronic, food, pharmaceutical and textile products. International orders also expanded

at a faster pace, with firms reporting increased demand from clients in Brazil, Europe, the UAE and the US.

The increase in domestic and overseas demand led to the sharpest expansion in manufacturing output in four months. New orders and output rose sharply for intermediate goods, while growth in orders for capital goods weakened from August.

Stronger demand also translated into increased hiring and purchasing. Employment growth resumed in September and was the fastest since May, after employment had contracted marginally in August.

Firms also increased purchases of materials both to support production and build inventories.

"Companies bought more materials and built up stocks to prepare for anticipated sales. Finished goods inventories recorded their second-largest increase in nearly 12 years, signalling a clear shift from leaner stock levels," Bhandari said.

Airtel Money IPO SET TO BE UK'S BIGGEST IN 5 YEARS

Bloomberg

feedback@livemint.com

Mobile payments firm Airtel Money is looking to raise \$529 million (\$700 million) for its shareholders in what could be London's biggest initial public offering in five years.

Existing investors including the Qatar Investment Authority and Mastercard Inc. are selling shares at a fixed price of £1.96, which would give Airtel Money, officially Airtel Mobile Commerce NV, a market value of £5.3 billion, according to terms of the deal seen by Bloomberg.

The valuation is lower than the \$8 billion to \$9 billion range reported previously, implying a discount to boost demand.

Airtel Money's offering may be the largest for London's stock market since IPO volumes plummeted after a pandemic-era boom. A successful debut would bring new impetus to the city's efforts to attract international listings.

Centre tightens sugar stock limits for dealers amid festive demand

Pallavi Singhal

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: With sugar prices having surged earlier this year, the Centre has further tightened stockholding limits for dealers as the new sugar season begins and India enters its peak festive season. The government said the move is to ensure adequate availability of sugar to consumers at reasonable prices during the festive season.

From October 15, sugar dealers will not be allowed to hold stocks for more than 15 days or keep more than 1,000 quintals at any location, a food ministry statement said on Thursday. The limits will remain in force until November 30.

The government, the release said, made an exception for Kolkata and its extended metropolitan areas and Assam, where dealers will be allowed to hold up to 2,000 quintals, citing the region's supply requirements



The new rules come into effect as the 2026-27 sugar season starts on October 1. MINT

and logistical constraints.

"The move comes even though retail sugar prices have already fallen 15% from their August peak, while ex-mill prices—the price at which sugar mills sell to bulk buyers before further distribution—have declined by about 28%," according to the ministry.

Ex mill prices are hovering between ₹4,500 - ₹4,800 per quintal. Retail prices stood at ₹56 per kg, up 20% year-on-year. The government expects

retail prices to ease further as the lower ex-mill prices work their way through the supply chain, it said.

The tighter stock limits are intended to prevent dealers from accumulating sugar for long periods, curb speculative trading and ensure that stocks move from mills to consumers without disruption, the ministry said.

Kolkata is a major sourcing and distribution point for sugar from Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra and Karnataka, supplying the eastern and northeastern regions. The higher limit for Kolkata and Assam has therefore been allowed to account for longer transportation distances and the logistical constraints of supplying the Northeast.

The new rules come into effect as the 2026-27 sugar season starts on October 1. The government has also advised sugar mills to begin crushing based on the agro-climatic conditions in their respective regions. PTI

PRICES HIKED FOR AVIATION FUEL, COMMERCIAL LPG

NEW DELHI: Aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices were raised by a steep ₹16 per litre from Thursday, while the price of commercial LPG was increased by ₹62.50 per 19-kg cylinder in step with firming international benchmarks, according to state-owned oil companies.

ATF prices were increased to ₹137 per litre from ₹121 for domestic airlines, according to the oil companies.

The latest revision comes after ATF prices were raised by ₹6.28 per litre, or 5.46%, in September, following a ₹5 per litre increase in August. ATF accounts for up to 40% of operating costs for airlines, making fuel prices a key cost factor for carriers. Alongside, commercial LPG rates were hiked by ₹62.59 per 19-kg cylinder.

Commercial LPG prices were raised by ₹9.50 per 19-kg cylinder in September, following two consecutive monthly reductions of ₹192 in August and ₹183.50 in July. PTI

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

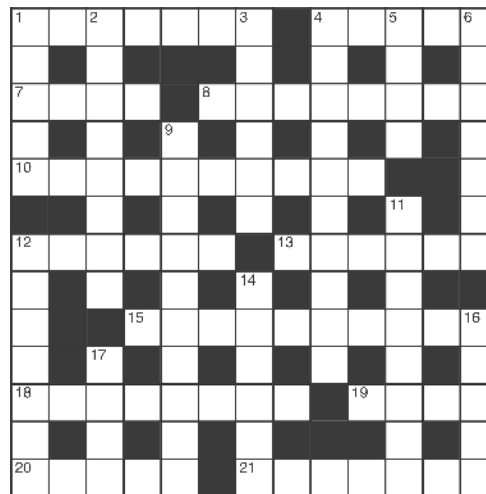
ACROSS

- Ice-covered railway station in the South of France (7)
- What one may get from a maid easy on the eye (5)
- Bloody wild orgy! (4)
- Depressed by loss of feathers? (8)
- Break away from the craft (5,5)
- Indisposed in bed when advertised to appear (6)
- Good grounds for holding sports (6)
- A tenor isn't disposed to use such a loud bass voice (10)
- Face up? Yet it might mean the opposite (4,4)
- Advanced in fast time (4)
- Angry about being long-limbed and slender (5)
- Changed speed or rested (7)

DOWN

- Sounds of relief of audible dimensions (5)
- It drains off the water when royal egg is cooked (8)
- One among the doctor's malingers (6)
- Pub is given praise for something new (10)
- It is made in a churn (4)
- On reflection, a must as a fruit (7)
- The rest of creation (7,3)
- Errs amid wayward lovers (8)
- Cry from a whale (7)
- A news broadcast with right to reply (6)
- How music may be distinguished? (5)
- Look what verse should do (4)

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QUICK CLUES

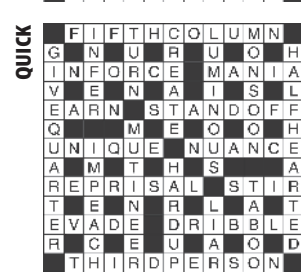
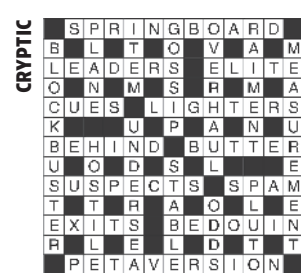
ACROSS

- Arrears of unfinished work (7)
- Sprang (5)
- Stare open-mouthed (4)
- In original condition (8)
- Cease trading (4,2,4)
- Quiver (6)
- Brawl in public (6)
- Aristocracy (5,5)
- Wild marjoram (8)
- Furtive glance (4)
- Slow learner (5)
- A crustacean (7)

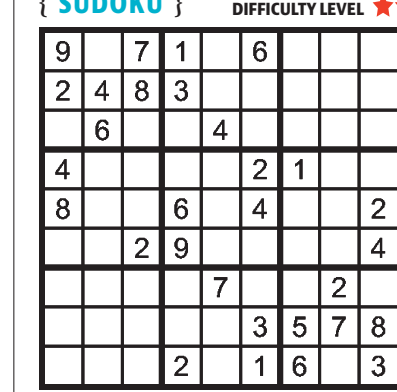
DOWN

- Sham (5)
- Taken prisoner (8)
- Obtrusively bright (6)
- Humiliation (4,2,4)
- Surrounded by (4)
- Curative treatment (7)
- Inappropriate (3,2,5)
- Contentious exchange of views (8)
- Slight footing (7)
- What follows as result (6)
- Thin candle (5)
- Kind of oven (4)

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17605)



{ SUDOKU } DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★★★★



Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.



GAME ZONE: Scan the QR code for more daily puzzles and brain teasers

{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE • HIGH • LOW

FRIDAY
Generally cloudy
sky with light rain
30°C | 21°C

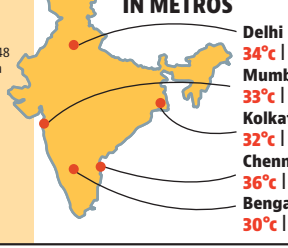
SATURDAY
Generally cloudy
sky with light rain
31°C | 21°C

SUNDAY
Generally cloudy
sky with light rain
31°C | 21°C

ALMANAC

Today is
2nd October 2026
• 19 Rabi Al-Akhar, 1448
• 07 Ashwina, Krishna
Paksha, 07
• Sarnvat, 2083
* Sunset: Friday
at 06:09 p.m.
Sunrise: Saturday
at 06:09 a.m.
Moonrise: Friday
at 11:00 p.m.

TEMPERATURE IN METROS



SPORT



J&K bowl out Rest of India for 237

SRINAGAR: Skipper Rishabh Pant paid for his impetuosity while a set Sarfaraz Khan played a loose shot as Rest of India were bowled out for 237 by Ranji champions J&K on Day 1 of the Irani Cup. Medium pacers Umar Nazir Mir (2/65), Sunil Kumar (3/36) and Lone Nassir (3/59) shared the bulk of spoils. At stumps, J&K were 21/2.

Ronaldo's Portugal future in doubt

COPENHAGEN: The international future of Cristiano Ronaldo hung in the balance after the 41-year-old walked out on the squad after learning that he would not start Portugal's game against Denmark on Thursday. Ronaldo announced late on Wednesday that he had left the team, shortly after a press conference in which coach Jorge Jesus confirmed the star would be left out of his starting line-up for a second consecutive Nations League game.

Vaidehee, Manish in Fenesta field

NEW DELHI: Two-time champion Vaidehee Chaudhari and defending men's champion Manish Sureshkumar will lead a highly competitive field in the 31st Fenesta Open National Tennis Championship to be held here October 5 to 17. Chaudhari will chase her third women's singles crown after winning in 2022 and 2024, while Sureshkumar returns to defend his 2025 title. Shruti Ahlawat adds to the women's challenge, having won her maiden ITF title at the same venue in May.

Nitesh trips at final hurdle, takes Greco Roman silver

The 97kg wrestler lost to Nakazato, but was India's first Greco Roman wrestler in the Asiad final in 64 years

Shantanu Srivastava
sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Back in 2015, when Nitesh Siwach was at home at Jagsi village in Haryana's Sonapat, he would hop on to his father's motorbike and set off before dawn daily to deliver milk. It wouldn't be a significant nugget until you know that Nitesh, then barely 12 and hardly strong enough to control the vehicle—never mind being under-age to ride—was still recovering from a knee surgery that would keep him out of sport for two years.

"We didn't have enough resources, so Nitesh decided to do his bit. Today, he is reaping the rewards for all the hard work he has done. He has had a tough life," Nitesh's father Anand said.

On Thursday, Nitesh became the first Indian since Ganpat Andalkar in 1962 Jakarta to reach an Asiad Greco Roman final. Nitesh though came up short against Japan's 2025 Asian Championships silver medalist Yuri Nakazato, losing the 97kg final 4-0.

The stockier Japanese put forth a defensive masterclass, not letting Nitesh attempt a single move. Nakazato was off the blocks with a pushout and a passivity point and went into the break 2-0 ahead. In the second period, the Japanese effected a two-point throw before resorting to his superior defence to keep the lead. Despite the loss, Nitesh's silver is a significant achievement considering it comes in the Greco Roman discipline where India has had limited inter-

Know Nitesh Siwach

Age	23
Sport	Wrestling 97 Kg GR
Training Base	SAI RC Sonapat, Haryana
Native	Panipat, Haryana

- ACHIEVEMENTS**
- 2022 U23 World Championships
 - 2023 U23 Asian Championships
 - 2024 U23 Asian Championships
 - 2025 Senior & U23 Asian Championships
 - 2026 Senior Asian Championships
 - 2026 ASIAN GAMES

Nitesh Siwach after winning silver in 97kg Greco Roman wrestling on Thursday.



national success.

Kabaddi to wrestling

Nitesh took up wrestling in 2012 after moving to the residential Pratap Sports School in Sonapat's Kharkhoda village. "He was initially into kabaddi but I wanted him to wrestle," Anand said. A wrestler in his youth, Anand competed in local dangals, but couldn't make it big. "You can say it was my

dream to wrestle for the country. My son has fulfilled it for me."

Anand co-owns a dairy in Panipat with younger brother Naveen and the duo exhausted all its savings and earnings to fuel Nitesh's career. "Raising a wrestler is not easy. We needed an average of ₹25,000-30,000 for his milk, supplements and other dietary needs. We happily killed all our hobbies and interests. No family outings,

no eating out, no new clothes, but we were happy to see him grow and work hard," Anand recalled.

"Things have been better with him getting into the national camp in 2021. We don't have to worry about his nutrition anymore but till the time the male wrestlers camped in Sonapat (they now train in SAI Lucknow), I would deliver milk for him daily," he added.

The injury to his left knee

needed a surgery that would cost over ₹50,000. Hard pressed for resources, Anand had to dig into his savings and borrow money to pay for his son's procedure.

"The dairy was still in its early years and we were not even breaking even. After the surgery, Nitesh decided to help me by delivering milk when he should have recuperated," he said.

To his credit, Nitesh bounced back from the injury quickly. "I was impressed with his height. He stood taller than most nine-year-olds when he came to me in 2012. As he grew older, his strength stood out. His arms in particular are very, very strong. Look at the way he threw the Mongolian wrestler in the semi-final," Om Prakash Dahiya, director of Pratap Sports School, said. Nitesh's run to the final showcased his relentless attacking style. Competing straight in the quarter-finals, he defeated Turkmenistan's Amanberdi Agamammedov 7-1 to set up a semi-final against Mongolia's Gankhuyag Ganbaatar.

A bronze medalist at the 2023 Hangzhou Asiad in 97kg freestyle category, Ganbaatar was out-classed by the Indian in the semi-final. Nitesh sped to a 9-0 win by technical superiority in a bout that barely lasted two minutes. Nitesh gained early advantage with a push-out before producing consecutive four-point throws to jump to 9-0, enough for the referee to blow the whistle and award him a win by technical superiority.

"It was a thoroughly dominating win. Nitesh didn't give his opponent a breather. He is a very sound wrestler who is unstoppable when his attacks work," India's Greco Roman coach Hargobind Singh told HT from Japan.

Nitesh has been in form, securing a silver at the Asian Championships in April in Bishkek before winning the Ulaanbaatar Ranking Series in June.

Sujeet, Aman must step up in attack, says coach Shako

Avishek Roy

avishek.roy@htlive.com

NEW DELHI: The drought of gold medals has pegged back India at the Asian Games. With the wrestlers set to take centre stage, India will pin hopes on Paris Olympics bronze medalist Aman Sehrawat and in-form Sujeet Kalkal to lead its challenge in men's freestyle.

For Sujeet and Aman, the Asian Games will be another opportunity to translate their form and international experience into a big title. Sujeet, competing in 65kg, has been one of India's most consistent wrestlers this year. The World No.2 is on a 15-bout winning streak and has won the U23 World Championships and Senior Asian Championships during that run. Indian men's freestyle coach Shako Bentinaidis believes the 65kg wrestler can be even more effective if he adopts a more attacking approach. "He is very good. He should be dominating, but he is not attacking too much. Given his talent, he should be dominating," Bentinaidis told HT.

The coach wants Sujeet to trust his attacking game rather than wait for his opponents to make mistakes. Sujeet recently competed in Russia, where Shako said he was very good. "In Russia he was beating everyone easily and we need that winning mentality, that kind of confidence to dominate bouts," he said. "Even if you give a few points, go for attack. Six or seven attacks in a bout is important, not just two or three."

It is a weight class in which Bajrang Punia won gold at the 2018 Asian Games, beating tough Japanese opponent Daichi Takatani in a high-quality, exciting final.

Sujeet's rise has been noticeable over the past year. At the World Championships last year, he lost (5-6) to Iran's Rahman Amouzadkhali, the Paris Olympics silver medalist who went on to win the world title. The performance gave Sujeet the belief that he could compete with the best.

However, it will be a tough field



Even if you give a few points, go for attack. Just don't wait. Six or seven attacks in a bout is important, not just two or three

SHAKO BENTINIDIS,
freestyle wrestling coach

in 65kg. Sujeet's biggest rival will be Japan's Olympic champion Kotaro Kiyooka, and the two could possibly clash in the semi-finals. Before that, he is expected to meet Iran's Abbas Ebrahimzadeh in the quarter-finals. In the lower half of the draw, Asian medallist Umidjon Jalolov of Uzbekistan and Ernazar Akmatalliev of Kyrgyzstan are also dangerous opponents.

Aman brings the experience of an Olympic medallist to the 57kg. The 21-year-old won bronze at the Paris Games and gold at the international ranking series in Budapest in July. He had been competing in the non-Olympic 61kg category, where he won silver at the Asian Championships earlier this year. He is now back in the 57kg Olympic weight class. "Aman is a bit slow and should be careful on defence. He needs to keep his rivals under pressure, keep moving. The moment he gives distance to opponent there is an attack," the coach said. "He is a very hard-working and disciplined wrestler. He has good counter-attacks. He is learning."

Aman will take on the winner of the bout between Olympic bronze medalist Gulomjon Abdullaev and Japan's Yamato Ogawa, the U20 Worlds. World champion Han Chong-song of North Korea, Kazakhstan's Nurdanat Aitanov, Iran's Ali Momeni and Mongolia's Davaabandi Munkh-Erdene are all strong opponents.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Culture isn't just what's trending.

It's the ideas changing how we live. The conversations shaping what we watch, read, wear, eat, create and care about. Every Saturday, HT Brunch goes beyond what's new to explore what's next—and why it matters. Because understanding culture is always more rewarding than simply following it.



EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



Abhishek the last action hero as India down Pak in a thriller

India were coasting at 3-0 before Pakistan rallied and set the stage for a nail-biting end. Malaysia up next

Sandip Sikdar

sandip.sikdar@htlive.com

NEW DELHI: With just 49 seconds left on the clock and the threat of a catastrophic collapse staring them in the face, Abhishek conjured a moment of pure brilliance which salvaged the Indian hockey team.

His desperate, blistering strike from inside the circle took a fateful deflection off Sufyan Khan and nestled into the back of the net, sealing a heart-pumping 4-3 victory for India over rivals Pakistan in an extraordinary Asian Games semi-final in Kakamigahara.

It was a contest that transcended tactical plans of the strategy board, a volatile emotional roller-coaster that swung from effortless elegance to sheer panic before ending in euphoria for the Harmanpreet Singh-led side.

The razor-thin escape propelled India into the gold medal showdown against Malaysia, who beat South Korea in the other semi-final, extending their formidable decade-long unbeaten run against Pakistan to 22 matches.

Yet beneath the celebrations and relief lies a wake-up call for chief coach Craig Fulton and his team. India had built a commanding, seemingly unassailable 3-0 cushion, only to watch their defensive composure evaporate into thin air as a spirited Pakistani side punished every shred of India's complacency.

"We started well but in the second half we made many mistakes, especially in our defence. They used those opportunities to score some quick goals. But we knew our structure and maintained it which also made us able to score the goal in the final minute. It is a good lesson for us to learn and perform better in the final," Harmanpreet told official broadcaster Sony after the match.

For the opening 30 minutes, the clash unfolded like a masterclass in attacking supremacy. India dictated the tempo from the opening whistle, suffocating Pakistan in their own half with ruthless efficiency. Fulton's men deployed a calculated aerial barrage, launching long balls directly into the 25-yard zone that systematically bypassed Pakistan's midfield and exposed their structural fragilities.

The relentless pressure paid dividends almost instantly. Just five minutes in, India earned their first breakthrough. Skipper Harmanpreet stepped up to the penalty corner (PC) battery and unleashed a thunderous drag-flick with unbridled power that whistled past Pakistani goalkeeper Ali Raza before the rushers could even react. With midfield engine



A last-gasp victory

INDIA					PAKISTAN				
	1st	2nd	3rd	4th					
INDIA	2	3	3	4	(HARMANPREET 5 PC, 13 PC, SUKHJEET 23, ABHISHEK 60)				
PAKISTAN	0	1	2	3	(ABU MAHMOOD 30 PC, HANNAN SHAHID 45, WAHEED RANA 49)				

STATS

INDIA 54% POSSESSION 46% PAKISTAN

7 PENALTY CORNERS 7

1 GREEN CARD 0

0 YELLOW CARD 1

Hardik Singh orchestrating proceedings, combining flair with a relentless work rate, India turned the screws. In the 13th minute, a clever decoy routine involving Jugraj Singh shifted the angle of the PC battery, allowing Harmanpreet to effortlessly slot in his second.

The dominance of the defending champions peaked in the 23rd minute with a goal carved out of pure magic. Shilanand Lakra produced the pass of the match from the baseline, a sublime reverse-stick feed that left the Pakistani backline paralysed.

Opportunistic forward Sukhjeet Singh needed no second invitation, stepping up for a simple tap-in to make it 3-0. On a milestone day for striker Mandeep Singh, celebrat-

ing his 300th international appearance, India looked poised to turn the contest into an easy win.

However, momentum in hockey is fickle. Pakistan, now coached by former India high performance director Herman Kruis, leveraged his knowledge of the Indian system to orchestrate a fightback.

The collapse began with indiscipline. Just three minutes before half-time, an error by Dilpreet Singh — failing to retreat behind the mandatory 5m mark — gifted Pakistan a PC. Skipper Abu Bakar Mahmood pounced on a poor trap, slipping the ball past India goalkeeper Mohith HS right at the stroke of the hooter.

When the teams returned from

the break, India's early aggression vanished, replaced by hesitation. Despite creating flashes of threat, including a reverse-stick drive from Abhishek that rattled the post, India lost control of the mid-field transition.

The turning point arrived in the dying seconds of the third quarter. With Dilpreet sitting out on an unnecessary green card, India's defence switched off completely. Ghazanfar Ali carved through the right flank with precision, finding an unmarked Hannan Shahid, who easily converted into an open goal after goalkeeper Suraj Karkera was drawn out of position.

Suddenly, a 3-0 walkover had changed into a tense 3-2 dogfight. Pakistan, thriving on turnover counterattacks, smelled blood. In the 49th minute, a glaring defensive lapse involving Harmanpreet

and Rajinder exposed India's backline. Hannan scooped the ball over the defenders to Waheed Ashraf Rana, who fired it into the open net to level the scores at 3-3.

The equaliser prompted Fulton into a desperate tactical shuffle, interchanging his goalkeepers to stabilise a panicky defence. The final 10 minutes descended into sheer chaos. Pakistan pressed relentlessly for a winner, earning a crucial PC with seven minutes to go. India survived only through the heroics of Amit Rohidas.

With the clock draining and the dread of a penalty shootout looming, India mounted one final attack. With 49 seconds remaining, Abhishek unleashed a speculative shot that deflected off Sufyan and flew into the net, sparking celebrations and sealing the dramatic 4-3 win.



India's Prince Noble and Manu Francis in action during the men's skiff at Asian Games.

REUTERS

Cousins tango to deliver India silver in skiff sailing

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MUMBAI: Growing up in the port city of Kochi, being by the water was almost second nature for Manu Francis and Prince Kurisinkal Noble. In late 2008, the first cousins who spent a lot of time playing together, thought of trying something new.

"We didn't know much about sailing. We were only looking for some entertainment," Francis said, chuckling. "From there, we're here now."

They're now Asian Games silver medalists. The Army duo finished behind China across the nine-race men's skiff event on Thursday to bag the country's first sailing medal at the Kaiyoh Yacht Harbor.

In their first Asian Games, Francis and Noble, whose mothers are sisters, came into the race's final day with bigger aspirations. Silver made them elated nonetheless.

"We were in the gold position yesterday (Wednesday), and that was our target," Francis told HT from Aichi. "Still, I am very happy and proud to have won a medal for India."

The conditions in Aichi tested them. Rain, low winds, high winds, and typhoon threats—each day posed different questions.

"The conditions were really challenging, and they handled it well," said their coach Sandeep Jain. "They felt some pressure of results since this was their first Asian Games. But I told them, this time won't come back, so don't worry about the outcome."

Outcomes were the last thing on their mind when Francis, 31, and Noble, 30, began sailing as kids. Competing in different classes initially, they decided to pair up in the 49er class in 2017.

"We felt like we had the correct weight for this class," said Francis. "We also know each other since childhood, so we

didn't have to worry about coordination or struggle with things like language."

Jain doesn't understand Malayalam, but trusts their coordination.

"Sometimes during training they talk in their language. I don't mind that because it's their way of communicating with each other," said Jain, a former sailor who competed with them in the same class and began coaching them at the Army Yachting Node in Mumbai since 2021.

Both Kerala men were recruited into the Army and shifted to Mumbai for training. Noble's father, a fisherman, died during the devastating 2018 Kerala floods.

"With the silver medal today, I have done more than what my father had wanted," Noble told PTI in Aichi. "After my father's death, my mother has been my support system."

"Our mothers are so happy," said Francis. "We generally go home only for 15-20 days a year. I miss my family a lot, but not once have they made us feel bad about being away."

Twice bronze medalists at the Asian Championships, the

duo had a three-month training block in Europe this year that "helped them a lot," according to Jain.

"The team has been preparing for months," said Capt. Jitendra Dixit, joint secretary general of the Yachting Association of India. "They have had some good international exposure, and the entire sailing contingent arrived in Japan almost two weeks ahead of the Games."

Those preparations resulted in another skiff medal on Thursday, with Harshita Tomar and Shital Verma taking bronze in the women's event.

For Francis and Noble, the silver gives them the belief to aim for bigger goals, starting with trying to qualify for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

"This gives huge confidence," said Francis. "We were competing with some good sailors and Olympians. If we keep improving, we are confident of qualification for the Olympics."

Ganesh takes bronze

India's Ganesh Thirumuru backed up his men's team archery gold on Wednesday with an individual bronze on Thursday. India's gold-gobbling compound exploits, however, could not translate into an individual champion.

After losing to South Korea's Kim Jong-ho in the semi-final, Ganesh bounced back brilliantly in the bronze medal match to defeat Vietnam's Dang Cong Duc 149-144.

Hours before that, Chikitha Taniparthi, riding high on her twin-gold effort a day before, lost a close quarter-final to Indonesia's eventual champion, Nurisa Dian Ashrifah, 144-143. Ganesh began the day promisingly, routing Chinese Taipei's Chen Chieh-Lun in the quarter-final 148-138. Jong-ho matched the Indian's high score in the semi-final, defeating Ganesh 148-144. The Indian had a 9 in every set, and against Jong-ho that proved costly.

medalstally				
COUNTRY	154	71	63	288
1 CHN	154	71	63	288
2 JPN	59	79	79	217
3 KOR	30	30	53	113
4 UZB	16	21	19	56
5 IRN	12	17	13	42
6 THA	12	11	15	38
7 BAH	11	5	5	21
8 INDIA	10	22	32	64
9 KAZ	9	19	36	64
10 PKR	7	8	9	24

Scan QR Code to follow HT's detailed coverage of the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya

GAMES CONNECTION



Ishan Kishan during his 46-ball 80* against Sri Lanka. PTI

KISHAN, BUMRAH HELP INDIA WIN

Ishan Kishan's 46-ball 80 on a tricky track laid the foundation as defending champions India hammered Sri Lanka by 124 runs in the men's cricket semi-final to set up a gold medal clash with Pakistan. Kishan and Vaibhav Sooryavanshi (38 off 21) took India to 169/7. In reply, Sri Lanka were 31/6 inside the powerplay before being bundled out for 45. Jasprit Bumrah struck twice in his opening over and was then joined by Axar Patel, who also claimed two wickets.

EALA LOSES IN SEMIS TO CHINA'S XIYU

Alex Eala of the Philippines hoped to take gold and earn an automatic berth in tennis at the LA Olympics. She got neither. Wang Xiyu of China defeated Eala 3-6, 6-3, 6-2 in the semi-finals to set up a final against fellow Chinese Zhang Shuai. Zhang defeated Yuliya Putintseva of Kazakhstan 6-4, 6-2. In addition to the loss, Eala could still face a \$10,000 fine for withdrawing from the China Open in Beijing a mandatory WTA 1000-level event.

SQUASH TEAMS WITH BRONZE

Defending champions India came up short against Malaysia in the men's semi-finals after the women met the same fate against Hong Kong ending the squash campaign with two bronze medals in team events. In the women's team semi-finals, Anahat Singh's opening-match loss proved crucial India went down against Hong Kong 1-2. India men were the stronger team on paper against Malaysia but were outplayed 1-2.

GOLF: PRANAVI 2ND AFTER SIZZLING 63

Pranavi Urs sank seven birdies in a bogey free 63 to be second at the halfway stage in the women's individual competition of the Asian Games golf on Thursday. At 11-under 129, the 23-year-old LET player was two shots off Singapore's leader, Shannon Tan. Diksha Dagar (72) and Aditi Ashok (725) struggled, but kept India third in team. In men, Saptak Talwar (68) and Yuvraj Sandhu (722) way back. India were fifth as a team.

Gold drought, missed chances in India's shooting campaign

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NEW DELHI: The end was emblematic of the entire campaign. Anish Bhanwala, India's lone entry in men's 25m pistol event, nailed only 11 of 15 by the end of the third series in the final, finishing seventh out of eight shooters, bringing the curtain down on an underwhelming run.

With 15 medals (3 gold, 8 silver, 4 bronze) out of India's overall tally of 65 (10, 22, 33) as of Thursday, shooting has been India's second best discipline in Japan, behind athletics' 24 (1-9-14).

Shooting and athletics are the only sports that have delivered a double-digit medal haul with Indian shooters finishing only behind leaders China.

With 27 medals (16, 7, 4), China again were the best shooting nation, a record they have held since 1978 Bangkok.

Viewed in isolation, India's numbers do not scream emergency, but it is pertinent to put the 15 medals in perspective, especially considering that underperformance in shooting has proved critical to India's below-par returns overall.

"We are often expected to deliver first day, first show, and frankly, we take pride in it. How shooters fare generally dictates how the entire contingent will fare," then rifle coach Suma Shirur had told this correspondent three years ago in Hangzhou where Indian shooters delivered their best ever result, winning 22 medals, including 7 gold. China won 29 shooting medals to finish on top but the gap seemed to be



India's Manu Bhaker (L) during the women's 25m pistol event. AP

narrowing. The early impetus given by shooters propelled India to a historic 106 medals. India will fall way short of that number this time.

The biggest disappointment has been the rifle and pistol teams, despite being formed after a rigorous process of trials where many youngsters pipped established names. That included 10m air pistol world champion Samrat Rana, world championships medalist Anjum Moudgil, Paris Olympics medalist Swapnil Kusale, and Hangzhou champions Sift Kaur Samra (50m 3 Positions) and Palak Gulia (10m air pistol).

Paris Olympics double medalist Manu Bhaker, competing in her third Asiad, failed to win a medal. Suruchi Singh, the break-

out star of Indian shooting, didn't medal in an individual event but only had a mixed team bronze with Kamaljeet Singh.

India had only five individual medals—two in men's 10m air rifle (Himanshu Singh's silver and Rudranksh Patil's bronze), one in women's 10m air rifle (Elavani Valarivan's silver), one in women's 25m pistol (Esha Singh), and the solitary gold from Neeru Dhandra in women's trap.

"It's not the performance we were expecting. We had high hopes, but it is what it is. We will go back to the drawing board and analyse the results," national coach Samareesh Jung said.

After the Paris Olympics, the shooters were divided into two groups, with one consisting of elite prospects. NRAI also intro-

duced a Moving Average Method that took into account performances from the previous year and said the latest five scores would be considered with the average of the best four forming the final score. The method had its detractors, but the shooters came around.

"I don't think selection policy is to be blamed here... The responsibility rests with shooters, coaches and the support staff," national rifle high-performance coach Manoj Kumar said. "Last time, we had Aishwary Pratap Singh Tomar, who had won medals in both his events (rifle 10m and 50m 3P) but he couldn't deliver this time. These things happen. The margins in rifle shooting are extremely small," he said.

That said, once again shooters' handling of nerves under pressure came under the scanner. In the women's 10m air rifle final for instance, Elaveni conceded her lead to finish second as her opponent shot a Games record to snatch gold.

"There is definitely the need for shooters to step up in the finals. The gold was there for the taking for both Elaveni and Rudranksh (in men's 10m air rifle final) and both lost to nerves," former rifle shooter Joydeep Karmakar said. Ronak Pandit, the 25m pistol national coach, agreed. "Look, all the coaches and athletes worked extremely hard. We did countless simulations and match scenarios, trained for every eventuality but you can't really dictate what a shooter does in the final. Esha could do it, but the more experienced ones couldn't," he said, referring Rishi Sarnobat and Manu Bhaker.

ODI WC 2027: India to play Pak on Oct 10

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NEW DELHI: Along expected lines, India and Pakistan have been paired in Group A for the 2027 ODI World Cup to be held in South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia from Oct 2 to Nov 21. Afghanistan, Australia, Zimbabwe and Qualifier A are the others in India's group.

Bangladesh, England, South Africa, Sri Lanka, New Zealand and Qualifier B are in Group B.

India play their opener against defending champions Australia on Oct 7 at Cape Town. Pakistan are up next on October 10 at the Wanderers, Johannesburg. Shubman Gill's men then play Afghanistan, Qualifier A and Zimbabwe on October 14, 17 and 24 respectively.

The scheduling is such that India and Pakistan can play thrice, subject to their qualifying for the Super 7s, the semis and the final.

ICC chair Jay Shah said: "The announcement of the schedule and opening of the ticket ballot are major milestones on the road to the ICC Men's Cricket World Cup 2027, bringing fans one step closer to a spectacular celebration of cricket across the three nations."

"The ICC remains committed to making its World Cup events accessible to as many fans as possible, with affordable ticket prices and options that bring families, young people and local communities closer to the action."

"South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia will provide an unforgettable stage for the world's best teams, combining a deep passion for cricket, extraordinary destinations and a renowned warmth of welcome. We look forward to welcoming fans from across the world and creating memories that will

GROUP A
INDIA, AUSTRALIA, PAKISTAN, AFGHANISTAN, ZIMBABWE, QUALIFIER A

GROUP B
SOUTH AFRICA, SRI LANKA, NEW ZEALAND, ENGLAND, BANGLADESH, QUALIFIER B

INDIA'S FIXTURES
vs Australia October 7
vs Pakistan October 10
vs Afghanistan October 14
vs Qualifier A October 17
vs Zimbabwe October 24

last long beyond the final."

The 2027 World Cup will have 12 teams in the main event. The tournament starts with a Super Series, with the second, third and fourth-placed teams from the ICC World Qualifier in Feb-Mar featuring in it.

After the conclusion of group league stages, the Super 7s will start from October 25 with the top three teams from each group and the better placed fourth team among the two groups qualifying for the next stage.

India have been classified as A1 with Australia as A2 and Pakistan being named A3. England is B4 while New Zealand, South Africa and Sri Lanka are B1, B2 and B3 respectively. If any of these teams fail to qualify, the team that qualifies will automatically receive that classification.

If India and Pakistan qualify for the Super 7s, they will once again meet on November 7 in Cape Town.

The final will be played at the Wanderers on November 21.